Rupa Gosvami

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The One Who Established the Lord's Desire

Narottama Dasa Thakura opens his “Prema-bhakti-chandrika” with a verse that says in a few words what matters most about Rupa Gosvami:

“When will Sri Rupa, who established on earth the cherished desire of Sri Chaitanya, himself give me a place at his feet?” (“Prema-bhakti-chandrika,” 1)

That desire was this: the Lord descended from Goloka to give living beings what the world had never received before — devotion to Himself, the exalted, radiant rasa. It was Rupa who revealed to the world this most intimate prema-bhakti, which belongs to Krishna alone. That is why he is called the one who carried out Sri Chaitanya's cherished design, and why his name stands first among the names of the six Gosvamis.

In the “Chaitanya-chandrodaya-nataka,” Kavi Karnapura places in the mouth of Sarvabhauma Bhattacharya a verse that lists Rupa's virtues one after another:

“Into Rupa — dear by his very nature, beloved by his very nature, by his very nature love, beautiful from birth, like the Lord Himself — the Lord, who is one in His form, placed the form of His own pastimes.” (“Chaitanya-chandrodaya-nataka,” 9.30)[1]

The word “rupa” here is both “form” and Rupa's name; the sense of the verse is that the Lord enabled Rupa to understand and describe His lilas. One biography explains the epithets of the verse thus: Rupa is the Lord's dear devotee, the object of His deep love and tenderness, wholly filled with prema, non-different from Him, like Him, His intimate associate and the image of His vilasa; and in him the Lord revealed the scripture of bhakti-rasa. In Krishna's eternal pastimes he is Rupa-manjari, of which more will be said at the end of this article.

Years of His Life

Two testimonies about the time of Rupa's appearance differ by four years. Bhaktivinoda Thakura, going through the papers (daptar) of a certain Vaishnava, found in them the dates of the six Gosvamis and in 1885 (1292 of the Bengali era) published them in the “Sajjana-toshani” (2nd year, p. 25), in a note entitled “Determining the Dates of the Six Gosvamis.” According to these records, Rupa appeared in 1411 of the Shaka era (1546 Samvat, 1489 CE) and remained on earth for seventy-five years — twenty-two at home and fifty-three in Vraja — and departed in 1486 Shaka (1621 Samvat, 1564 CE), on the twelfth day of the bright fortnight of the month of Shravana. The old manuscripts collected by the learned pandita of the shripata of Gopivallabhapura, Vishvambharananda Deva Gosvami, agree with this exactly.[2] According to our Vaishnava calendar, the day of Rupa Gosvami's departure is the Gaura-dvadashi of the month of Shridhara, which falls the morning after the Gaura-ekadashi that begins the Jhulana-yatra.[3]

Lineage

Rupa's family goes back to brahmanas who were kings of Karnata in South India. His genealogy of seven generations was preserved by Rupa's nephew Jiva Gosvami at the end of the “Laghu-vaishnava-toshani” and by Narahari Chakravarti in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (1.540–568); Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati sets it out as well in his “Anubhashya” (on CC, Adi 10.84).

The founder of the line was Sarvajna, a Yajurvedi brahmana of the Bharadvaja gotra and king of Karnata; as the most honoured of the brahmanas of that land he was called “Jagad-guru.” His son Aniruddha-deva, a master of the Vedas, had two wives and two sons: Rupeshvara, learned in the shastras, and Harihara, skilled in arms. After their father's death Harihara seized the kingdom from his brother, and Rupeshvara with his wife went east on eight horses and settled with his friend, King Shikhareshvara.[4]

Rupeshvara's son, Padmanabha-deva, a pandita and a devotee of Jagannatha, settled on the Ganga at Navahatta (Naihati); King Danujamardana honoured him, and there he worshipped the Deity of Purushottama. He had eighteen daughters[5] and five sons — Purushottama, Jagannatha, Narayana, Murari and the youngest, Mukunda-deva. Mukunda's son, the brahmana Kumara-deva, moved because of unrest in Naihati to Bakla-Chandradvipa and also set up a residence at Fatehabad (then in the district of Jessore), between Naihati and Bakla.[6] Chandradvipa was an ancient kingdom in the lands of present-day Bangladesh; it included Faridpur, Bakharganj and the southern parts of the Dacca and Pabna districts.

Kumara-deva was a pious brahmana. His wife, Rupa's mother, is named in “Our Teachers” as Sri Revati Devi, and the book says that they had five sons and one daughter.[7] Of the sons three became renowned: the eldest, Sanatana, the second, Rupa, and the youngest, Vallabha, or Anupama; the names of the others are unknown. Vallabha's only son was Jiva. Sanatana himself, in his commentary on the “Brihad-bhagavatamrita” (1.3), calls Rupa his dear servant and says of him: the son of Kumara, of the line of Jagad-guru, the renowned acharya of the brahmana families of Karnata. And the “Sanatanashtaka,” attributed to Rupa, calls Sanatana “the ornament of the line of brahmana kings of the blessed South.” Apart from this genealogy, no reliable information about the descendants of the family has been found.

Childhood and Names

After Kumara-deva's death, Sanatana, Rupa and Vallabha lived and studied in the house of their maternal uncle in the small village of Sakurma near the capital of Gauda. The elder brothers became brilliant scholars — in the words of one biography, “the crown jewels of the Gaudiya Vaishnava scholars”; they were taught philosophy and the shastras by Sarvabhauma Bhattacharya's brother Vidyavachaspati, who often stayed in Ramakeli.[8]

From early childhood, the same biography relates, all three were immersed in bhava-bhakti. Remembering Vrindavana, they played in the groves of tamala, keli-kadamba and tulasi around their home, named the ponds there Radha-kunda and Shyama-kunda, and always served Sri Madana-mohana. News reached them of Gaurasundara's wonderful pastimes in nearby Navadvipa, and they longed to see Him, but an inner voice told them to wait: soon they would have the darshana of the Saviour of the fallen. When word came that Sri Chaitanya had taken sannyasa and gone to Puri, Rupa and Sanatana fainted: they had never seen Him in Navadvipa, and now He was leaving Bengal for ever. Then a voice from the sky said, “Do not grieve: the merciful Sri Gauranga will soon come here,” and the brothers were consoled.

In this way the biographers stress that Rupa and Sanatana were not worldly people who came to faith in time, but eternal participants in Krishna's pastimes. In their earthly pastimes the Lord's associates conceal their transcendental nature, yet when they are near one another they cannot help revealing it; outwardly, however, the brothers behaved as sadhakas striving for perfection, to show people how one ought to act.

The names “Rupa” and “Sanatana” were given to the brothers by Sri Chaitanya Himself when they became His disciples; their earlier names are unknown, though some hold that Sanatana was called Amara and Rupa Santosha.[9] Vallabha too received the name “Anupama” from the Lord; Krishnadasa Kaviraja says of him: “Sri Rupa's brother was also a great Vaishnava. His name was Sri Vallabha, but he was better known as Anupama Mallik” (CC, Madhya 19.36). At court, however, the brothers were known by their titles — Sakara Mallik and Dabir Khas. Vrindavana Dasa Thakura confirms this as well, anticipating the story at the very beginning of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”:

“In the Antya-khanda Sri Gaurasundara reveals Himself to Dabir Khas. The two brothers, recognising the Supreme Lord, attain liberation and receive new names — Rupa and Sanatana.” (CB, Adi 1.171–172)

And in the story itself he says:

“At that time two fortunate souls came before Sri Chaitanya. The Lord cast His merciful glance on these two brothers, Sakara Mallik and Rupa.” (CB, Antya 9.238–239)

At the Court of Hussain Shah

The brothers' learning, intelligence and noble character drew the attention of the ruler of Gauda, Hussain Shah, and they came to hold the two highest posts at his court: Sanatana, “a Brihaspati in intellect,” and Rupa, unequalled in appearance and virtues, became the “two pillars” of his rule.[10] Sanatana received the title Sakara Mallik, Rupa that of Dabir Khas; the Sultan addresses Rupa by this title in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” as well. Rupa was the Sultan's personal adviser, his private secretary, and Sanatana his first minister.[11] “Our Teachers” adds that besides Sanskrit the brothers knew Arabic, Persian and Urdu and were acquainted with many influential and highly placed people in India. Yet service at court was only the outer side of their life: inwardly they always sought one thing alone — Krishna-prema.

According to the dictionary “Raja-vyavahara-kosha,” the word “dabir” means “one versed in reasoning” (yuktabhijno dabirah syat), and “khas” means “one's own,” that is, the sovereign's personal adviser. Others derive it from the Persian “dabir” (secretary, munshi) and the Arabic “khas” (personal): “personal secretary”; “Sakara Mallik” would then mean “chief secretary.” “Mallik” means “lord”: so the Muslims styled respected wealthy families close to the government. Such titles were mere ranks conferred by Hussain Shah and in no way mean that the brothers' ancestors had embraced Islam: Jiva calls their father “the best of the twice-born, the venerable Kumara” (dvija-varah shriman kumarah), and there is nothing non-Hindu in the names of their forefathers.

According to the “Anubhashya,” all three of Kumara's sons became Vaishnavas; for the sake of their service they left their home in Fatehabad and settled in Ramakeli, where Jiva was born, and for their service to the nawab all three received the title “Mallik.” The youngest, Vallabha, was the chief superintendent of the royal mint. The Shah rewarded the brothers generously, and they became very wealthy. Hindus not infrequently had to serve a Muslim ruler in those days, and among them were great devotees: Keshava Vasu Khan, the city magistrate and chief of the guard; Gopinatha Vasu and Purandara Khan, first ministers; the physician Mukunda Kaviraja; and Keshava Chhatri, the royal diplomat and adviser.

Ramakeli

The shripata of Ramakeli lies on the Ganga in the district of Malda (West Bengal), south of the present town of Malda.[12] Here in Ramakeli, which Sultan Barbak made the capital of Bengal in 1486, Rupa and Sanatana had their headquarters; many well-known devotees lived here as well, among them Sri

Nrisimha, the son of Advaita Acharya. Under the British, Ramakeli was a district centre. The place is also called Gupta-Vrindavana, “hidden Vrindavana.”

Rupa and Sanatana built large houses both in Ramakeli and in Fatehabad. Great scholars and brahmanas came to them from Bengal and beyond; many brahmanas from Karnata settled near their house, which stood on the Ganga near a small town that one biography calls Bhatravari; brahmana panditas from Navadvipa also came to serve the brothers.

The memorial places of Rupa and Sanatana are shown here to this day. First of all there is Tamatala: on a high platform grows a spreading tamala tree, and beside it four keli-kadambas, two on each side. According to tradition, it was under this tree, at midnight, that Rupa and Sanatana first met Mahaprabhu; it is said that the Lord sat here during the meeting and distributed love for Krishna, and a shrine with the prints of His feet now stands on the spot. There is also in Ramakeli the Deity of Madana-mohana, known to have been installed by Rupa and Sanatana; there is the Sanatana-kunda, and next to it are shown Radha-kunda, Shyama-kunda and eight kundas named after the sakhis headed by Lalita. Nearby is the Rupa-sagara, a large pond said to have been dug at Rupa's order; it survives to this day. Here too is the Baraduari, a huge stone audience hall (darbar) with twelve doors; in 1801, in the time of “Krent Sahib” (the reading of the name is uncertain), its domes were covered with gold leaf, and tradition says that here Dabir Khas held his office. And finally there is the ghat of Havaskhana: according to tradition, it was from here that Sanatana, having given the jailer seven thousand coins, left his confinement and crossed the Ganga by night.[13]

The Meeting under the Tamala

On the pretext of a journey from Nilachala to Vrindavana, Sri Chaitanya came to Gauda-mandala and spent five days in the house of Vachaspati in Vidyanagara (in Jahnu-dvipa, near Kola-dvipa); from there He went to Kuliya and then, by way of Malda, to Ramakeli.[14] When the rumour spread that from Kuliya the Lord would go to Vrindavana, Nrisimhananda Brahmachari began in meditation to pave for Him a road of precious stones from Kuliya to Vrindavana and to spread over it an unbroken bed of flowers. But when the road reached Kanai-natashala near Gauda, his mind was disturbed and the meditation broke off. “This time,” said Nrisimhananda, “the Lord will go only as far as Kanai-natashala, not to Vrindavana.” And so it happened.

Countless crowds followed the Lord, and so He came to Ramakeli on the Ganga, near Gauda. Even the badshah Hussain Shah was amazed at His influence and grew alarmed, suspecting Him of a political aim. At first the king was reassured by the devotee Keshava Chhatri, his adviser: this was only a mendicant sannyasi on pilgrimage with few people about Him, and there was nothing to fear; but the king did not believe him, for thousands were following the Lord. At the same time Keshava secretly sent the Lord advice to leave, since the king could not be trusted.[15]

Then the Sultan called Dabir Khas in private and asked him about the Lord. Krishnadasa Kaviraja Gosvami records Rupa's answer:

“‘The person you have taken for a great prophet is the Supreme Lord Himself. How great is your fortune, that the Lord who granted you your power has Himself descended here, in your country. He always wishes you only good and grants success to your words. His blessings will make you successful in every undertaking. Why do you ask me? Ask your own heart! You are a king, a representative of God. Your heart already knows about Sri Chaitanya. The voice of your heart will itself confirm the truth of this knowledge.’ The king replied, ‘Listen, my heart tells me that Sri Chaitanya is the Supreme Lord Himself. Of this there is no doubt!’” (CC, Madhya 1.176–180)

So diplomatically did Rupa glorify the Lord that the Shah was reassured.

Returning home, Dabir Khas took counsel with his elder brother. Both wished to see the Lord for themselves; concealing their royal dress, they slipped out of the palace and late at night came first to Nityananda and Haridasa Thakura, who told the Lord of their arrival.[16] The brothers took straws between their teeth and tied cloth about their necks as a sign of humility, fell at the Lord's feet like rods and with tears began to entreat Him. The Lord bade them rise and blessed them, and they, with folded palms, glorified Sri Krishna Chaitanya, the merciful Saviour of the fallen, and said of themselves: by birth, occupation and association we are among the lowest of men; You have come to deliver the fallen — know then that there is no one in the world more sinful than we. You delivered Jagai and Madhai, but they were brahmanas from holy Navadvipa, they did not serve low people, and they were saved by the Name, uttered even in abuse;

“whereas we are millions of times more sinful and lower than Jagai and Madhai. Our association with meat-eaters has made us like them, mlechchhas, and our deeds no longer differ from theirs. Our connection with them has become so strong that we ourselves have become enemies of the cows and of the whole brahminical culture. Our deeds have bound us hand and foot so tightly that we have been cast into the foul abyss of sense enjoyment. No one in the whole universe can save us but You, for You are the Saviour of the most fallen.” (CC, Madhya 1.196–199)

If You save us, they said, the whole universe will learn the greatness of Your mercy. We grieve over our unworthiness, but Your divine qualities irresistibly attract us, and our hearts burn with an unattainable desire — as a dwarf dreams of reaching the moon (CC, Madhya 1.204–205).

These words are an expression of great Vaishnava humility (dainya), not an admission of any real fall. Rupa and Sanatana are the Lord's eternal associates, who stand above varnashrama, and to take their self-abasement literally, regarding them as men of low birth, is an offence.

The Lord answered:

“‘Listen, Dabir Khas. You and your brother are both My servants from long ago. From now on your names are Rupa and Sanatana. Give up your humility now, for it breaks My heart. You sent Me several humble letters. From these letters I gained an understanding of your life. From your letters I understood your hearts. And to instruct you, I constantly quoted one verse: “A married woman attracted to another man only appears to be diligent in her household duties, while in her heart she anticipates the sweetness of a new meeting with her beloved.” I came to Bengal only to see the two of you. I had no other purpose. No one understands why I came to this village, Ramakeli. No one knows My intentions. It is very good that you both have come to Me. Now go home and do not worry about anything. You are both My servants birth after birth. Very soon Sri Krishna will certainly set you free.’” (CC, Madhya 1.207–215)

The verse about the woman who, while doing her household duties, thinks in her heart of her beloved was the Lord's instruction to the brothers in reply to their letters: while serving at court, think of Krishna with all your heart. Then He lovingly placed His hands on their heads, and they placed His feet on their heads and, having received the mercy of His feet, began to look for a way to leave their service. Wishing to show that a conditioned soul is delivered by the mercy of devotees, the Lord told His associates to bless the brothers. Nityananda, Haridasa, Srivasa, Gadadhara Pandita, Mukunda, Jagadananda, Murari, Vakreshvara and others were there; at the Lord's bidding Rupa and Sanatana touched their feet, and the devotees, joyfully calling “Hari! Hari!”, congratulated them on their great good fortune.

At that time the youngest brother, Vallabha, also received the Lord's mercy: Mahaprabhu met him for the first time when He came to Ramakeli and gave him the name “Anupama.” According to one biography, this meeting took place in 1513. Haridasa Thakura, who accompanied the Lord on this

interrupted journey to Vrindavana, also met Rupa and Sanatana here for the first time, and from then on they knew one another's virtues well. And little Jiva, who was then living with his uncles in Ramakeli, secretly saw Mahaprabhu's feet, as the “Bhakti-ratnakara” relates.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati explains in his “Anubhashya” (on CC, Madhya 1.208): Mahaprabhu showed His mercy to Dabir Khas and Sakara Mallik by giving them the spiritual names Rupa and Sanatana. The giving of a name (nama-karana) is a samskara of the lowest stage, yet whoever disregards the mercy shown in a spiritual name will not attain krishna-bhakti and remains intoxicated with worldly position; the prakrita-sahajiyas, who wear neither the marks of a Vaishnava nor a name received from the guru, are not Gaudiya Vaishnavas.

Before leaving, the brothers gave the Lord their advice:

“‘O Lord! Although the ruler of Bengal is respectful towards You, You should leave this place as soon as possible. He is a Muslim and should not be trusted. Nor is it right that such a crowd follows You. You are going to Vrindavana, and thousands of people are following You. That is not fitting for a pilgrim.’” (CC, Madhya 1.222–224)

Vrindavana is a place of simplicity, not of pomp; the Lord's work here was done, and it was better for Him to leave before misfortune came. Having blessed the brothers, the Lord left Ramakeli. In the morning He came to Kanai-natashala, where He saw many pictures of Krishna's pastimes, and at night He pondered Sanatana's advice and decided: with such a crowd I shall spoil the simplicity of Vrindavana — I shall go there alone or with one companion. And having gone only as far as Kanai-natashala, He turned back to Puri.[17]

The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” tells of the brothers' meeting with the Lord differently — as an event in Nilachala, where Rupa and Sanatana came after giving up their worldly affairs. The Lord told Sakara Mallik and Dabir Khas to beg for prema-bhakti at the feet of Advaita Acharya, and Advaita blessed them; then He told them to go to Mathura and give the sweetness of bhakti to the people of the West, and said:

“I shall come to Mathura later. Prepare a secluded place for Me.” Then the Lord changed the name of Sakara Mallik to Sanatana. (CB, Antya 9.272–273)

Sakara Mallik, in Vrindavana Dasa's words, became “Sanatana the avadhuta”; the note on this passage calls such a giving of a name the “third samskara.”[18]

Already from the meeting in Ramakeli it is clear that Mahaprabhu intended to teach the world through Rupa and Sanatana.

Leaving Royal Service

Soon a strong spirit of renunciation awoke in the brothers. To be freed from service the sooner and join the Lord, they paid two brahmanas handsomely to perform a purashcharana of the Krishna mantra on their behalf.[19] Rupa left his post and carried a great deal of wealth from Ramakeli by boat to his house in Fatehabad. There he divided it: half he gave to brahmanas and Vaishnavas, a quarter for the maintenance of his relatives, and the remaining quarter he entrusted to reliable brahmanas against future misfortune. For Sanatana he left ten thousand coins in Gauda.[20]

Meanwhile Sanatana, pleading illness, stopped attending court and studied the “Bhagavatam” with a group of Sanskrit scholars. The Shah first sent him a physician, then, learning the truth, came himself, and when Sanatana flatly refused to return to his duties, had him imprisoned and set off on a campaign against Orissa.

Hearing that the Lord had returned from Gauda to Nilachala and would soon go to Vrindavana, Rupa sent two messengers to Puri to find out when Mahaprabhu would set out by the forest road through Jharikhanda; the messengers returned to Gauda with news of His journey. Rupa wrote to Sanatana that the Lord had gone to Vrindavana and that he himself was following Him with his younger brother Anupama, and begged his brother to free himself quickly by any means and come to the Lord's feet.[21] Bhaktivinoda Thakura ("Amrita-pravaha-bhashya," 2.20.3) reports that the letter consisted of a single Sanskrit verse:

"Where is Mathura, the city of the lord of the Yadavas? Where is Uttara-Koshala of the lord of the Raghus? Remembering this, steady your mind: this world is not eternal."

Sanatana understood the hidden meaning — the Lord had gone to Mathura — and rejoiced. He bribed the jailer with seven thousand coins from the money Rupa had left, escaped from confinement and set out after his brothers.[22]

Prayaga

Rupa and Anupama came to Prayaga and learned with great joy that the Lord was there. When He went for darshana of Bindu-madhava, crowds ran after Him, and the brothers kept their distance; but when the Lord came to take His meal in the house of a South Indian brahmana, they came there and, holding straws between their teeth, prostrated themselves at His feet, rising and falling down again and again and reciting verses of praise and humility.

"Sri Chaitanya was overjoyed to see Sri Rupa and asked him to rise and come to Him. 'It is impossible to describe Krishna's mercy!' He said. 'By His mercy you have both been pulled out of the well of worldly pleasures.' 'One who is brilliantly educated and knows all the Vedas, but has not dedicated himself to unalloyed service to Me, should not be considered My devotee. On the other hand, a person, even if born in a family of dog-eaters, may be My dear devotee if he is not attracted by the fruits of karma and jnana. All should show respect to such a person, and whatever he offers should be accepted with respect. Such a devotee of Mine is worthy of the same worship that is offered to Me.' Reciting this verse, He embraced both brothers and then mercifully touched their heads with His foot." (CC, Madhya 19.48–51)

The verse the Lord recited is from the "Itihasa-samuchchaya."

Having received this mercy, Rupa — the best of transcendental poets (aprakrita-kavi-shreshtha) — together with his younger brother, with folded palms, bowed to the Lord with a verse of his own:

"O Krishna, I offer You my obeisances. Your name is Sri Krishna Chaitanya. The colour of Your body is golden yellow. You embody divine compassion. You are engaged in bestowing love for Krishna. And at the same time You are Krishna Himself! I offer You my humble obeisances." (CC, Madhya 19.53)

This obeisance from Rupa's lips was accepted by the whole Rupanuga-sampradaya as its ever-revered prayer to Sri Gaura. In it are named at once the name, form, quality, associates and pastimes of Gaurasundara: the name — "Sri Krishna Chaitanya"; the form — golden radiance; the quality — supreme magnanimity; the associates — the parshadas who belong to Krishna Himself (Svarupa, Rupa, Ramananda Raya and others, and with them the sampradaya that follows them); the pastime — the bestowal of krishna-prema. Thus the whole of gaura-tattva is contained in a single verse.

The Lord seated Rupa beside Him and asked about Sanatana. "He is now the king's prisoner," Rupa answered, "and will be freed only if You release him." "Sanatana's bonds are already broken," said the Lord; "he will soon come to Me." That day, at the brahmana's invitation, the brothers stayed in his house and received the remnants of the Lord's meal. The Lord took up residence at Triveni, the

confluence of the Ganga and the Yamuna, and Rupa and Anupama settled nearby.[23]

Vallabha Bhatta

The learned Vallabha Bhatta was living at that time in the village of Arail (Adail), about a mile from the confluence, on the other bank of the Yamuna. The seat (baithak) of Vallabhacharya is shown today about a krosha from present-day Arail, at a place called Deorah: it is no longer in the village itself but in the Arail pargana, and according to local tradition Sri Chaitanya came there. The owner of this baithak is Muralidhara Lalji, the owner of the well-known Gopalji temple in Kashi. The very name “Deorah” is a corruption of “deva-rishi”: according to the books of the Vallabha sampradaya, gods and rishis lived there for the sake of Vallabhacharya's company.

Hearing of the Lord's great influence and that He was at Triveni, Vallabha Bhatta hastened to Him and prostrated himself at His feet; the Lord embraced him and began to speak of Krishna. In this conversation His prema welled up, but, regarding Vallabha as an outsider (bahiranga), the Lord concealed His feeling, and Vallabha could only marvel at what he saw.[24] Rupa and Anupama were at the Lord's feet, and He introduced His most beloved devotees to Vallabha. Out of humility the brothers bowed to the Bhatta from a distance; and when he moved towards them to embrace them, they — seeking no honour and honouring others (amani-manada) — drew back, calling themselves unworthy: “We are low and untouchable; do not defile yourself,” and sat at a distance.

Pleased with their humility, the Lord, after showing Vallabha — a man of high family proud of his learning — outward worldly respect, decided to test his way of thinking:

“‘Do not touch him, for he belongs to the lowest caste, whereas you are a brahmana of an ancient and noble family, of profound learning and experienced in performing many Vedic rites.’ Hearing that their lips were constantly repeating the names of Krishna, Vallabha Bhatta understood Sri Chaitanya's hints and said, ‘The constant chanting of Krishna's names makes them dance. Therefore they cannot be low; on the contrary, they are most exalted.’” (CC, Madhya 19.69–71)

And Vallabha quoted a verse of the “Srimad-Bhagavatam” (3.33.7): “Glory and praise to those whose tongue repeats Your holy name! They are to be honoured even if they were born in families of dog-eaters…” (CC, Madhya 19.72)

Vallabha passed the test: there was in him no offence of seeing a Vaishnava as an ordinary mortal; he had faith in the name of Hari and was not merely a smarta brahmana bound by rituals; the Vaishnava nature had largely awakened in him, and so his invitation could be accepted. The measure here is not birth or learning but one's attitude towards the devotee and faith in the holy name. Seeing that an understanding of the devotee's superiority had taken root in Vallabha's heart, the Lord praised him and, condemning the views of the ritualistic smartas, quoted verses of the “Hari-bhakti-sudhodaya” (3.11–12):

“In the fire of the sacred practice of loving service to God, all the consequences of past sins, such as low birth, are burned away. Even one born in a family of dog-eaters may win the approval of great theologians by the power of his sincere service to God. Whereas even a knower of the Vedas is not recognised as such if he is an atheist.” “If someone has no loving devotion to the Supreme Lord, all his virtues, such as high birth, knowledge of the scriptures, repetition of Vedic mantras, as well as austerity and strict observance of vows, are like ornaments on a corpse. Such ornaments can bring only false joy to the unenlightened.” (CC, Madhya 19.74–75)

Vallabha invited the Lord and His companions to his home and at the Triveni ghat seated them in a boat; with the Lord were Rupa, Anupama, Balabhadra Bhattacharya and Krishnadasa the Rajput. As the boat was crossing the Yamuna, love seized Mahaprabhu at the sight of its dark waters, and He began to

dance, frightening everyone:

“With a loud cry He leapt into the waters of the Yamuna. At this sight everyone was seized with fear and trembling. In great haste the devotees pulled Him back into the boat, but, finding Himself there again, He began to dance.” (CC, Madhya 19.79–80)

Having brought the Lord to his home, Vallabha washed His feet with his own hands, and the whole family placed that water on their heads; he dressed the Lord in a new kaupina and upper cloth and performed a “great puja” with incense, flowers, fragrances and lamps. Then with great care he fed the Lord many dishes and gave the remnants of His meal to Rupa and Krishnadasa the Rajput;[25] after the meal he offered Him spices, laid Him down to rest and himself began to massage His feet, and the Lord told him to go and eat too.

There came the mahabhagavata Raghupati Upadhyaya from Tirhut,[26] a disciple of Madhavendra Puri, and the Lord spoke with him at length about rasa. To the Lord's questions about the highest form, the highest abode, the age and the rasa, he answered thus:

“Shyamasundara is the highest form of God, the city of Mathura is the highest divine abode, the beginning of blossoming youth is the highest time of life, and nothing can compare with the sweetness of the rasa of conjugal love.” (“Padyavali,” 82; CC, Madhya 19.106)

The Lord embraced him. All the people of the village, on seeing Mahaprabhu, became devotees of Krishna, and Vallabha took the Lord back to Prayaga by boat.

Ten Days at Dashashvamedha

Wary of the crowds at Triveni, the Lord went to the Dashashvamedha ghat. In all He remained in Prayaga only ten days, staying there unrecognised.

“Wary of the great gathering of people, Sri Chaitanya went to the Dashashvamedha ghat. There He instructed Sri Rupa Gosvami, investing him with His special power. There He revealed to Sri Rupa the highest truths about Krishna, teaching him the highest conclusions of the science of bhakti and rasa in full accord with the ‘Srimad-Bhagavatam.’ He imparted to him all the confidential conclusions He had earlier heard from Ramananda Raya. By His mercy Sri Rupa was able to grasp them perfectly.” (CC, Madhya 19.114–116)[27]

Having invested His shakti in the heart of this most worthy disciple, the Lord made him mature and awakened all truths in his heart, so that Rupa became skilled in expounding them. These teachings are called the “Sri-rupa-shiksha.” Kavi Karnapura says in the “Chaitanya-chandrodaya-nataka”:

“When in the course of time the accounts of the pastimes of Vrindavana had vanished from people's memory, the Lord, to glorify them again in all their fullness, bathed Rupa and Sanatana in the nectar of His mercy in that same place.” (“Chaitanya-chandrodaya-nataka,” 9.38)[28]

And elsewhere in the same drama (9.29): Rupa, long bound fast by Gaura's beloved qualities and free of attachment to home, revealed his form like the highest rasa embodied, and in Prayaga the Lord bestowed His mercy on him and his younger brother Anupama with loving talks and tight embraces. As one biography explains, Rupa, attached from the very beginning to the qualities of his ishtadeva Gaurasundara, only played the role of household life and displayed the lila of liberation from it: an eternal associate of the Lord is not bound by home.

Rupa himself recorded this in the opening verse of the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” (1.1.2), which Krishnadasa Kaviraja quotes:

“I am the lowest of men and have no knowledge, yet the Lord has mercifully inspired me to write books on bhakti. Therefore I humbly bow down at the lotus feet of the Supreme Lord Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, who has given me the ability to do this.” (CC, Madhya 19.134)

“Lowest,” “wretched” are words of humility; and the inspiration in the heart of which Rupa speaks is the shakti invested by the Lord: He instructed Rupa not with words alone but revealed all truths within him. This was not the training of a novice: the Lord was giving shiksha to His eternal associate in order to reveal bhakti-rasa to the world through him. According to one biography, in Prayaga Mahaprabhu directly told Rupa to write the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu.”

For ten days in succession, having invested His shakti in Rupa, the Lord set forth to him in concise form, like sutras, the characteristics of bhakti-rasa. Giving him the plan of a future book on rasa, He described the characteristics of the various rasas, showed how to taste the bottomless ocean of rasa and explained how difficult it is to attain devotion to Krishna. Through Rupa, Mahaprabhu revealed to the world Krishna's pastimes in Vrindavana and the path to Krishna in Vrindavana. Krishnadasa Kaviraja testifies:

“By the mercy of Sanatana Gosvami I learned the truths of bhakti. And by the mercy of Sri Rupa Gosvami I tasted the ambrosia of loving relationships with Sri Krishna.” (CC, Adi 5.203)

And again:

“Through Haridasa Thakura He revealed the greatness of the holy names of Krishna. And through Sanatana Gosvami He disclosed the essence of sacred devotion to God. Through Sri Rupa Gosvami He revealed the taste of transcendental loving relationships with Krishna in Vrindavana. Who is able to describe all the confidential deeds of Sri Chaitanya?” (CC, Antya 5.86–87)

Kaviraja begins the nineteenth chapter of the Madhya-lila, which tells of the teachings given to Rupa, thus:

“Wishing to revive the memory and knowledge of Sri Krishna's pastimes in Vrindavana, lost over time, Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu invested Sri Rupa with His divine power and empowered him to do so, just as earlier He had given Brahma the power to create all the worlds of this universe.” (CC, Madhya 19.1)

A Drop of the Ocean

Krishnadasa Kaviraja sets out the teachings of Prayaga in the nineteenth chapter of the Madhya-lila; here we shall only trace their course. The Lord began thus:

“‘Sri Rupa! I shall explain to you the science of bhakti-rasa briefly, for no one can describe it in its fullness. The ocean of bhakti-rasa is boundless; it simply cannot be measured. I shall help you taste just one drop of it, so that you can understand its essence.’” (CC, Madhya 19.136–137)

Countless living beings, said the Lord, wander through eight million four hundred thousand species of life as their karma dictates. The shrutis compare the soul to a particle of the tip of a hair divided into a hundred parts and then again into many hundreds (“Mundaka Upanishad” 3.1.9: “this atma is minute”). The prayers of the personified Vedas in the “Bhagavatam” (10.87.30) say: “If the countless embodied souls were all-pervading, they would not be subject to You, O Unchanging One; but they are minute, and therefore subject. You are their inseparable cause and ruler; and whoever fancies You their equal does not know, for his view is corrupt.” Souls come from the Lord like sparks from a fire, and He is their cause, ruler and inner witness; the doctrine of the identity of the soul and God is the fruit of a false teaching.

Souls are eternally liberated or eternally conditioned. The conditioned are immobile (trees and plants) or mobile; the mobile are beasts and birds, creatures of the waters and of the land, and among the creatures

of the land human beings are very few. If from among humans one excludes the barbarian mlechchhas, the Pulindas, the Buddhists and the Shabaras, there remain the followers of the Vedas; some of them follow dharma, others do not; of those who follow dharma many are devoted to rituals, others to knowledge, and of ten million knowers only one is truly liberated, that is, free of worldly understanding.[29] Of all the liberated, one who has taken up the service of Krishna with faith is a krishna-bhakta: he has no desires other than service. All others, up to the liberated, are bound by the thirst for enjoyment (bhukti) or liberation (mukti): the pious and the ritualists seek enjoyment, the knowers liberation, others the siddhis of yoga. As long as these three desires are in the heart, there is no peace; only the selfless devotee of Krishna attains the highest peace. So Parikshit says to Shukadeva ("Bhagavatam" 6.14.4–5): "Of the pious only a few seek liberation, O best of the twice-born; of thousands who seek it hardly one is liberated and attains perfection; and among millions of the liberated and perfected a peaceful devotee of Narayana is the greatest rarity, O great sage."

Then the Lord told Rupa about the creeper of bhakti:

"Wandering throughout the universe, only immensely fortunate souls, by the mercy of Guru and Krishna, receive the rare opportunity to obtain the seed of loving service to God. <…> Such a fortunate soul should, like a gardener, carefully plant this seed in his heart. And it should be watered by hearing and chanting." (CC, Madhya 19.151–152)

The creeper grows, pierces the shell of the universe, passes the waters of the Viraja and the effulgence of Brahma-loka, reaches the spiritual sky and rises to Goloka-Vrindavana, where it climbs the wish-fulfilling tree of Krishna's feet and there bears the fruit of prema. This creeper blossoms not in this world, nor even in Vaikuntha, but only in Vrindavana, at Krishna's feet. But watering alone is not enough:

"But if an offence against a Vaishnava is committed, it is like a mad elephant that uproots or tramples this sprout, and it dies and withers. <…> The devotee, like a careful gardener, must fence this sprout of devotion on all sides, protecting it from the mad elephant of offences." (CC, Madhya 19.156–157)

The leaves of the creeper can also be withered by scorching heat; but at the unripe stage the greatest obstacle on the path of sadhana is offence against a Vaishnava. Therefore the wise gardener puts up a fence — he hears hari-katha in the company of sadhus, and this destroys the anarthas. The verse about the mad elephant, says one biography, should always be remembered by one who seeks pure bhakti.

The second danger is the weeds that grow beside the creeper: the thirst for enjoyment and liberation, forbidden acts, hypocrisy and fault-finding, a tendency to violence against living beings, the thirst for gain, the hope of worldly honour and position. It is they that are fed by offences in hearing and chanting, while the main stem withers; therefore they must be cut from the very beginning. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati ("Anubhashya" on CC, Madhya 19.160–161) lists what bad association leads to: the thirst for enjoyment, liberation and siddhis, deceit, illicit connection with women, the sham bhakti of the sahajiyas, the five abodes of Kali — gambling, intoxication, illicit sex, slaughter and the hoarding of gold — regarding Vaishnavas as a caste, dishonest collection of money, ostentatious seclusion for the sake of fame, concessions to non-devotees, and "discipleship" under a caste "guru" hostile to Vishnu and the Vaishnavas. Pull up the weeds at once, and the creeper will reach Goloka; otherwise there is the round of births in higher and lower worlds. Then the main stem will reach Vrindavana and yield the ripe fruit of prema, and the gardener, holding on to the creeper, will approach the tree of Krishna's feet and, serving them, will taste in the highest happiness the juice of that fruit.

Prema is the highest goal of the soul; the four aims of life — dharma, artha, kama and moksha — are like a blade of grass before it. It is born not from a semblance of bhakti (bhaktyabhasa) but only from pure bhakti. The mark of pure bhakti is that there is no desire other than the eternal satisfaction of the

senses of Krishna, Adhokshaja; no worship of His other aspects — Brahman, Paramatma — in place of Krishna; no coverings of impersonal knowledge, of the obligatory and occasional rites of the smritis (these are not service), of the thirst for the siddhis of hatha- and raja-yoga, of bodily and mental renunciation for its own sake — austerities and vows. Free of all this, accepting in life only what is favourable to bhakti, to serve Krishna with all the senses — this is shuddha-bhakti. The "Narada-pancharatra," which Rupa will quote at the beginning of the "Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu," defines it: "Service to Hrishikesha, the Lord of the senses, with one's senses — free of all designations (upadhis) and pure through devotion to Him alone — is called bhakti." Service to Hrishikesha with all the senses is the essential characteristic of bhakti (svarupa-lakshana), and its two marginal characteristics (tatastha) are freedom from upadhis and orientation towards Krishna alone together with its own purity.

Bhakti tinged by the three gunas is saguna; but beyond it there is nirguna-bhakti, pure bhakti. Its mark is given in the "Bhagavatam" (3.29.11–14): as soon as one hears of the Lord's qualities, the mind flows to Him unceasingly, as the Ganga flows to the ocean; such bhakti is causeless and unobstructed; the devotees do not accept, even when offered, salokya, sarshti, samipya, sarupya or oneness with the Lord without service; this is the supreme (atyantika) bhakti-yoga, by which the soul crosses beyond the three gunas of maya and attains pure prema.[30] But if desires for enjoyment, liberation and the like live in the heart, prema will not be born even from hundreds of sadhanas: the thirst for bhukti and mukti is two witches, and as long as they are in the heart, the happiness of bhakti will not come.

Bhakti has three stages — sadhana, bhava and prema; its nine forms, beginning with hearing and chanting, are first performed in sadhana-bhakti. As the anarthas diminish through hearing and chanting with faith, faith rises and is called nishtha, ruchi, asakti, and then bhava, or rati. Rati is born from sadhana-bhakti; thickening, it is called prema, and further sneha, mana, pranaya, raga, anuraga, bhava and mahabhava, just as the juice of the sugar cane becomes molasses (gur), then khanda-sara, sugar, sitopala and the finest candy, mishri. All the stages from rati to mahabhava are the sthayi-bhava, the abiding sentiment of krishna-bhakti-rasa. Rasa arises when vibhava, anubhava, sattvika and vyabhichari join the sthayi-bhava. The sthayi-bhava is the chief foundation, the root (mula) of rasa; vibhava is its cause (hetu), anubhava its effect (karya), the sattvika-bhavas its special effect (karya-vishesha), and the vyabhichari (sanchari) its helpers (sahaya). Vibhava is alambana and uddipana; alambana is vishaya and ashraya: in krishna-bhakti-rasa the devotee is the ashraya, Krishna the vishaya, and Krishna's qualities the uddipana.

"One of these five rasas abides constantly in the devotee's heart, whereas the seven additional tastes may appear suddenly, owing to particular circumstances." (CC, Madhya 19.188)

The five principal rasas are shanta, dasya, sakhya, vatsalya and madhura; the seven secondary ones are hasya, adbhuta, vira, karuna, raudra, bhayanaka and bibhatsa. The secondary ones only nourish the principal: they come when occasioned and, having played their part, depart.[31] Krishna-rati is twofold: mixed with awareness of majesty, and pure. In Dvaraka, Mathura and Vaikuntha bhakti is mixed with awareness of majesty, and prema there is constrained; but in Gokula the cowherds and gopis, in pure love, do not acknowledge Krishna's majesty even when they see it.

In shanta-rasa there is fidelity to Krishna and the giving up of thirst for anything else; as sound, the quality of ether, is present in all the elements, so the qualities of shanta are present in all the higher rasas. But in shanta there is no feeling of "He is mine": its object is Parabrahman, Paramatma, worship in it is imbued with knowledge, and there is no service in it. In dasya this feeling is added to shanta — "He is my Lord, I am His eternal servant"; awareness of His lordship and reverence abound, and here service begins. In sakhya confidence (vishrambha) is added to the qualities of shanta and dasya, there is no reverence, and "mine" grows into "He is my equal." In vatsalya service becomes care, and the

informality of sakhya and an abundance of the feeling “mine” go as far as punishments and scoldings: the devotee regards himself as the guardian and Krishna as his ward. And in madhura, to fidelity, diligent service, informality and care is firmly joined service by the giving of oneself in the mood of the beloved (kanta-bhava); in it all five qualities meet, and as in earth the properties of all the elements beginning with ether are united, so in madhura-rasa the qualities of all the rasas are united. Thus the Lord established the supremacy of madhura-rasa.

In conclusion the Lord said:

“‘Such is My general description of the various rasas of loving service to God. You should consider how this can be explained in more detail. In one who constantly thinks of Krishna, love for Him gradually manifests. By Krishna's mercy even an uneducated person can reach the far shores of the ocean of loving relationships with God.’” (CC, Madhya 19.235–236)

First Visit to Vrindavana

“Having said this, Sri Chaitanya tenderly embraced Sri Rupa. Then He decided to set out for Benares. When the next morning Sri Chaitanya was ready to set out, Sri Rupa bowed before Him and made a humble request: ‘If You permit, I would like to go with You. I cannot bear these powerful waves of separation.’ Sri Chaitanya replied, ‘Your duty is to carry out My instructions. Vrindavana is not so far from here. Therefore go there. From Vrindavana you will come to Bengal, and from there go to Jagannatha Puri, where we shall meet.’ So Sri Chaitanya embraced Sri Rupa and boarded the boat, and Rupa fell unconscious on the spot. The brahmana from South India took Sri Rupa into his house, and then both brothers set out for Vrindavana.” (CC, Madhya 19.237–243)

In Mathura, at Dhruva-ghata, Rupa met Subuddhi Raya. He had formerly been an official in Gauda; when Hussain Shah deprived him of caste, he came to Kashi and, rejecting the verdicts of the smarta panditas, at the Lord's bidding took complete shelter of Krishna's name and went to Vrindavana. In Mathura he gathered and sold dry firewood; he himself lived on a pice worth of roasted chickpeas, and with the rest he fed needy Vaishnavas, and to all the Bengalis who came there he gave rice with yoghurt and oil for massage. Serving the Vaishnavas, as his example shows, is not for the rich alone: whoever sincerely wishes to serve will be given the means by the Lord. Rupa had known Subuddhi Raya before and rejoiced greatly to see his renunciation and his service to the Vaishnavas; Subuddhi served him with great love and himself led him round the holy places of Vraja-mandala — all the twelve forests of Vrindavana (CC, Madhya 25.200).

At the sight of the places of Krishna's pastimes, the plan of a drama about His pastimes was born in the heart of Rupa, “the crown of transcendental poets.” He began it right there in Vrindavana and then composed its nandi-shloka, the opening verse of benediction (and with it several verses of the prologue: obeisances, blessing, an indication of the subject). That time Rupa stayed in Vrindavana only a month. Looking for Sanatana, the brothers went to Prayaga by the road along the Ganga, while Sanatana was meanwhile going to Mathura by the great royal road — and they missed each other. In Mathura Sanatana learned about Rupa from Subuddhi Raya, and later, walking round the twelve forests with Subuddhi and a Sanoriya brahmana, heard from them that Rupa and Anupama had shortly before made this circuit and gone along the Ganga to Bengal.

In Kashi Rupa and Anupama met the Maharashtrian brahmana, Chandrashekhara and Tapana Mishra, took their meals in Tapana Mishra's house and heard from him the whole account of the Lord's teachings to Sanatana. At that time the boy Raghunatha, Tapana's son, saw Rupa and heard Mahaprabhu's teachings. After staying ten days in Kashi, the brothers went to Gauda; on the way Rupa pondered the events of the drama and made notes (kadchas). And in Gauda Anupama left his body on

the bank of the Ganga (“attained the Ganga”) and went to the eternal abode of Ramachandra.[32]

Satyabhamapura and Puri

After Anupama's passing, Rupa, burning with longing, set out for Nilachala, to the Lord's feet. Because of his brother's passing he was delayed on the road longer than he expected and no longer found the Gaudiyas led by Shivananda Sena — they had gone to Nilachala earlier; so Rupa missed their annual journey and reached Puri much later.

“In the province of Orissa there is a village called Satyabhama-pura. On his way to Puri he stopped there for the night. There in a dream he saw a maiden of unearthly beauty, who showed him her special favour. ‘Dedicate a whole play to Me,’ she commanded him. ‘By My mercy it will turn out extraordinarily beautiful.’ On waking, Sri Rupa thought: ‘Satyabhama tells me to write a separate play. I intended to describe Krishna's pastimes in Vrindavana and in Dvaraka in one play. Now I must divide them into two parts.’” (CC, Antya 1.40–44)

So Rupa understood that the maiden who had appeared to him was Satyabhama-devi, and decided to write the vraja-lila and the dvaraka-lila separately, as two dramas. This revelation, “Our Teachers” explains, accords with Mahaprabhu's teaching that the service of Vrindavana — Radha-dasyam — stands above every other kind of service to Krishna: the mood of Dvaraka is other than the mood of Vrindavana.

“Absorbed in these thoughts, he soon reached Jagannatha Puri. Arriving there, he went to the hut of Haridasa Thakura. With boundless love Haridasa Thakura received Rupa and said, ‘Mahaprabhu told me that you would come.’ Every day Sri Chaitanya came to Haridasa after seeing the upala-bhoga ceremony in the temple of Jagannatha. Unexpectedly He appeared before them. Rupa Gosvami prostrated himself. ‘This is Rupa offering You dandavat,’ said Haridasa. Having greeted Haridasa, the Lord embraced Rupa.” (CC, Antya 1.45–48)

Drawn by Rupa's humble and pure devotion, the Lord seated them both beside Him, asked about their welfare and talked with them at length. Asked about Sanatana, Rupa replied, “We did not meet: I went along the Ganga, he by the high road; in Prayaga I heard that he had gone to Vrindavana.” He also told of Anupama's passing.

Rupa met the Lord's other devotees, and one day the Lord came with all His associates and introduced Rupa to them; Rupa bowed at the feet of each, and all embraced him. Out of love for Rupa the Lord asked Nityananda and Advaita to pour Their mercy on him with all Their hearts: “By Your mercy may Rupa obtain the power to spread krishna-rasa-bhakti in the world.” Thus Mahaprabhu arranged for Rupa, and later Sanatana too, to meet Advaita and Nityananda. Rupa became dear to all the Lord's devotees — both the Gaudiyas and the people of Utkala.

Every day the Lord visited Haridasa, spoke intimately with Rupa and gave them both mahaprasada received from the temple; He sent them the remnants of His own meal with Govinda. For Haridasa, Rupa and Sanatana, though they were gurus even for the best of transcendental brahmanas, did not go into the temple of Jagannatha: out of great humility and for the sake of propriety, after their long closeness to the Muslim court, they considered themselves no better than mlechchhas.[33]

“Haridasa Thakura, Sri Rupa and Sri Sanatana never entered the temple of Jagannatha. After seeing the upala-bhoga ceremony, Mahaprabhu would visit these three saints and only then go home. So the Lord came to these devotees every day, even if one of them was not there.” (CC, Madhya 1.63–65)

Thus Sri Chaitanya, the “moving Jagannatha,” came to them Himself, and this was His constant rule. Rupa did not even enter the house of Kashi Mishra to see the Lord, though nothing prevented him, and

lived with Haridasa at Siddha-bakula. Mahaprabhu respected his decision and never told him to go to Jagannatha: Rupa's humility attracted the Lord, and through his example He wished to teach the world humility. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” says that the Lord “through Ramananda revealed the crushing of Kandarpa's pride, through Damodara revealed detachment, through Haridasa showed forbearance, through Sanatana and Rupa revealed humility” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.630–631).[34]

“Do Not Take Krishna out of Vraja”

“The next day the omniscient Lord Sri Chaitanya came to Rupa Gosvami and said to him: ‘Do not try to take Krishna out of Vrindavana, for He never wishes to go beyond it. “The Krishna who is called Yadu-kumara is Vasudeva-Krishna. He is different from Krishna, the son of Nanda Maharaja. Krishna Yadu-kumara performs His pastimes in Mathura and Dvaraka, but Krishna Nanda-nandana never leaves Vrindavana.”’” (CC, Antya 1.65–67)

The verse the Lord quoted is from the “Yamala.” Krishna, the son of Yadu, is Vasudeva, who plays in Mathura and Dvaraka; but the son of the king of the cowherds, Gopendra-nandana, does not leave Vrindavana.

Hearing this, Rupa was amazed. Now he was firmly convinced that Satyabhama-devi and the Lord were separately telling him to write two dramas: the “Lalita-madhava,” about the pastimes in Dvaraka, and the “Vidagdha-madhava,” solely about the pastimes in Vraja. And the dramas, formerly conceived as one, he began to plan and write separately — each with its own nandi, prologue (prastava) and plot.

“Priyah So ’yam”

The Ratha-yatra came. In divine madness the Lord danced before the chariot in the mood of separation and repeated a verse by an ordinary poet, seemingly about quite worldly lovers; no one understood why He loved this verse so much. Only Svarupa Damodara knew its hidden meaning and delighted the Lord with padas in the same mood. But by Mahaprabhu's mercy Rupa understood His inner states: the Lord looked at Jagannatha and spoke the verse in the mood of Radha — and Rupa, the only one besides Svarupa, grasped His intention and at once composed a verse after His heart, revealing its deeper meaning. This is told in detail in the article on Svarupa Damodara.

The verse the Lord repeated:

“He who in youth stole My heart is again My Lord. Again there are the clear moonlit nights of the month of Chaitra, the malati flowers smell just the same, and the same gentle breeze blows from the kadamba groves. Nothing has changed in Our intimate relationship: I am the same beloved, yet I find no happiness here. My heart longs to return to the bank of the Reva, to the shelter of the vetasi tree.” (CC, Antya 1.78)

And Rupa's verse:

“Dear friend, at last on the field of Kurukshetra I have met My long-dear sweet friend Krishna. I am the same Radhika, and We are together again. How sweet is the magical moment of Our meeting! Yet I want to be again on the bank of the Yamuna, beneath the shade of the groves of Vrindavana, and hear again His flute sounding the fifth note and driving Me mad.” (CC, Antya 1.79)[35]

Rupa wrote his verse on a palm leaf, tucked the leaf into the thatched roof of the hut and went to bathe in the sea. Meanwhile the Lord came, happened to look up, saw the leaf, read the verse — and was plunged into prema, marvelling at how clearly Rupa had grasped His innermost feelings. On returning, Rupa saw the Lord in prema and prostrated himself before Him.[36] The Lord slapped him: “How did you know the most secret thing in My heart?” — and embraced him tightly.

Then the Lord, as if not knowing the answer, playfully showed the verse to Svarupa, asking him to check whether it had any faults, and asked how Rupa had entered His thoughts.

"'As I understand it,' replied Svarupa Damodara, 'You are especially favourable to him. No one is able to understand this confidential meaning. I think You have fully endowed him with Your causeless mercy.' Sri Chaitanya said, 'I met Rupa Gosvami in Prayaga. I could not help granting him My mercy, seeing that he was supremely worthy of it. I endowed him with My spiritual power. Now you too must instruct him. In particular, enlighten him in the science of spiritual rasas.' Svarupa said, 'As soon as I saw his unique verse, I understood that You had given him Your special mercy. Seeing the effect, one can understand its cause.'" (CC, Antya 1.86–91)

Rupa's poetry disclosed the Lord's most intimate mood — the mood of Radha longing for Vraja; it can be understood only by His mercy, and by the effect the cause is known.

"Tunde Tandavini"

"So the Chaturmasya ended, and all the Vaishnavas of Bengal went home, but Rupa Gosvami remained in Jagannatha Puri in the shelter of Mahaprabhu's lotus feet. One day, when he was writing his book, Sri Chaitanya suddenly came. Seeing the Lord, Haridasa and Rupa sprang to their feet and fell before Him in dandavat. Sri Chaitanya embraced them both and sat down. 'What book are you writing?' He asked. Taking one of the palm leaves, He was very pleased to see the beautiful handwriting. 'Rupa's handwriting is like strings of pearls,' He praised him." (CC, Antya 1.93–97)

Rupa was then writing the "Vidagdha-madhava." On the leaf the Lord read a newly composed verse in glory of the Name — and was plunged into prema:

"How much sweetness these two syllables 'Krish-na' contain! I cannot even imagine it. As soon as one utters Krishna's name, it seems to dance on the tongue, and then one wishes to have thousands of mouths. When this name enters the ears, one wishes to have millions of ears. And when the holy name of Krishna begins to dance in the courtyard of the heart, it conquers the mind, and all the senses fall still." ("Vidagdha-madhava," 1.15; CC, Antya 1.99)[37]

Hearing it, the nama-acharya Haridasa Thakura in rapture began to glorify the meaning of the verse and broke into a dance (CC, Antya 1.100): for the true greatness of the Name, says Kaviraja, is revealed only by great devotees who disclose the meaning of the scriptures (1.101). According to one biography, Haridasa said that he had heard of the glory of the Name from many scriptures and sadhus, but never such a description of its sweetness.

The Gathering at Rupa's

On another day, after the darshana of Jagannatha, the Lord came to Rupa at Siddha-bakula with all His associates — Sarvabhauma, Ramananda Raya, Svarupa and others. On the way He praised to them Rupa's verses "priyah so 'yam" and "tunde tandavini" and glorified his virtues in every way. This gathering is also described in the article on Ramananda Raya; here we tell of it from Rupa's side.

At Rupa's the Lord told him to read "priyah so 'yam." Out of respect Rupa was abashed and kept silent, and Svarupa read the verse; all were amazed, and Ramananda and Sarvabhauma said to the Lord that the power to disclose what is hidden in His heart can be obtained only by His mercy. Svarupa explained that by Mahaprabhu's special mercy Rupa had understood what neither Brahma nor the demigods comprehend. Then the Lord told him to read "tunde tandavini." Rupa was shy of reading his own verse, but did not dare disobey the repeated commands:

"When the devotees, and especially Ramananda Raya, heard this verse, they felt unprecedented bliss and amazement. All agreed that although they had heard many descriptions of the glory of God's holy

name, it had never been so sweet as with Rupa Gosvami." (CC, Antya 1.121–122)

Ramananda asked what book Rupa was writing, that it held such a treasury of unprecedented truths, and Svarupa told of the two dramas: the "Vidagdha-madhava," about the pastimes in Vraja, and the "Lalita-madhava," about the pastimes in the cities (pura-lila). At Ramananda's request Rupa read the nandi-shloka of the "Vidagdha-madhava":

"May these pastimes of Krishna lessen all the sufferings of this world and dispel all unworthy desires. These pastimes are as sweet as shikharini (a mixture of yoghurt and sugar candy). They bring to nothing the pride even of the nectar made on Chandra-loka, for they spread so strong and enchanting a fragrance of the loving relationships of Srimati Radharani and the other gopis." ("Vidagdha-madhava," 1.1; CC, Antya 1.128)

Then Ramananda asked him to read the verse of benediction describing Rupa's chosen Deity. Rupa was abashed and silent: the subject of the verse was the Lord Himself, seated beside him. "In an assembly of Vaishnavas there is nothing to be shy of in reading the very essence of one's book," said Ramananda, and at the Lord's insistence Rupa read:

"May the Supreme Lord, who has come as the son of Srimati Shachidevi, abide for ever in the innermost region of your heart. Shining with the colour of molten gold, He has by His causeless mercy descended in this age of Kali to give what no Avatara offered before — the most exalted mood of loving service to God, the rasa of conjugal love." ("Vidagdha-madhava," 1.2; CC, Antya 1.132)

Ramananda asked about the various parts of the "Vidagdha-madhava," and Rupa answered every question with great humility, quoting verses from each part. Admiring his transcendental poetry, Ramananda wished to hear the nandi and the obeisance to the chosen Deity in the second drama, the "Lalita-madhava." Rupa, humbly speaking of Ramananda's greatness and his own insignificance, read the nandi and then the prayer for blessing to his ishtadeva, Sri Krishna Chaitanya:

"The moon-faced Supreme Lord has come as the son of mother Shachi to spread loving devotion to Himself. He is the emperor of the whole community of brahmanas. He drives away the darkness of ignorance and governs the mental faculties of each and every one. May this waxing moon, Sri Chaitanya, grant us all well-being and happiness." (CC, Antya 1.177)

In His heart the Lord rejoiced, but to teach people He outwardly showed anger:

"'Your poetic descriptions are full of the sweetness of Krishna's rasas and are therefore like an ocean of nectar. But why have you inserted unjustified praise of Me? It is like a spoonful of tar in a barrel of honey.' 'It is not tar,' objected Ramananda Raya. 'It is a little camphor, with which he has only enhanced the taste of his exalted poetry.' 'Ramananda Raya,' answered Mahaprabhu, 'you are glad to hear these verses, but I am ashamed, for people will laugh at them.' 'On the contrary, they will be very happy to hear these verses,' said Ramananda Raya, 'for remembering one's beloved Deity at the beginning of any undertaking attracts good fortune.'" (CC, Antya 1.179–182)

The Lord's anger was only an appearance meant to teach people, and Rupa, by remembering his Deity at the beginning of his book, had done nothing contrary to the shastras and siddhanta.[38]

Ramananda asked about each part of the "Lalita-madhava" too, and Rupa answered, quoting the relevant verses. Having gone through both dramas, Ramananda turned to Mahaprabhu's feet and began, as if with a thousand mouths, to extol Rupa's poetry:

"'This is not verse but an endless stream of nectar. It is the essence of all the highest truths presented in the form of a play. Rupa Gosvami's wonderful poetry is the highest example of the description of loving relationships. These verses can draw anyone into a whirlpool of spiritual bliss.'" (CC, Antya 1.193–194)

And he added: what use are a poet's poetry and an archer's arrow if, entering another's heart, they do not make the head spin? Without the Lord's mercy an ordinary person could not write such verses: in them all the characteristics of drama are observed and the essence of siddhanta is expressed, and the love of Radha and Krishna is depicted so that mind and ear reel with delight.

"'I met Rupa Gosvami in Prayaga,' replied Mahaprabhu. 'He attracted Me by his extraordinary qualities, which gave Me great joy. This poetry is endowed with such wonderful and sweet metaphors, and with many other literary ornaments. Without these poetic virtues the preaching of the spiritual rasas is simply impossible. I ask you all to bless Rupa Gosvami, so that he may ceaselessly describe these pastimes of Vrindavana, full of the divine rasas of love for Krishna. His elder brother, Sanatana, is so wise and learned that there is no one who can compare with him. His detachment from everything worldly is as strong as yours, Ramananda. In him humility, detachment and unsurpassed learning are united. I empower these two brothers to go to Vrindavana and write literary works on bhakti.'" (CC, Antya 1.197–202)

In one biography's retelling the Lord says here: "Having invested shakti in the hearts of both brothers, I have sent them to Vrindavana to propagate the scriptures of bhakti."

"Then Sri Chaitanya embraced Rupa Gosvami and asked him to offer prayers at the lotus feet of all the devotees present. Advaita Acharya, Nityananda Prabhu and all the other devotees poured their causeless mercy on Rupa Gosvami and embraced him. All the devotees were immensely astonished at the special mercy Sri Chaitanya had shown Rupa Gosvami, and at the unsurpassed virtues of Rupa himself." (CC, Antya 1.206–208)

Sri Gaurasundara is Himself the lord of Sarasvati; Ramananda, the author of the "Jagannatha-vallabha-nataka," is Vishakha-devi in the pastimes of Vraja; Svarupa Damodara, Gaurasundara's "second self" and an ocean of transcendental rasa, is Lalita-devi. Both they and all the devotees who know rasa praised Rupa's poetry: it cannot be compared with the verses of worldly, "village" poets. The "Vidagdha-madhava," as one biography says, was heard and praised without measure by Sri Chaitanya Himself — "the united form of Radha and Madhava" — by Ramananda, Svarupa and others close to Gaura. Worldly men of letters, for their part, place Rupa on a level with Kalidasa, or below or above him. But just as neither a piece of glass nor even the Koh-i-noor can be compared with the transcendental Kaustubha gem, so no worldly poet celebrated by the crowd can be compared even with the radiance of the toenails of Rupa's feet.[39]

The "Srimad-Bhagavatam" (1.5.10) says: "Speech, however colourful its words, that does not sing the glory of Hari, which purifies the world, is a place of pilgrimage for crows; the swans find no joy in it." Poetry that does not serve with undeviating devotion the one transcendental Madana, Krishna, is the delight of "crow-like" seekers of pleasure; but the bhagavata-paramahamsas, like the royal swans of Lake Manasa, reject poetry without the taste of hari-katha, however full of verbal brilliance. Worldly poets sometimes bow to Hari by custom at the beginning of a book, but their devotion is not undivided: now they glorify Parvati and Shiva as the mother and father of the world, now they describe their love-play and the birth of Kumara, as in the "Kumara-sambhava." But the poetry of Rupa, the crown of transcendental poets, is ever honoured by the undividedly devoted paramahamsas, for it serves Krishna's pleasure alone.

Once in the same Nilachala, Svarupa Damodara, the Lord's "second self" and the best judge of the siddhanta of bhakti-rasa, on hearing words contrary to siddhanta in the nandi-shloka of a village poet from Bengal, held up as an example the opening verses of Rupa's two dramas:

"Poetry that describes the contradictory relationships of worldly people cannot give anyone joy. But the poetry of one who is absorbed in love of God and skilled in describing pure loving feelings gives true

happiness. The two beautiful plays of Sri Rupa Gosvami are an example of this. Merely on hearing their introduction all the devotees feel the highest happiness." (CC, Antya 5.107–108)

Head of the Sampradaya

The book of our line, "Our Teachers," sees in these days at Puri the establishment of Rupa as head of the sampradaya. Mahaprabhu was surrounded by exalted souls. Ramananda Raya He regarded as His equal and even as His guru, and He Himself acknowledged his exalted position in the famous conversation on the bank of the Godavari; Svarupa Damodara is honoured as Mahaprabhu's second manifestation, and no work was presented to the Lord without his strict examination. And yet it was not they but Rupa whom He made head of the sampradaya. To Svarupa's answer that the Lord's heart is open to Rupa by His mercy (see above), this book adds: Mahaprabhu, who always showed humility, this time revealed His own nature: "Yes, I have given Rupa everything."

Then, according to this account, Mahaprabhu presented Rupa to the assembly of His closest associates and asked them to test him, appointing Ramananda Raya as judge. Rupa read passages from the "Lalita-madhava" and the "Vidagdha-madhava," and Ramananda, examining the depth and consistency of the truths set out in them, asked about style, poetics and theology; Rupa's answers astonished everyone. Haridasa Thakura, the acharya of the holy name, said of his verse in glory of the Harinama: "Never before have we heard anything that expresses the understanding of the Holy Name with such perfection." And Ramananda concluded: Rupa has presented the genuine teaching of Mahaprabhu, his poetry surpasses all that was written before him, and he is the greatest of poets; a hero is one who always attains his goal, and Rupa is a great hero, for his poetry "strikes the very heart and never misses." "All of us," he said, "acknowledge him as Your successor."

All who were present confirmed: "Without doubt You have bestowed all Your mercy on him. Otherwise he could not have written such things." Then Mahaprabhu wished that all of them should bless Rupa, so that he might reveal His teaching to the world. The Vaishnavas objected: "Your mercy will be enough." "No, it is not enough," Mahaprabhu replied. "You are My friends. So bestow your mercy on him; then he will feel pure love for Krishna and will be able to spread His message." And all the great souls blessed Rupa without hesitation. Thus Mahaprabhu revealed the true glory of Sri Rupa and placed His sampradaya in his care. At the assembly where He proclaimed Rupa head of the sampradaya, in the words of this book, were present Ramananda Raya, Svarupa Damodara, Sarvabhauma Bhattacharya, Advaita Acharya, Bhagavan Acharya, Shikhi Mahiti and hundreds of other saints and scholars.[40]

Rupa's authority, says "Our Teachers," was acknowledged by all the great devotees of Mahaprabhu: Sanatana, Rupa's guru, honoured him as his senior; Raghunatha Dasa glorified him in his prayers; Svarupa Damodara, Ramananda Raya, Sarvabhauma Bhattacharya, Advaita Acharya and Haridasa Thakura — those dearer to Mahaprabhu than anyone — acknowledged his leadership. Mahaprabhu Himself wrote no books: He charged His disciples to work out and establish His teaching, and all the writings of the Gaudiya Vaishnavas go back to the works of Rupa — to the source from which the stream of Mahaprabhu's teaching flows. Rupa and Sanatana He taught Himself, while to others He only gave advice, and He made them the guardians of His teaching; therefore by Rupa's name the followers of Mahaprabhu call themselves Rupanugas, and their school the Rupanuga-sampradaya. Rupa's direct disciple, Jiva Gosvami, brilliantly defended his views in the "Shat-sandarbha," and the knowledge received from Rupa and Sanatana has come down to our day through Raghunatha Dasa, Jiva and other acharyas.

The Command to Go to Vrindavana

“So all the devotees spent the four months of the rainy season in Sri Chaitanya's company. Then the Lord bade them farewell, and they returned to Bengal. But Rupa Gosvami remained at Sri Chaitanya's lotus feet until the festival of Dola-yatra, which he happily witnessed together with Mahaprabhu. After Dola-yatra Sri Chaitanya took leave of Rupa Gosvami too. The Lord endowed him with His mercy and spiritual power and gave him this command: ‘Now go to Vrindavana and stay there. And send your elder brother Sanatana here. Having come to Vrindavana, live there, write books on the treasure of the spiritual rasas and restore the forgotten holy places. Serve Krishna and preach rasa-bhakti. I too shall soon come to Vrindavana again.’ With these words Sri Chaitanya embraced Rupa Gosvami, and he then placed the Lord's lotus feet on his head. Rupa Gosvami took leave of all Sri Chaitanya's devotees and returned to Vrindavana by way of Bengal.” (CC, Antya 1.214–221)

This command is called fourfold: to write the scriptures of bhakti-rasa, to find the lost holy places, to establish the service of Deities and temples, and to preach transcendental bhakti-rasa — and so to establish the Lord's innermost desire. Rupa and Sanatana fulfilled it.[41] Taking leave of the Lord, Rupa placed His feet on his head and went to Vrindavana by way of Gauda.[42] In Gauda he divided his movable and immovable property among his relatives, had the money kept there brought to him and distributed it to relatives, brahmanas and temples; because of this he was delayed in Gauda for nearly a year.

Life in Vraja

Having settled in Vrindavana, the brothers carried out the Lord's command:

“Having met in Vrindavana, the two brothers began to live together, carrying out the will of Sri Chaitanya. They collected many sacred scriptures and searched out all the forgotten holy places. At these places they built shrines and began the worship of Krishna there.” (CC, Antya 4.217–218)

Of Rupa's books Kaviraja writes:

“Rupa Gosvami too has many works. The most important of his books is the ‘Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu.’ In it he described the essence of the bhakti-rasas, loving service to Krishna in various spiritual relationships with Him. He also wrote the book ‘Ujjvala-nilamani,’ by which we can understand the greatness and essence of the loving relationships between Sri Radha and Sri Krishna. He also composed two plays: ‘Vidagdha-madhava’ and ‘Lalita-madhava.’ From them we can learn everything about the rasas with which Krishna's pastimes are filled. Sri Rupa wrote many books, such as the ‘Dana-keli-kaumudi.’ In all he composed more than a hundred thousand verses in Sanskrit. In all his books he described in detail the nature of transcendental loving relationships with Krishna in Vrindavana.” (CC, Antya 4.223–226)

Of the books themselves we shall speak below, in the section “Works.”

Describing the branches of Gaurasundara's tree of prema, Krishnadasa Kaviraja speaks also of the branch of Rupa and Sanatana:

“By the sweet will of the gardener, Sri Chaitanya, the branches of Sri Rupa and Sanatana grew so much that they covered all the western lands. Spreading as far as the river Indus and the Himalayas, those branches embraced all of India, including all the holy places of pilgrimage such as Vrindavana, Mathura and Haridvara. The fruits of divine love that grew on these branches the devotees distributed generously everywhere. Having tasted the nectar of this love, all people became intoxicated. Usually the people of the western provinces were unprincipled and unwise. But the preaching of Sri Rupa and Sanatana Gosvami transformed them, giving them an understanding of how to live properly in devotion to Krishna. Acting in full accord with the instructions of the scriptures, these two Gosvamis discovered the forgotten holy places and established proper worship of the Deities in Vrindavana.” (CC, Adi 10.86–90)

How the brothers lived in Vrindavana, performing bhajana all eight praharas of the day, was told in Puri by Vaishnava eyewitnesses:

"'They live in the forest without a home of their own. Every night they sleep under a different tree. Sometimes they come to the houses of brahmanas and collect a little alms. Having given up all enjoyments, they eat only dry flatbread and roasted chickpeas. Their only possessions are a water pot, a patchwork blanket and a worn cloth. They constantly chant the names of Krishna, speak of Him and dance in jubilation. They worship Krishna all day and night and sleep only an hour and a half. And sometimes for several days without sleep they perform nama-sankirtana in the bliss of divine love. They write books devoted to bhakti-rasa. Sometimes they hear about Sri Chaitanya or become absorbed in thinking of Him.' Hearing such words, Mahaprabhu's personal associates felt great happiness and exclaimed: 'Can one be surprised at the deeds of one who has received Sri Chaitanya's mercy? For him nothing is impossible.'" (CC, Madhya 19.127–132)

The alms spoken of here is madhukari: a handful of food from door to door, as a bee gathers honey from flowers.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati explains ("Anubhashya" on CC, Madhya 19.131): the Gosvamis now chanted the Name, now worshipped the Lord by writing books on bhakti-rasa, now remembered and glorified Mahaprabhu. The view of the prakrita-sahajiyas that sadhana requires giving up the study and writing of the shastras for the sake of "ignorance" is foreign to the Rupanugas; but whoever studies or writes for money, fame and honour grows weeds and will not obtain the true fruit, and a genuine Rupanuga does not seek such petty gains.

Of this same renunciation one biography speaks in reply to those who called the Gosvamis of Vrindavana self-seeking — and it speaks of them all together: Rupa, Raghunatha and the other Gosvamis, desiring only Krishna's pleasure, gave up ministerial posts under Hussain Shah, wealth like that of Indra, and wives as lovely as apsaras; they spent only one night under each tree and chewed dry chickpeas. The crown of the great renunciants, they showed themselves to be great lovers, intoxicated with divine madness, and even those who trust only their own experience unanimously praise their renunciation; to say that they appropriated the money of worldly people and of the Deities is childish prattle.

Drawn by the bhajana of Rupa and Sanatana and by the Lord's earlier instructions, Raghunatha Bhatta, Gopala Bhatta and Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami came to Vrindavana, and Jiva Gosvami at Nityananda's merciful bidding. Following Rupa and Sanatana, they preached Gaurasundara's innermost desire; the brothers' example drew the other Gosvamis to Vrindavana, and all of them are followers of Rupa. Soon after Lokanatha had settled in Vrindavana at the Lord's bidding, Rupa, Sanatana, Gopala Bhatta and others began to come there to live, and their company gladdened Lokanatha; they were all of one mind and heart, and Lokanatha was the eldest among the Gosvamis.[43] Sanatana, Rupa and Raghunatha, according to one biography, performed their bhajana in Vraja as one soul (abhinnatma) — just as Lokanatha and Bhugarbha did, and later Narottama and Ramachandra.

Jiva recalls in the "Laghu-toshani" that Gopala Himself, in the form of a cowherd boy, appeared to the two brothers, bringing them milk (kshira-aharana-lila), and that Raghunatha Dasa was their renowned friend, whom the best of the Aryas regarded as their equal. Rupa and Sanatana were also the first to found the Sri Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha, "the assembly of the king of the Vaishnavas of the whole world"; it was founded anew on 5 February 1919 in Calcutta.

Sri Govinda-deva

In Vrindavana Rupa established the service of Govindaji, and Sanatana that of Madana-mohana: as Madana-mohana was the treasure of Sanatana's life, so Govinda was the lord of Rupa's life. Krishnadasa Kaviraja, naming the three Deities of Vrindavana — Madana-mohana, Govinda and Gopinatha — says:

“These three principal Deities have for ever captured the hearts of all the Gaudiya Vaishnavas. I worship Their beautiful feet, for They are the Lords of my life.” (CC, Adi 1.19)[44]

Among the obeisances to the three lords of Vrindavana at the beginning of the “Chaitanya-charitamrita,” Kaviraja bows to Govinda as the lord of abhidheya:

“I pray for the mercy that will help me constantly remember the Divine Couple, Sri Sri Gandharva-Govindasundara, seated on a throne adorned with shining jewels in the forest of Vraja, beneath a mind-enchanting wish-fulfilling tree and surrounded by Their closest maidservants (sakhis and manjaris).” (CC, Adi 1.16)

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati explains: Madana-mohana is the Deity of sambandha, and the acharya of sambandha is Sanatana; Govinda is the Deity of abhidheya, who accepts service, and the acharya of abhidheya is Rupa; Gopinatha is the Deity of prayojana, and the acharya of prayojana is Raghunatha Dasa. Rupa shows how to serve Radha and Krishna, and therefore Rupa's feet are the highest goal even for the acharya of prayojana, Raghunatha Dasa.

How Rupa revealed the service of Govinda is told in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (2nd taranga, 422–453), following the verses of the “Sadhana-dipika” of Radhakrishna Gosvami, a disciple of Haridasa Pandita Gosvami, who lived in Vraja-mandala.[45] Krishnadasa Kaviraja calls Haridasa Pandita the superintendent of Govinda's service (CC, Adi 8.54). Pandita Banamali Lala Gosvami of the Radha-ramana-ghera in Vrindavana spoke in 1940 of a “Sadhana-dipika” by Narayana Bhatta, but the “Sadhana-dipika” quoted in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” is the work of Radhakrishna Gosvami. This book (the verses from it given below are quoted by the “Bhakti-ratnakara” elsewhere, in the 6th taranga) beautifully glorifies following Rupa: “With those who stand outside the siddhanta of Rupa, the ocean of mercy, travellers on the path of raga should not converse about prema-rasa. I bow to the feet of Rupa, by whose mercy even an ignorant person grasps his teaching.” And again: “Tongue, always utter the name ‘Rupa’! Mind, remember Rupa, the embodiment of compassion! Head, bow before Rupa of the merciful glance — and before Raghunatha Dasa, his second body, who has no equal.”

According to the “Sadhana-dipika,” having come to Vrindavana at the Lord's bidding, Rupa found no Deity there and grieved deeply. He searched for his beloved Lord through the forests of Vraja, through the villages, in every house of the Vrajavasis, and, not finding Him, one day sat under a tree on the bank of the Yamuna and wept, burning in separation from Krishna. Then a handsome Vrajavasi came up to him and in a sweet voice asked why he was sad. Rupa told him of the Lord's instructions. The man led him to the hill of Goma-tila and said, “Every morning a cow (kamadhenu) comes here and pours out her milk of her own accord; understand what this means and do what is needed,” and vanished.[46] At his words and his form Rupa fainted in prema, and on coming to himself understood: “Krishna came and spoke with me, and I did not recognise Him.” He understood the secret and announced to the Vrajavasis that here was the Yoga-pitha and here Govinda-deva lay hidden. All the Vrajavasis — children, old men, youths — with hearts melted by love began to dig and, by the mercy of Baladeva, beheld within the Yoga-pitha the face of Govinda, who enchants millions of Kamadevas.[47] It is said that this Govinda was originally worshipped by Krishna's great-grandson Vajranabha.[48]

Rupa informed Gaurasundara in Nilachala by letter, and the Lord, greatly pleased, told “the strong” Kashishvara to go to Vrindavana to help Rupa and Sanatana; Kashishvara did not want to leave the Lord. Then, understanding that Kashishvara's heart was pained by separation from Him, the Lord brought the Deity of Krishna that stood beside Jagannatha and said, “Know that He is non-different

from Me.” The Deity and Mahaprabhu took food together, and Kashishvara, bowing down, carried the Deity of Sri Sri Gaura-Govinda to Vrindavana: this is Mahaprabhu standing beside Govinda. The “Sadhana-dipika” prays: “May Gaura-Govinda be merciful to me, whose feet by their radiance surpass Madana, whose face puts to shame the lotus and the jewel, at whose feet Rupa took shelter.”[49]

The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (6th taranga, 92–110, also following the verses of the “Sadhana-dipika”) tells of the Deity of Radha too. A South Indian brahmana, Brihadbhanu, a great Vaishnava, settled in the village of Radhanagara in Utkala; the Deity of Srimati Radharani came from Vrindavana to his house, and he served Her as a daughter, in vatsalya-rasa. After Brihadbhanu's passing, the king of Utkala, Prataparudra, hearing of this, himself came to Radhanagara for darshana, and at night in a dream Radhika told him to take Her to the temple of Jagannatha; there She was installed with great reverence at a place called Chakraveda (Chakraberha), and ordinary people honoured Her as Lakshmi. Then She gave a command in a dream to the prince Purushottama Jana, and the Deity with many people set out from Sri Kshetra for Vrindavana and was installed to the left of Govinda-deva (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 6.107); all in Gauda, Utkala and other lands came to know of it.

The huge temple of Govinda-deva, with its seemingly broken summits, draws every eye; it stands on the high hill of Goma-tila, west of the broad road from Mathura to Vrindavana. Its construction is told of in various ways; it is said to have been built of red Jaipur sandstone by the famous Man Singh, king of Amber, who in 1590 renewed an earlier structure and added to it. Growse, the authority on Mathura, in “Mathura: A District Memoir,” called the temple of Gobind Deva not only the finest of its series but the most impressive religious edifice of Hindu art, at least in Northern India. The enclosure around the temple is called the “Govindera ghera.” On either side of the jagamohana stands a small temple; the interior of the southern one is called the Yoga-pitha — it is said that Govinda was found there. Going down the steps, one comes to a narrow dark place where the pujaris show by lamplight the Deity of Yogamaya; there too is a footprint of Krishna. On the north wall of this small temple there is an inscription in Devanagari: in the thirty-fourth year of Akbar's reign the maharajadhiraja Man Singh, son of Maharaja Bhagavan Dasa, of the line of Prithviraja, built the temple on the Yoga-pitha of Vrindavana for Govinda-deva; the work was supervised by Kalyana Dasa, the sculptor was Manikchand Chopang, the mason Govinda Dasa (Dilvali); at the end is what appears to be a signature — Ganesha Dasa Bimabala. From the date of the inscription it is clear that the temple was built many years after Govinda-deva's appearance.

Govindaji, revealed on Goma-tila, was at first served in a simple hut. Krishnadasa Kaviraja writes of Raghunatha Bhatta, whose life was in Govinda alone:

“Later he instructed his disciples to erect a temple for Lord Govinda. He personally made many different ornaments for the Deity of Govinda, such as a flute and earrings in the shape of the mythical sea creature.” (CC, Antya 13.131)

The CC names neither the disciple of Raghunatha Bhatta to whom he entrusted this nor the builder of the temple.

Aurangzeb, it is said, destroyed the main temple and its five upper towers. Tradition relates that the badshah from his distant palace in Agra saw every day a bright light on the summit of Govinda's temple and out of envy could not bear that the temple stood higher than his pleasure palace; he sent troops to destroy the temples of Mathura and Vrindavana, but the priests, learning of it through spies, at once carried their Deities away by forest paths. So Govinda-deva came to Jaipur, where He is served to this day.[50] But just as Ravana, having stolen only Sita's shadow, thought he had stolen Sita herself, the Lord's svarupa-shakti, so it was here: enemies touch only the outward. The almighty Lord plays at being helpless, the protector of Brahma and Shiva as if in need of protection; this wonderful pastime attracts

the service of the devotees and bewilders those who have turned away from Him.

According to the “Sadhana-dipika” (in the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” 2.449–453), at the Lord's bidding the merciful Rupa also revealed Vrinda-devi, on the bank of the Brahma-kunda. It is said that She resided in a small temple north of the Govinda-ghera and has now been moved to Kamyavana.

In the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” Rupa describes the “ruin” that the darshana of Govinda brings:

“Friend, if you value the company of your kinsfolk, do not look at Govinda standing at Keshi-ghata — smiling, bent in three places, with sidelong glance, with the flute at His lips tender as young shoots, with a peacock feather in His hair.” (“Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu,” 1.2.239)[51]

Its meaning is that the darshana of Govinda takes away the taste for everything else.

Baladeva Vidyabhushana, at the beginning of his commentary on Rupa's “Govinda-virudavali,” tells how it came to be. A certain poet from the South recited a laudatory “deva-virudavali,” and Govinda, pleased with the elegance of its words and meaning, gave him the garland from His neck. Rupa wondered: how could Govinda, the Lord of all, be pleased on hearing a “deva-virudavali”? And one day, while Rupa slept, Govinda said to him, “Compose My virudavali with such-and-such characteristics.”

In Krishnadasa Kaviraja's time Govinda was served by His beloved servants. The “Chaitanya-charitamrita” says:

“In the most intimate temple of Vrindavana, beneath wish-fulfilling trees, there is a golden throne adorned with jewels. On that golden throne the son of Nanda Maharaja, Sri Govinda, the God of Love Himself, is ever seated. In that temple Sri Govinda is worshipped, served by the highest standard. His garments, ornaments and paraphernalia are divine and wholly spiritual. Thousands of servants serve Sri Govinda unceasingly. And even tens of thousands of mouths would not suffice merely to describe this worship. At that time the superintendent of this temple was Sri Haridasa Pandita. His virtues and fame were known to the whole world.” (CC, Adi 8.50–54)

“Kashishvara Gosvami had a disciple named Govinda Gosvami, who was a dear servant of the Deity of Govinda in Vrindavana.” (CC, Adi 8.66)

“And the disciple of Gadadhara Pandita named Bhugarbha Gosvami also spoke only of the deeds of Sri Chaitanya. Other topics did not interest him at all. The disciples of Bhugarbha Gosvami were Chaitanya Dasa (the servant of the Deity of Govinda), Mukundananda Chakravarti and Krishnadasa, full of divine love.” (CC, Adi 8.68–69)

Haridasa Pandita was a disciple of Ananta Acharya, a disciple of Gadadhara Pandita; Govinda Gosani, a disciple of “the strong” Kashishvara, was a great servant of Sri Govinda.

Gopala in Mathura

Rupa revered the hill of Govardhana as Krishna Himself and therefore, following Mahaprabhu's command, together with Sanatana never climbed it. Just as Gopala once on some pretext gave Mahaprabhu darshana at the foot of the hill, so He showed mercy to Rupa and Sanatana as well.

In his old age Rupa enacted the pastime of no longer being able to reach Govardhana, and longed to see Gopala, the Deity of Madhavendra Puri. And when Rupa's heart was deeply longing for His beauty, Gopala, wishing to give “His own” Rupa darshana — in fact, to show him mercy — on the pretext of fear of iconoclast mlechchhas came Himself from Govardhana to Mathura, to the house of Vitthalanatha (Vitthaleshvara), the younger son of Vallabhacharya, and accepted service there for a month. So Rupa with his companions gazed his fill on the beauty of Gopala-deva (CC, Madhya 18):[52]

“Sri Rupa with his companions also spent a whole month in Mathura, beholding this Deity. He was accompanied by Gopala Bhatta Gosvami, Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami, Raghunatha Bhatta Gosvami and Lokanatha Dasa Gosvami, Bhugarbha Gosvami, Sri Jiva Gosvami, Sri Yadava Acharya and Govinda Gosvami, Sri Uddhava Dasa, Madhava, Sri Gopala Dasa and Narayana Dasa. Also the great devotee Govinda, Vani Krishnadasa, Pundarikaksha, Ishana and Laghu Haridasa. With great joy Sri Rupa came for the darshana of Sri Gopala accompanied by all these eminent devotees.” (CC, Madhya 18.48–53)

Ishana, a Vaishnava of Vrindavana, was also among those accompanying Rupa according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara.” The place in Mathura, in the Satghara quarter, where Rupa came for the darshana of Gopala was found in the mid-1930s by Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati (on 29 October, in the month of Kartika).

One biography relates that the brothers continued to care for Gopala's service later as well. When His pujaris, driven out and beaten by Krishnadasa's men (see the article on Madhavendra Puri), came to Rupa and Sanatana in Vrindavana — the brothers were then living with hearts deeply wounded by separation from Gaura — and afterwards lodged a complaint in the royal court of Mathura, whose officials had been bribed beforehand, the brothers, hearing that the service of Gopala, the treasure of Madhavendra Puri's life, would pass into the hands of the royal officials, handed over the service and the temple of Gopala to Vitthalanatha, the son of Vallabhacharya, and duly arranged for Gaudiya pujaris. Vitthalanatha was especially favoured by Rupa and the Rupanugas: because he accepted the authority of Sri Krishna Chaitanya and His associates, the Gosvamis headed by Rupa and Raghunatha approved his service to Gopala. According to the same biography, Vitthalanatha in Mathura together with Rupa honoured Gopala Bhatta Gosvami (the words also allow the reading “honoured both Rupa and Gopala Bhatta”), and Rupa, wandering through Vraja-mandala, came to Gathuli and greatly rejoiced to see Vitthala's (Vitthalanatha's) service to the Deity of Krishna Chaitanya.[53]

The Sweet Rice and Radha's Braid

The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5.1311–1330) relates that once Rupa wished to cook sweet rice for Sanatana and invite him to eat, but there was nothing needed in his hut. And Srimati Radharani, who fulfils the innermost desires of the devotees, in the form of a young cowherd girl brought milk, rice, sugar and ghee.[54] Rupa opened the door and saw a beautiful cowherd girl with gifts. “Child, why have you come? Why did you trouble yourself?” “What trouble, baba? I have only come to render a little service to a saint.” Rupa accepted the gifts and invited her to sit down, but she said she had work to do and vanished, leaving Rupa perplexed.

He cooked the sweet rice, offered it to his Deity, Govinda-deva, and gave the prasada to Sanatana when he came. Sanatana felt an extraordinary bliss and asked where the milk and rice had come from. “A cowherd girl came,” said Rupa. “I was just thinking how to cook sweet rice for Sanatana, and she appeared as if by magic.” Sanatana understood that it had been Sri Radha Thakurani Herself and with tears of love said, “By accepting service from Her we are ruined — we shall not reach our cherished goal”; for Radha is their Mistress and they Her servants, and the relationship of service had been reversed. Again and again he reproached himself for having accepted service from Her whom he longed to serve, and strictly forbade Rupa to accept such gifts in future.[55]

According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” Sanatana once came to Radha-kunda to Rupa and Raghunatha Dasa; they rose, showed him honour, seated him, and all three held an ishtagoshthi, a discussion about Krishna. Rupa had then written a hymn to Radharani, the “Chatu-pushpanjali” (“Offering of Four Flowers”), and one verse had lodged in Sanatana's mind: “You, O Gaurangi, of the colour of fresh gorochana, clad in garments the colour of the blue lotus, and Your long braid, glittering with clusters of jewels, is like a black serpent.” Sanatana had his doubts: is it fitting to compare Radharani's braid to a

snake? That same day, bathing in Radha-kunda, he saw cowherd boys and girls playing at a distance; behind the head of one girl something black was swaying, and it seemed to him a poisonous snake. “Child, beware, there is a snake on your back!” he cried, but she did not hear. Running up, he saw that it was Sri Radha Herself, and the boys and girls laughed for a long time. Sanatana was struck dumb — and understood the rightness of Rupa's comparison.

The Elder Brother

Even when speaking of Sanatana, the Gaudiya acharyas call him again and again “Rupa's elder brother.” So write Kavi Karnapura (“Chaitanya-chandrodaya-nataka,” 9.34)[56], Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami in the “Stavavali” (“Sva-niyama-dashaka,” 1; “Manah-shiksha,” 3) and in the “Mukta-charita” (4), Jiva in the closing verse of the “Laghu-toshani,” and Krishnadasa Kaviraja, in the verse of obeisance to the shastra-gurus at the beginning of chapters of the Antya-lila, bows “before my shastra-gurus: Srila Rupa Gosvami and his elder brother Srila Sanatana Gosvami” (CC, Antya 2.1; likewise Antya 3.1).

Sanatana himself, in the opening verse of his commentary “Dig-darshini” on the “Brihad-bhagavatamrita,” bows to Sri Chaitanya, “having taken shelter of whose Rupa” this low man obtained bhakti: the word “rupa” here means both the Lord's “form” and Rupa himself. Rupa always revered Sanatana, the acharya of sambandha, as his spiritual teacher — “Sanatana is the guru of Srila Rupa Gosvami,” says one biography; and Sanatana, as already mentioned, in his commentary on the “Brihad-bhagavatamrita” calls Rupa his beloved servant. The dedication of Sanatana's “Vaishnava-toshani” (“shrimach-chaitanya-rupasya prityai…”) can be understood in two ways: “for the pleasure of Sri Krishna Chaitanya” or “for the pleasure of Srila Rupa Gosvami,” at whose bidding this commentary was written. Sanatana's literary contribution to the Gaudiya sampradaya is comparable only with that of Rupa and Raghunatha Dasa.

Raghunatha Dasa

Raghunatha Dasa lived for sixteen years in Puri with Mahaprabhu, in the care of Svarupa Damodara. When both had departed, he came in grief to Vrindavana to see the feet of Rupa and Sanatana one last time and then throw himself from Govardhana. The brothers spoke with him at length and held him back: his body was dedicated to Mahaprabhu's service and would yet fulfil many of His desires. They accepted him as their “third brother,” kept him always with them, and were themselves enriched by hearing from him the nectarean accounts of Mahaprabhu's pastimes. So being accepted by Rupa and Sanatana saved Raghunatha from perishing in separation. Rupa's two best servants were Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami and Jiva Gosvami.

The songs about Raghunatha Dasa say that he is “non-different from Rupa”; and when Rupa and Sanatana disappeared, “his eyes went blind,” and, not seeing Rupa and his companions, he wept; after Sanatana's departure he drank only water, and after Rupa's departure he gave up even water. Raghunatha himself says at the end of the “Mukta-charita” that he wove this bouquet at Jiva's bidding, following the full instruction of Sri Rupa. There is also a tradition: reading Rupa's “Lalita-madhava,” a drama of separation, Raghunatha Dasa sank into such an ocean of separation that people began to fear for his life. Seeing this, Rupa wrote the short, merry “Dana-keli-kaumudi,” full of jests, gave it to Raghunatha and took back the “Lalita-madhava”; having read the new book, Raghunatha forgot his separation.

Raghunatha Bhatta

Mahaprabhu told Raghunatha Bhatta, the son of Tapana Mishra, not to marry, but after his parents' death to go to Vrindavana and, under the shelter of Rupa and Sanatana, perform bhajana all eight praharas of the day, following in Rupa's footsteps and studying the “Bhagavatam” and other scriptures

under their guidance; and so he did. When he came to Vrindavana, Rupa and Sanatana were overjoyed and embraced him lovingly. He gave himself into their care and every day in a sweet voice read the “Bhagavatam” to them — in Rupa's assembly, “the assembly of the king of the Vaishnavas of the whole world” (shri-shri-vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha) — and, overwhelmed by prema (tears, trembling, a faltering voice), sometimes had to break off the reading:

“Later, at Sri Chaitanya's bidding, he went to Vrindavana and stayed there to live, taking shelter of Sri Rupa Gosvami. Raghunatha Bhatta read the ‘Srimad-Bhagavatam’ aloud for Sri Rupa Gosvami. And so, by the mercy of Sri Chaitanya, he became intoxicated with divine love for Sri Krishna.” (CC, Adi 10.157–158)

Gopala Bhatta

Gopala Bhatta, at his parents' behest, came straight to Vrindavana and settled with Rupa and Sanatana (“Karnananda,” 5th niryasa; “Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.163–165). The brothers already knew that he would come and received him as a brother; from then on a lifelong friendship bound them. Rupa was just about to send word to Mahaprabhu in Puri with some devotees, and the brothers informed the Lord of Gopala Bhatta's arrival. The Lord, delighted, replied: “Regard Bhatta Gopala as your younger brother, look after him with love and from time to time send Me good news”; and with His answer He sent Gopala Bhatta the signs of renunciation — a dor, a kaupina and an upper garment.[57]

Gopala Bhatta was very close to Rupa and Sanatana; Rupa held him as dear as his own life and entrusted him with the service of Radha-ramana. Hearing that Krishna had mercifully appeared to Gopala Bhatta as Radha-ramana from a shalagrama, Rupa and Sanatana with other devotees at once came for darshana and with tears of love beheld this world-enchanting Deity; Gopala Bhatta invited Rupa, Sanatana and the other Gosvamis to a great festival of the Deity's abhisheka — on the Vaishakha full moon of 1599 Samvat (1542 CE).[58] Together with Rupa and others Gopala Bhatta restored the lost holy places of Vrindavana. And the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa,” as the book itself says (1.2), was compiled by Gopala Bhatta, a disciple of Prabodhananda, to please Raghunatha Dasa, Rupa and Sanatana.

Jiva

Jiva, having studied the scriptures in Kashi under Madhusudana Vachaspati, came to Vrindavana, took full shelter of Rupa and Sanatana and studied under them the whole “Bhagavata” and the scriptures on bhakti; both gurus entrusted him with revising their works.

The “Bhakti-ratnakara” tells of “Rupa's mercy to Jiva”: when Jiva had out-argued the scholar Vallabha Bhatta, Rupa gently reproached him and sent him away for a time, and then, at Sanatana's intercession, accepted and blessed him again.[59] This is a lila of instruction, not worldly anger or punishment: thus Rupa taught his disciple humility. As for the interpretation that Rupa cast Jiva off, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta rejects it (see below and the article on Jiva Gosvami).

Another incident, of which Srila Bhaktisiddhanta writes, was this. A certain digvijayi, thirsting for worldly fame, obtained from Rupa and Sanatana a written acknowledgement of victory (jaya-patra): Jiva's gurus yielded to him without debate. The proud man began to revile them as ignoramuses and demanded the same from their disciple; Jiva engaged him in debate, defeated him and silenced the reviler of his gurus (Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, “Anubhashya” on CC, Adi 10.85). Thus Jiva showed what a true disciple should be. Ignorant sahajiyas say that Rupa reproached Jiva for this and banished him for a time, and only Sanatana's intercession restored Jiva to Rupa's company; Srila Bhaktisiddhanta rejects this interpretation: Jiva acted rightly in defending the honour of his gurus. Only by Krishna's mercy, seeing themselves as servants of the guru and the Vaishnavas, will such interpreters understand what it means to be “humbler than a blade of grass” and to “honour others.”

After the departure of Rupa and Sanatana, writes Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, Jiva became the chief teacher of siddhanta, the undisputed head of the Gaudiya sampradaya in Mathura, Bengal and Orissa, and the "prime minister" of the Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha in Vrindavana; he is the best of Rupa's followers and one of the shiksha-gurus of Krishnadasa Kaviraja. And if Jiva, for the good of certain disciples, allowed svakiya-vada in his teaching, he acted as befits an acharya and was no opponent of parakiya-vada.

In the opening verses of his works Jiva remembers Rupa. In the "Madhava-mahotsava" — "my Prabhu Sri Rupa Gosvami, at whose bidding I undertook this work; his mercy is my only support"; in the "Gopala-champu" — "my uncles Rupa and Sanatana, my two Prabhus, who instructed me — may they be my shelter"; in the commentary on the "Brahma-samhita" — "Sri Rupa Prabhu is my only shelter"; in the "Durgama-sangamani" his commentary is a boat for crossing the "Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu," which came forth from Rupa's lips. And in several works a verse is repeated: "He whose elder brother is the venerable Sanatana, like the Eternal, and whose younger brother is Sri Vallabha — that Sri Rupa is the eternal shelter of Jiva."

In the "Tattva-sandarbha" and at the beginning of each of the six "Sandarbhas" Jiva writes: "Glory in Mathura-mandala to Srila Rupa and Sanatana, who inspire me to write this book revealing the truth"; the colophons state that the books were written "by the instruction of Rupa and Sanatana." As the basis of the "Sandarbhas" Jiva names the notes of Gopala Bhatta — a devotee from the South, of a brahmana family, a very close friend of Rupa and Sanatana (according to Baladeva, "the friend of them both"): he had written the book but not put it in order, and Jiva put it in order to please the two saints, Srila Rupa and Sanatana; its content, moreover, is what Sanatana heard from the Lord in Kashi and Rupa in Prayaga.

In the epic poem "Madhava-mahotsava" Jiva, at the end of each of its nine ullasas, honours Rupa as the guru's feet, a form non-different from Krishna. The verse at the end of the first ullasa can be read in two ways: "The Lord, full of compassion, rescued me, long burning in the forest fire of samsara, accepted me as His own and placed me at His pure feet — Him, the great Krishnadeva (or: Rupa, whose chosen Lord is Krishna), I worship here in Vrindavana." The other eight such verses with a translation were printed in the article "Sri Sri Rupanuga-dhara" in the journal "Gaudiya" (20th year, no. 2). In the "Krishna-sandarbha" too Jiva calls Rupa his only shelter: in anuchchheda 178, "my revered feet by which I live" (upajibya-charana) concluded thus the account of the manifest pastimes of Radha and Govinda in the "Lalita-madhava"; and in anuchchheda 189, the eternal pastimes of Radha and Krishna are as described by the "younger brother" of those feet, Sanatana's — that is, by Rupa.

Lokanatha, Narottama and Srinivasa

When Mahaprabhu and His intimates headed by Rupa and Sanatana disappeared, Lokanatha could not bear the separation. Coming again to Vrindavana, he learned that Rupa and Sanatana had already departed, and grieved bitterly; it was then that Narottama came to him.[60] Narottama Dasa Thakura prays in the "Prarthana": "When will my master Lokanatha take me with him and give me to Rupa's feet?"

Narottama Thakura, the servant of Rupa, Raghunatha and Jiva, sang Rupa's greatness "with a million mouths" and chose him as his cherished krishna-prema. He is the first of the later followers of Rupa, the intimate associate of Mahaprabhu; in the eternal pastimes he is Champaka-manjari, who ever assists Rupa-manjari in the service of Radha and Krishna. In his four songs about Rupa-manjari (one of them, "shri rupa-manjari pada…" from the "Prarthana," was much loved by Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati) the feet of Rupa-manjari are Narottama's whole wealth, his bhajana, life, ornament, desired perfection, dharma, vow and japa; he longs for her darshana; "by Rupa's mercy one attains the feet of the Couple," he has heard from the sadhus; he prays to Sanatana and the whole family of Gaura to fulfil his desire, to

Lokanatha to give him to Rupa, and to the narma-sakhis to instruct him. In the third and fourth songs Narottama sees himself as a new maidservant (nava-dasi): Rupa tells her to prepare everything for the service, and she carries to the Couple on a jewelled tray the paraphernalia and a golden pitcher of fragrant water, standing timidly behind Rupa. The Couple, smiling, ask, “Rupa, where did you find this new maidservant?” — and Rupa-manjari answers that Manjunali brought her and gave her, and sets Narottama to service.

On the way to Vraja the weary Narottama dreamed of Rupa and Sanatana: they placed their hands on his chest and fed him milk brought by Mahaprabhu Himself, and his weariness vanished. Reaching Mathura and seeing the Yamuna, Narottama remembered the names of the six Gosvamis headed by Rupa and Sanatana and wept; and in one of his songs he laments: “Where are my Svarupa and Rupa, where are Sanatana, Raghunatha Dasa?..” In another song he sings: “Glory to Sanatana and Rupa — bottomless wells of prema-bhakti-rasa, embodiments of ujjvala-rasa, wish-fulfilling trees! Their books clearly set forth prema-bhakti; they are the shelter of madhura-rasa. Rupa and Sanatana, pierce my heart with the precious arrows of love for Radha and Krishna!”

Mahaprabhu foretold the birth of Srinivasa: “Through Rupa, Sanatana and others I shall reveal the scriptures of bhakti, and through Srinivasa they will be distributed” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 2.120–123). When Srinivasa came to Vraja, Rupa, Sanatana, Kashishvara and Raghunatha Bhatta had already disappeared, while Raghunatha Dasa, Gopala Bhatta and Jiva were still on earth. According to the “Nava-padya” of Nrisimha Kaviraja, Rupa and the others headed by Sanatana said to Srinivasa in a dream: “This is no time to grieve: Gopala Bhatta is here; receive the mantra from him and our books, go to Gauda and preach.”[61] Jiva entrusted Srinivasa, Narottama and Shyamananda with taking to Gauda the books of Rupa and Sanatana, and also of Raghunatha Dasa, Gopala Bhatta and others. And when the robber-king of Vana-Vishnupura, Vira Hambira, opened the stolen chest of the Gosvamis' books, he saw on a palm leaf the name “Sri Rupa Gosvami” — and at the mere sight of Rupa's flawlessly beautiful handwriting the sins of his whole long life flew away, his heart was purified, and krishna-prema awoke in it.

The Rupanugas

Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami in the “Mukta-charita,” proclaiming the incomparable glory of the dust of Rupa's feet, prays: “Holding a straw between my teeth, again and again I beg: may I be, birth after birth, the dust of Sri Rupa's lotus feet.” In the “Sva-niyama-dashaka” and the “Manah-shiksha” he proclaims that to be initiated as a follower of Rupa (a Rupanuga) is the highest, the only goal of the soul's life, and in the “Manah-shiksha” (3) he instructs the whole Rupanuga-sampradaya that wishes to live in Vraja: “If you wish, birth after birth, to live with love in the land of Vraja and serve the youthful Couple, then, O mind, always remember and honour with love Svarupa, Rupa with his companions and his elder brother Sanatana.”

Of the incomparable greatness of following Rupa Raghunatha Dasa speaks many times in other places of the “Stavavali” too: in the “Vraja-vilasa-stava” (38), “Vilapa-kusumanjali” (1, 14, 72), “Sva-niyama-dashaka” (1, 10), “Radha-krishna-ujjvala-kusuma-keli” (44), “Prarthanamrita” (opening verse and 20), “Madana-gopala-stotra” (21), “Vishakhananda-stotra” (134), “Prarthanashraya-chaturdashaka” (4, 10, 11, 14) and “Abhishta-suchana” (1, 2, 13); the “Dana-keli-chintamani,” he says, he wrote by the power of the dust of Sri Rupa's lovely lotus feet. In the opening verse of the “Mukta-charita” he says that by the mercy of his guru Yadunandana Acharya he obtained Svarupa, Rupa and his elder brother Sanatana. Thus the highest acharyas — Raghunatha Dasa, Jiva, Narottama — define themselves by following Rupa.

Krishnadasa Kaviraja begins each chapter of the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” with obeisances to Mahaprabhu and His associates and ends it with a prayer for service at the feet of Rupa and Raghunatha:

“Praying for mercy at the feet of Sri Rupa and Sri Raghunatha, I, Krishnadasa, narrate this ‘Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita.’” (CC, Adi 1.110)

Kaviraja is honoured as the best of Rupa's followers. Vishvanatha Chakravarti followed Rupa's example, going to live in Vrindavana for the sake of bhajana, and with detailed commentaries explained Rupa's confidential works on rasa, difficult for ordinary people: his “Ananda-chandrika” is a commentary on the “Ujjvala-nilamani,” and he also commented on the “Vidagdha-madhava.” The Vaishnavas speak of three of his works — summaries of Rupa's books, the “Ujjvala-nilamani-kirana,” the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu-bindu” and the “Bhagavatamrita-kana”: “kirana, bindu, kana — with these three you will become a Vaishnava.” Govinda Kaviraja composed songs on shanta, dasya, sakhya, vatsalya and madhurya following Rupa's “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” and “Ujjvala-nilamani.”

The shiksha-guru-parampara from Mahaprabhu to Vishvanatha, according to Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, is this: Mahaprabhu — Svarupa Damodara — Rupa and Sanatana (with Raghunatha Dasa, Raghunatha Bhatta and Gopala Bhatta) — Jiva — Krishnadasa Kaviraja — and so on. This Madhva-Gaudiya succession in the spirit of Rupa was not broken even in “periods of darkness”: acharyas may be solitary (viviktanandi) or preachers (goshthyanandi).

Baladeva Vidyabhushana served Rupa's Govinda in Jaipur and was therefore called “Govinda-dasa.” Troubled by the dispute with the Ramanandis, at Vishvanatha's bidding he went to the temple of Sri Govinda, Rupa's Deity, told Him everything and in a dream received from Govinda the command to write a commentary on the “Vedanta-sutra” which He Himself would approve; the “Govinda-bhashya” is dedicated to Govinda and named after Him. From the date in his commentary on the “Stavamala” it is clear that he lived after the battle of Plassey (1757). In the “Prameya-ratnavali” he bows to Shyamasundara, Chaitanya, Vyasa, Rupa and Sanatana, “risen like two moons.” On Rupa's books he wrote the “Stavamala-vibhushana” (a commentary on the “Stavamala”), a commentary on the “Nataka-chandrika,” the “Saranga-rangada” (a commentary on the “Laghu-bhagavatamrita”) and a commentary on the “Utkalika-vallari” (1686 Shaka, 1764 CE). “Our Teachers” calls his works a treasure offered at the lotus feet of Sri Rupa: thanks to Baladeva the Rupanuga-sampradaya took final shape as an independent tradition.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati considered the dust of Rupa's feet the chief thing in his life and often said that he desired nothing else. He taught: many fools think that teaching through books, as Rupa, Sanatana, Jiva and Raghunatha Dasa did, or accepting many disciples, as Madhva, Ramanuja and Narottama did, is an obstacle to sadhana and a worldly entanglement; this is a delusion. Some Rupanuga Vaishnavas say that Prabodhananda inclines to the svakiya doctrine and do not care to read his books, considering Rupa's parakiya-vada higher; one biography, following Narahari Chakravarti, declines to enter this dispute.

Acharyas of the Nineteenth and Twentieth Centuries and the Rupanugas

Jagannatha Dasa Babaji is called in a verse of obeisance “the best of Rupa's followers,” and his teaching, according to Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, accords with Rupa's. Bhaktivinoda Thakura is “the best of the Rupanugas”; his svarupa is Kamala-manjari, a maidservant of Rupa-manjari, the head of Lalita's retinue. In June 1868 Bhaktivinoda visited the house of Rupa and Sanatana in Ramakeli, and in Puri he studied the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” in detail. In the “Sajjana-toshani” (8.9) he denounced the pseudo-Vaishnavas who, reviling Nityananda and Mahaprabhu, invent false accusations of association with women against the faultless Rupa Gosvami, Ramananda and others, and so deceive the world. And

Srila B. R. Sridhar Maharaj, in the “Srimad-Bhaktivinoda-viraha-dashakam” (9), his hymn to Srila Bhaktivinoda, glorifies the service of Radha's feet, approved by Gauranga, understood by Svarupa, honoured by Sanatana, Rupa's elder brother, distributed by Rupa and others, tasted by Raghunatha and the other followers of Rupa, guarded by Jiva and others and revered by Shuka, Shiva and Brahma.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati worshipped Govardhana with the hymns of Rupa and Raghunatha and constantly repeated the words of Rupa's first “Govardhanashtaka” — “Govardhana, fulfil my hope” (pratyasham me tvam kuru govardhana purnam) — and those of Raghunatha: “Govardhana, grant me a dwelling near you” (nija-nikata-nivasam dehi govardhana tvam). During a journey to Vrindavana, on 3 October, he had the darshana of Rupa's beloved Deities, Radha-Govinda. He began a commentary on Rupa's “Upadeshamrita” but stopped after eight verses, and lectured on the “Upadeshamrita” in Vraja. In Prayaga, around 1924–1925, he pointed out the exact place where Rupa received Mahaprabhu's teachings; at the Purna-kumbha-mela in January 1930 he installed at Triveni the Deities of Radha-Govinda, “the life and soul of Sri Rupa,” and spoke of the teachings given to Rupa; on 21 November 1932 the Sri Rupa Gaudiya Math was founded in Prayaga (Allahabad), and on 30 December 1935 he spoke there again of the teachings given to Rupa; and in the mid-1930s he found in Mathura the place where Rupa came for the darshana of Gopala.

The followers of Rupa, he wrote in his letters, do not preach faith in their own strength but attribute everything to the source of strength: “we do everything for the sake of Sri Krishna Chaitanya, Sri Rupa, Bhaktivinoda and our guru.” His last instructions: preach the message of Rupa and Raghunatha; the highest goal is to become dust at the feet of Rupa's followers; our essence is a speck of dust at Sri Rupa's feet birth after birth; may the current of Rupa's ideas flow through the world; Narottama accepted the understanding of Rupa and Raghunatha. His sayings: the followers of Rupa do not trust in their own strength; the intimate devotee longs only for service to Rupa's followers; the one desire is the dust of the feet of Rupa, who embodied on earth the desires of Chaitanya; may this institution of Rupa's followers be ever engaged in service. Bhaktisiddhanta himself is glorified as “the destroyer of unorthodox teachings contrary to the conclusions of Rupa and his followers,” “the best of the followers of Svarupa and Rupa,” through whom flows the current of Svarupa, Rupa and Bhaktivinoda; “be a servant of the followers of Svarupa and Rupa,” say the verses dedicated to him, and service to the gopis and Gopinatha in them follows Rupa-manjari.

His disciple Bhakti Dayita Madhava Gosvami is called “dear to the followers of Rupa”; Srila Bhaktisiddhanta told his disciples to preach the message of Rupa and Raghunatha together, and the commentary of Srila B. R. Sridhar Maharaj on the gayatri is called a contribution to the Rupanuga-sampradaya.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's guru, Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji, told him to give up all other occupations and devote his life to preaching the message of Sri Rupa and Sri Sanatana; and it was for him, says “Our Teachers,” to spread the teaching of Sri Rupa not only in India but all over the world. On the eve of his departure he wished to hear Narottama's song “Sri Rupa-manjari-pada” — the hymn of the Gaudiya Vaishnavas in which the whole siddhanta, the highest mood of devotion and the special position of Srila Rupa Gosvami are expressed — and not from a brahmachari with a beautiful voice but from Srila B. R. Sridhar Maharaj: “I do not need beautiful singing.” His godbrothers saw in this the transfer to Sridhar Maharaj of the authority of acharya of the Rupanuga-sampradaya. Nishkinchana Krishnadasa Babaji considered the writings of Sridhar Maharaj non-different from the scriptures of Srila Rupa Gosvami, and of his “Sri Sri Prema-dhama-deva-stotram” he said that Srila Rupa Gosvami himself, the head of Mahaprabhu's succession, is present in it.

Srila A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupada, having withdrawn from worldly affairs, settled in Vrindavana, in the temple of Sri Sri Radha-Damodara, founded, in the words of “Our Teachers,” by

Srila Rupa Gosvami (according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” Rupa himself revealed the Deity of Radha-Damodara and gave Him to Jiva; Rupa's samadhi is there as well), and there he began translating the “Srimad-Bhagavatam.” The very name “Krishna consciousness” he took from a verse included in Rupa's “Padyavali” — krishna-bhakti-rasa-bhavita (“imbued with the taste of devotion to Krishna”); Krishnadasa Kaviraja quotes this verse too:

“The sweetness of bhakti, revealed in an individual relationship with Krishna, cannot be attained even by performing pious deeds for millions of births in succession. Only one thing is needed — an ardent desire to obtain such unalloyed devotion without delay, wherever it may be found.” (CC, Madhya 8.70; “Padyavali,” 14)

Bhaktivedanta Swami applied to perfection the principle of yukta-vairagya, renunciation in devotion, formulated by Rupa: to accept all that is favourable to service and reject what is unfavourable, engaging everything in Krishna consciousness according to the directions of the shastras and the acharyas. And Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, following the principle of true renunciation proclaimed by Rupa, introduced daiva-varnashrama into his movement.

Srila Sridhar Maharaj, when he began to accept disciples, did not exert himself excessively, for the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu,” in its list of the angas of bhakti, says not to build too many temples or hold large programmes. Srila Govinda Maharaj recalled how, hearing his exposition of the sixty-four angas of bhakti, he wondered: Guru Maharaj preaches widely, collects donations, builds temples — “Rupa Gosvami forbids this”; what will he say? The answer took only a few words: “Everything depends on capacity. One person can rule an empire and still have time for rest. Another wears himself out trying to cope with family cares and still does not succeed.” What is beyond one person's strength is a small thing for another, and each must do what lies within his power.

Works

Rupa's books are listed by three witnesses whom the Gaudiya Vaishnavas trust without reservation. The first is his nephew and disciple Jiva Gosvami. In the conclusion of the “Laghu-vaishnava-toshani” he names the works of “the younger of the brothers”: the poems “Hamsa-duta” and “Uddhava-sandesha,” the “Chhando-’shtadashaka,” the “Utkalika-vallari,” the “Govinda-virudavali,” the “Premendu-sagara” and many other well-known stotras to Krishna; two plays, the “Vidagdha-madhava” and the “Lalita-madhava”; the bhanika “Dana-keli”; the “pair” of books on rasa, the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” and the “Ujjvala-nilamani”; the compilations “Mathura-mahima,” “Padyavali” and “Nataka-chandrika”; and finally the abridged “Bhagavatamrita.”[62]

The second witness is Narahari Chakravarti. He quotes these verses of Jiva in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (1.796–799) and then, taking a list from Krishnadasa Adhikari, a disciple of Jiva (his name stands in the guru-parampara kept in the temple of Radha-Damodara), adds four books that Jiva did not name: the “Krishna-janma-tithi-vidhi,” the greater and lesser “Ganoddesha-dipika” and the “Prayuktakhyata-chandrika.” In the verse list of the same first taranga of the “Bhakti-ratnakara” Rupa's books number sixteen: the “Hamsa-duta,” “Uddhava-sandesha,” “Krishna-janma-tithi-vidhi,” the greater and lesser “Ganoddesha-dipika,” the “Stavamala” on Krishna and His intimates, the “Vidagdha-madhava,” “Lalita-madhava,” “Dana-keli-kaumudi,” “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu,” “Ujjvala-nilamani,” “Prayuktakhyata-chandrika,” “Mathura-mahima,” “Padyavali,” “Nataka-chandrika” and “Laghu-bhagavatamrita.” This count and order are followed in the biographies of Rupa, and the books are taken in the same order below. In Bengali verses (1.811–821) Narahari adds that Rupa wrote sixteen books, showing in them the limits of siddhanta together with lila; the “Lalita-madhava” is the summit of vipralambha, the rasa of separation; the “Dana-keli-kaumudi” (also called “Dana-lila-kaumudi”) is an ocean of bliss; the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” is incomparable, and the

“Ujjvala-nilamani” is full of rasa.

The third witness is Krishnadasa Kaviraja. One of his lists has already been given above, in the account of the brothers' life in Vraja (Antya 4.223–226); the other stands at the beginning of the “Madhya-lila”:

“He devoted a hundred thousand shlokas to the Lord's pastimes in Vrindavana. The chief of Sri Rupa's books are these: ‘Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu,’ ‘Vidagdha-madhava,’ ‘Ujjvala-nilamani’ and ‘Lalita-madhava,’ ‘Dana-keli-kaumudi,’ ‘Stavavali,’ the eighteen ‘Lila-chhandas’ and ‘Padyavali,’ ‘Govinda-virudavali,’ ‘Mathura-mahatmya’ and ‘Nataka-varnana.’ One cannot count all the books of Sri Rupa, such as the ‘Laghu-bhagavatamrita,’ in which he described in detail the pastimes of Vraja.” (CC, Madhya 1.37–41)

“A hundred thousand” is in Bengali “laksha granthas”; a grantha here means a shloka or a stretch of text of a fixed number of syllables. Kaviraja's “Nataka-varnana” is the same as the “Nataka-chandrika,” and the “Stavavali” is the “Stavamala.”

Sometimes the “Upadeshamrita,” the “Namashtaka,” the “Siddhanta-ratna,” the “Kavya-kaustubha” and other books are also attributed to Rupa. The last two were in fact written by Baladeva Vidyabhushana; of the “Upadeshamrita” and of the other attributed works we shall speak below.

“Hamsa-duta”

First in Jiva's list stands the “Hamsa-duta” (“The Swan Messenger”). It is a khanda-kavya — a short poem modelled on one part of a great poem (mahakavya) — and Rupa is held to have composed it before he met Sri Chaitanya. The poem has 142 verses in the shikharini metre (seventeen syllables to the line); so many are in the edition of Jivananda Vidyasagara (“Kavya-sangraha,” part 1, Calcutta, 1888), while the Bengali “Basumati” edition, with a hundred and one verses, is full of errors and not to be trusted. Several old manuscripts survive, and the poem has been printed more than once in Devanagari. Later Rupa himself quoted its verses as examples in the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” (three verses) and in the “Ujjvala-nilamani” (ten).

The subject of the poem is Radha's separation from Krishna. When at Akrura's request Krishna left Nanda's house and went to Mathura, Radha, pining, came with Her friends to the bank of the Yamuna. The familiar kunjas reminded Her of Krishna still more keenly, and She fainted; the sakhis could barely keep life in Her. Seeing Her divine madness (divyonmada), Lalita notices a white swan floating on the Yamuna and decides to send it to Krishna — to tell Him how Radha is and bring Him back to Vraja. She describes the way to the swan: the kadamba by the ghata where Krishna stole the gopis' garments, the place of the rasa-lila, Govardhana, the head of the asura Arishta, the Bhandira tree, the place of Brahma's prayers, the pool of Kaliya, Vrinda-devi, the forests full of the cries of peacocks — and the beauty of Mathura, capital of the Yadavas, the rapture of its women at the sight of Krishna, His chambers and the service rendered to Him, His form from feet to face. The swan should speak of the maidens of Vraja when the cuckoo sings or the scent of jasmine drifts by: let it remind Krishna of all that delighted Him in Vrindavana and tell Him that in Mathura, captivated by the service of the townspeople, He has grown cold to the simple wealth of the forest and to the forest maidens.

Let the swan tell Him also of Radha's burning separation, of Kubja's good fortune, of how Radha worships Parvati and Shiva for the sake of meeting Krishna, and of how in adhirudha-mahabhava She at times takes Herself to be Krishna. Uddhava, whom Krishna had sent to console the gopis with knowledge of the Paramatma, only deepened their grief; a disciple of Brihaspati, a minister absorbed in affairs of state, while the Yamuna, sister of Yama, has become as merciless as her brother — neither will tell Krishna how the gopis suffer — so there remains only the guileless white swan. Lalita recounts to it Radha's laments in Her divine madness, speaks of her own ardent wish to see the Divine Couple together again in Vrindavana and to serve Them, addresses Krishna's forest garland, His makara

earrings, the Kaustubha gem and His conch, praising their good fortune and asking their sympathy, and bids the swan convey the gopis' loving anger to Krishna in the guise of a tale of the ten avataras — Matsya, Kurma and the rest. In these verses (128–137) Rupa, through Lalita and the double meanings (shlesha) of loving anger, shows that the son of Nanda is the source of all avataras and the shelter of all; this is the essence of Gaudiya Vaishnava philosophy and the hidden secret of vraja-bhajana. The poem ends with an entreaty: the swan can separate milk from water — surely it will feel the grief of the maidens of Vraja, fly to Mathura and carry out its errand.

The opening verse of the poem is an obeisance to Shyamasundara:

“Clad in garments brighter than powdered orpiment, His feet redder than hibiscus flowers, dark of body like the tamala, a playful smile on His face — may He appear in my heart.” (“Hamsa-duta,” 1)

In the penultimate verse Rupa praises Sanatana: wholly loving Bhagavan, ever serving the “Bhagavata,” turned away from worldly rasa from birth, full of the sweetness of bhakti, known as “Sakara,” first among heroes — he is like the son of Vyasa, Shukadeva. The last verse is a prayer for the poem's fruit: may sensitive rasikas find no flaw in it against rasa, bhava or ornaments of speech, and may it pour dense waves of bliss into the heart of Krishna, friend of the whole world, hero of the pastimes of rasa.

That the poem was written before the meeting with Mahaprabhu is seen from two signs: its opening has no obeisance to Sri Krishna Chaitanya, and Sanatana is called in its conclusion by his court name, “Sakara Mallik.” Some propose to read instead of “viditah sakarataya” (“known as Sakara”) a supposedly corrupted “viditah sat-kavitaya” (“known for good poetry”), but the reading “sakarataya” is given by many manuscripts and several printed editions; the commentary in Jivananda's “Kavya-sangraha” explains it as “by the nobility of his family.” This verse also refutes the inventions of scholars who trust only their own experience (adhyakshika): that Sakara Mallik was formerly attached to the world and only circumstances brought him to renunciation, or that Dabir Khas and Sakara Mallik, living among mlechchhas, adopted their ways and lost caste. These offensive opinions are fabricated from beginning to end. Sanatana here is a stranger to worldly rasa from birth, wholly surrendered, full of prema and, like Shukadeva, the crown of paramahamsas, first among the heroes of knowledge, bhakti and renunciation. Thus the “Hamsa-duta” testifies that Rupa and Sanatana are eternally perfect associates of Bhagavan, not worldly men who came to renunciation later.

More wonderful still: the truth that the rasa of meeting is not nourished without separation, and all the states of Radha's adhirudha-mahabhava that Shachinandana, having taken Her feeling and radiance, would display — all this Gaurahari awakened in Rupa's heart even before, in the outward lila, Rupa came to the shelter of His feet, and Rupa expressed it in this short poem. Already here the hidden secret of krishna-bhajana is revealed: the only desirable service of a sakhi is service to the meeting of Radha and Govinda; desire for one's own enjoyment is no sign of krishna-prema; the heart is given to the ashraya-vigraha, the abode of love, and above all to Radha, crown of such abodes; vraja-lila is higher and more wonderful than the lila of the cities (pura-lila); bhajana is performed in the mood of separation. No worldly poet, however skilled in the rasa-shastras, could express such conclusions about transcendental separation; there is nothing like it in Kalidasa and the other poets who sing of the world. This is one more sign that Rupa is an eternal associate of the Lord.

Two commentaries on the “Hamsa-duta” are known: by Gopala Chakravarti and by Madhu Mishra, son of Ananda (or of Purushottama). The second is described in the catalogue of the Madras Government Oriental Manuscripts Library, and its colophon calls it Madhu Mishra's commentary on the “Hamsa-duta” composed by “Rupa and Sanatana.”

“Uddhava-sandesha”

The second poem is a mirror of the first. In the “Hamsa-duta” Lalita, on behalf of Radha, crown of heroines, sends a swan from Vraja to Mathura; in the “Uddhava-sandesha” Krishna Himself, crown of heroes, sends Uddhava, Brihaspati's disciple, from Mathura to Vraja to console the gopis suffering in separation. It is also called “Uddhava-duta,” but “Uddhava-sandesha” — “the message Uddhava carries” — is more exact: it is Krishna's own message. The basis of the plot is this: angered by the arrogant words of Kamsa that Akrura had conveyed, Krishna left Vraja for Mathura, lived there for a time and sent Uddhava to console the gopis, Nanda, Yashoda and all the Vrajavasis and to tell them about Himself. The title and subject come from the “Bhagavatam” (10.46.2–3), where Krishna in private takes Uddhava by the hand and sends him to Vraja to gladden His parents and with His message to ease the gopis' pain of separation.

The poem opens thus: from the roof of His pleasure palace Krishna gazes at Mathura, beautiful with blossoming trees — and suddenly, deeply stirred, remembers the forests of Gokula. Overwhelmed by prema at the thought of the love of the beauties of Vraja, He chooses Uddhava, first among His close friends, as messenger, explains that He went to Mathura out of anger at Kamsa's words, says that Radha is His dearest and that She, Lalita and the sakhis barely bear the burden of life, holding on only by His consolations, and bids Uddhava revive Radha, bitten by the serpent of separation, with the mantra of His message. The forest of Vraja is dearer to Him than anything, and even its unmoving dwellers, down to the trees, are wasted by separation from Him; the memory of even the shadow of His trouble pains the gopis more than their own troubles the size of Mount Sumeru. Krishna describes the road and the places of His pastimes, recalls the past at each and sinks into prema; when Uddhava's chariot reaches the slopes of Nandishvara, He says, Radha's friends will think Krishna Himself has come.

Uddhava is given errands: to bless the trees of Vraja, to ask after the welfare of the cows, to bow to the old cows as to mothers, to embrace the cowherd friends as His representative, to bow to Nanda and Yashoda, and to introduce himself to the gopis as “Krishna's counsellor in matters of love”; to console Chandravali, Vishakha, Dhanya, Shyamala, Padma, Lalita, Bhadra, Shaibya and the others, and to give Radha, crown of the maidens of Vraja, wasted by separation, His vaijayanti garland to bring Her back to consciousness. The two concluding verses are benedictions: may the “Uddhava-sandesha” again and again pour streams of joy into the hearts of the devotees of the Lord who delights in His pastimes in Vraja, who dances in Mathura out of guileless love and whose lotus feet are Rupa's shelter; and may the young, merciful Lord, who played in childhood with Shridama and others, performed the rasa-lila with the young gopis and slew many demons in play, carry the readers across the ocean of worldly existence.

When the poem was written it does not say; neither the opening nor the concluding verses contain Krishna's name or an obeisance to Him. But in one of the last verses Rupa names himself (“rupashraya-pada,” “the feet that are Rupa's shelter”) and with the word “svami” his master, Sanatana or Krishna. The name “Sri Rupa” could not have been there before the meeting with Sri Chaitanya, and so the poem is assigned to the time after the meeting.[63] It has 131 verses in the mandakranta metre (seventeen syllables); it was printed in Devanagari in the “Kavya-sangraha” edited by Haeberlin and in Jivananda Vidyasagara's “Kavya-sangraha” (part 3, Calcutta, 1888). Rupa quotes verses of the “Uddhava-sandesha” as examples in the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” (Uttara 5.7) and many times in the “Ujjvala-nilamani.”

“Krishna-janma-tithi-vidhi”

Jiva calls this book “The Rule for Krishna's Birthday” (“Krishna-janma-tither vidhih”); its full title is “Krishna-janma-tithi-mahotsava-vidhi,” and it is also known as “Krishnabhisheka.” The compilers of one of the biographies obtained one manuscript in Vrindavana and saw another, old one with Banamali Lala Gosvami. In the opening verse Rupa bows to the two Lords of Vrindavana and says that he records the rule for Krishna's birthday according to the shastras and custom — “at the command of prabhu.” The

plural of respect here points to Sanatana: the book was written at his special command. Rupa speaks of Sanatana in the plural of respect — “prabhupada,” “prabhu” — in other openings as well, and in the “Padyavali” (verse 233; in some manuscripts, instead of “shrimat-prabhunam,” it says outright “to the feet of Shrimat Sanatana Gosvami”).

The rules of the Janmashtami vow are set out in detail in the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” (15.133–240): the obligation of the vow, its origin and greatness, the harm of neglecting it, the determination of the day (with the Rohini nakshatra, the “midnight” Janmashtami, the prohibition of a day touched by Saptami), the breaking of the fast, the morning sankalpa, the birth chamber and the whole puja — from bathing to the arghya to the moon, the worship of Devaki and Krishna and the prayer. Why, then, did Sanatana bid Rupa write another book? Either Rupa compiled a brief rule before the detailed rules entered the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa,” or he wrote the book later to describe specially the mahabhisheka on Krishna's birthday. Comparing the topics of the two books, a thoughtful reader will see the particular features of each. In Rupa's book it is thus: on the eve, on Saptami, the platform for the bathing is cleansed, a pit is dug in the courtyard, banana posts are set at the corners, with an awning and flags; on the morning of Janmashtami the Deity is carried with kirtana and dance to the platform adorned with lamps and pots, with umbrella and chamara; then come the svasti-vachana, the bhuta-shuddhi, the installation of the pot, the sankalpa, the puja, the bathing and abhisheka in various ways with mantras, the offering of the sacred thread, betel and garlands, the maha-niranjana and a stotra to Krishna. The day is spent with Hari's intimates, glorifying Govinda with Vedic and Puranic hymns; at midnight comes the auspicious abhisheka for the birth and a vigil with song and dance; in the morning, the great festival of the king of Vraja, the Nandotsava, and the honouring of mahaprasada with the Vaishnavas.

The other rules of the vow Rupa directs to be taken from the “Bhavishyottara-purana” — on which the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa,” too, bases the origin of the vow (Yudhishthira asks, and Krishna tells) — while he himself describes in detail, with the applied mantras, only the abhisheka, more fully than the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa”; hence the book's second title. The concluding verses say that this rule of bathing Krishna on His birthday is set out in the mood of Vraja according to the Tenth Canto of the “Bhagavatam”; whoever performs it will become dear to Govinda, be filled with deep prema and serve Him ever directly in Vrindavana. The colophon of the Vrindavana manuscript names Sri Rupa Gosvami as the author.

“Ganoddesha-dipika”

The full title of the book is “Sri Sri Radha-Krishna-ganoddesha-dipika,” “The Lamp Pointing Out the Associates of Radha and Krishna.” Why it is needed is explained by a well-known verse: the object of worship is the son of the king of Vraja together with His abode Vrindavana, and the highest way of service is the one shown by the maidens of Vraja. Those who walk the path of raga follow Krishna's ragatmika associates and their manner of service, and for that one must know all the members of His family. In our own nature (svarupa) we are Krishna's eternal intimates, and our eternal relationship is with His family; without knowing it one cannot be established in sambandha, abhidheya or prayojana. But this knowledge must be heard and realized from the lips of a transcendental guru — with an ear turned towards service, a pure heart and transcendental faith.

The sadhus of old lovingly mentioned the names of Krishna's associates and facts about them briefly, like sutras; all this was kept in tradition and in the shastras. Rupa, as he says, gathered these facts from the traditions of Mathura-mandala, from the shastras, Puranas and Agamas and from the words of saintly devotees, and arranged them — for the joy of his friends and to lay out the path of raga in order (“Ganoddesha-dipika,” 3–5). The book also contains direct references, for example to the “Adi-purana,” the “Garuda-purana” and the “Sammohana-tantra.” Krishna's family are the Vrajavasis, and the book gives the names, appearance, qualities, retinue and service of all its members and their branches. The

family is divided into cowherds (pashupala) of the Yadu line, brahmanas (vipra) and artisans (bahishtha); the cowherds into vaishyas who live by milk, abhiras who tend calves and buffaloes, and gurjaras who tend goats; and by the kind of relationship with Krishna into eight classes: revered elders, brothers and sisters, female messengers, servants, artisans, maidservants, friends of His own age and beloveds. Also described are the groups (yuthas), garments, ornaments, umbrellas, couches, canopies, kunjas, houses, carts and mounts of Radha-Krishna and Their retinue, the nature of the eight sakhis, their arts, bhavas, gatherings and much else; from the “Sammohana-tantra” two more groups of eight sakhis of Radha are given.

The book has two parts, a greater and a lesser. The greater (“Brihad-ganoddesha-dipika”) opens with obeisances to the feet of the guru with the devotees, to Chaitanya, who appeared together with Nityananda, to the son of Nanda with the gopis and Vrajavasis, and to the feet of Radhika. At its end (250–252) it says: the associates of the Lords of Vrindavana are countless, only a pointer is given here, and the rest — couches, food, drink, betel, swings, tilaka and so on — the wise will learn from the shastras and from the guru; knowledge of the names and forms of Krishna's associates had almost vanished, but Rupa's sight, illumined by Bhagavan's mercy like a lamp, beheld these names full of rasa. The last verse gives the time: the book was “lit” in the house of Nanda, king of Vraja, in 1472 Shaka (1550 CE), in the month of Shravana, on a Sunday, on the shashthi. The lesser part describes Krishna's form, qualities, sweetness and ages, His friends of every degree — companions, well-wishers, priya-sakhas and priya-narma-sakhas — Baladeva, servants, messengers male and female, Paurnamasi, Vrinda, Nandimukhi, His cows, deer, peacocks and parrots, the places of His pastimes — ghatas, hills, lakes, trees — and then Radhika: the marks on Her palms and soles, Her beauty, Her relatives and friends — the priya-, prana- and nitya-sakhis and the manjaris — Her worshipful deity, Her cows, heifer, doe, swan, myna, ornaments, flower garden, raga, dance and birthday. It too ends by pointing to the countlessness of the associates (250); in some manuscripts the closing verse of the greater part is repeated in the lesser, and the penultimate verse names the same year 1472 Shaka.

Attempts have been made to dispute Rupa's authorship of the book. The first argument: if it was written in 1550, why does Jiva not name it in the “Laghu-toshani” (1582)? But Krishnadasa Kaviraja in his list does not name the “Hamsa-duta” and “Uddhava-sandesha” either, nor quote a single verse from them, though he could not have been unaware of them: he quotes the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” and “Ujjvala-nilamani” abundantly, where both poems are cited more than once. Nor can one say that he omitted them as written before Rupa came to the Lord: their siddhanta fully agrees with Rupa's rasa-shastras, or Jiva would not have named them either, and in the conclusion of the “Uddhava-sandesha” (verse 130) Rupa calls himself by name — “shri-rupashraya-pada” — so the poem was certainly written after the meeting with the Lord. Nor is there any “copper-plate decree” obliging every later author to name all the books of his predecessor: the four books of Rupa that Jiva did not name could well have been mentioned by another, later witness.

The second argument: the opening of the “Brihad-ganoddesha-dipika” names Nityananda, whereas nowhere else, not even in the three “Chaitanyashtakas,” does Rupa name Him explicitly. This argument is weak. Karnapura in the “Chaitanya-chandrodaya-nataka” names neither Gopala Bhatta nor Jiva, while in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” he names both and speaks of their position in Vraja; and in the openings of Jiva and Raghunatha, too, Nityananda is not named explicitly. The “Ujjvala-nilamani” has no obeisance to Mahaprabhu, though in the earlier “Vidagdha-madhava,” “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” and “Lalita-madhava” He is specially glorified: Rupa received the subject of the “Ujjvala-nilamani” in Prayaga, briefly, “in sutras,” by the power of Gaurasundara's mercy, and in the second opening verse he says that here he unfolds the confidential truths of madhura-rasa told briefly in the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu”; Jiva says the same in the “Lochana-rochani.” A mind relying on empirical

knowledge alone does not penetrate such matters, and to declare the book someone else's because of Nityananda's name is to destroy one's own understanding.

The third argument: after verse 246 the names of Radhika's sakhis are given from the “Sammohana-tantra,” whereas Rupa supposedly never refers to tantras elsewhere. But he does refer to them by name: in the “Laghu-bhagavatamrita” to the “Sammohana-tantra,” the “Satvata-tantra” and the “Bhargava-tantra,” in the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” to the “Vaishnava-tantra” and simply to “the tantra,” and likewise in the “Ujjvala-nilamani.” Such arguments against the authenticity of Rupa's books are constructions of those to whom the realm of the acharyas is closed; they must be examined impartially, by hearing through succession (shrauta).

“Stavamala”

The “many stavavalis” of which Kaviraja speaks (Madhya 1.39) are the “Stavamala,” “The Garland of Hymns,” compiled by Jiva. In his introduction Jiva says that he, insignificant, wholly dependent on Rupa — his chosen master, the author of the “Rasamrita” — has strung his stotras into a garland, and gives the order: stotras to Chaitanya, to Krishna, to Radhika and to the Divine Couple; then the “Virudavali”; the pastimes from the Nandotsava to the slaying of Kamsa in various metres; figured verses; songs (the “Gitavali”); and finally stotras to Lalita, the Yamuna, Mathura, Govardhana, Vrindavana and the names of Krishna.

The “Stavamala” contains forty-nine works. It opens with three “Chaitanyashtakas.” Then come stotras to Krishna: the “Mahanandakhya-stotra,” “Lilamrita-nama-dashaka,” “Premendusagara” (a hundred and eight names of Krishna), “Keshavashtaka,” two “Kunjaviharyashtakas,” “Mukundashtaka,” “Vraja-nava-yuvaraj-ashtaka,” “Pranama-pranaya-stava,” “Hari-kusuma-stavaka,” “Gatha-chhandah-stava,” “Tribhangi-panchaka,” two untitled verses — on self-surrender and on the bonds of hope — and the “Mukunda-muktavali.” To Radha are dedicated the “Ananda-chandrika” (ten of Her names), “Premendusudhasava” (a hundred and eight names of Vrindavaneshvari), “Radhashtaka,” “Prarthana-paddhati,” “Chatu-pushpanjali” and “Gandharva-samprarthana-ashtaka”; to the Divine Couple the “Radha-Krishna-nama-yugala-ashtaka,” the “Vraja-navina-yuva-dvandva-ashtaka” with a verse of meditation, the “Karpanya-panjika-stotra,” the “Utkalika-vallari” and two verses on the night's-end (nishanta) pastimes. Next come the “Govinda-virudavali” with many kinds of viruda metres, the eighteen pastimes in metres (“Ashtadasha-chhandah”), the “Govardhanoddharana,” further accounts of the stealing of the garments and of the rasa-lila, the “Svayam-utprekshita-lila,” “Khandita” and “Lalitokta-totashtaka,” twelve figured verses (“Chitra-kavitvani”: of two letters and of one, in the shape of a wheel, a serpent, a lotus and so on), the forty-two songs of the “Gitavali” and finally the “Lalitashtaka,” “Yamunashtaka,” “Mathurashtaka,” two “Govardhanashtakas,” “Vrindavanashtaka” and “Krishna-namashtaka.” In different editions (Nirnaya-Sagara, 1903; Baharampur) a number of works are titled or divided differently.

When the Lord withdrew, Rupa, crushed by separation, constantly remembered and sang of His pastimes; they are preserved in the “Chaitanyashtakas,” where every verse ends with the same plea: “Will that Chaitanya come again before my eyes?” The time of one stotra Rupa gave himself: the “Utkalika-vallari” was written while he lived in Gokula, in the month of Pausha, 1471 Shaka (at the turn of 1549 and 1550). How the “Govinda-virudavali” came about has been told above in Baladeva Vidyabhushana's words; Rupa used many of its virudas as examples in the “Samanya-virudavali-lakshana.” In the table of its kinds (kalikas) are virudas of short and long syllables named “achyuta,” “utpala,” “tilaka,” “turanga,” “purushottama” and others, “manjaris” of three kinds, tribhangis, and mixed and prose kalikas.

The “Chhando-’shtadashaka,” “Eighteen Metres,” is named both by Jiva at the end of the “Laghu-toshani” and by Kaviraja (“the eighteen lila-chhandas”). The second verse of the “Nandotsavadi-charita” says that the great pastimes of Hari from the Nandotsava to the slaying of Kamsa are told in eighteen elegant metres: the Nandotsava; the slaying of Shakata, Trinavarta and other childhood pastimes; the yamala-arjuna trees; the herding of the calves; the stealing of the calves by Brahma; Talavana; the subduing of Kaliya; the pastimes in Bhandiravana; the pastimes of the rainy season and autumn; the stealing of the garments; the mercy to the brahmanas' wives; the abduction of Nanda by Varuna; the rasa-lila; the deliverance of Sudarshana; the song of the gopis; the slaying of Arishtasura and others; the pastimes in Kamsa's arena. These eighteen stotras Jiva included in the “Stavamala.” Baladeva Vidyabhushana wrote a commentary on them and at its end asks that Krishna, Rupa and the sadhus be pleased with it. The figured verses of the “Stavamala,” with their definitions, are quoted by Jiva in the “Bhakti-rasamrita-shesha” and by Baladeva in the “Sahitya-kaumudi.”

At the end of every song of the “Gitavali” the name “Sanatana” stands as the signature (bhanita), and some consider it Sanatana's work, citing the “Dashama-charita” in the list of his books (CC, Madhya 1.35). But Baladeva at the end of his commentary calls these songs Rupa's work.[64] The songs are in the gatha metre, with ten anushtubh verses added; their themes are the Nandotsava, Vasanta-panchami, the Dola-yatra and the rasa-lila, and within it the marks and examples of the eight kinds of heroine. For each song a raga is given — ashavari, karnata, kalyana, kedara, gaudi, dhanashri, bhairava, mallara, ramakeli, lalita, vasanta, saurashtri — while the tala (ekatali) is named only twice.

Into the “Padyavali” Rupa took verses from the “Govinda-virudavali,” from the “Chhando-’shtadashaka” (on the herding of the cows and calves) and from the “Mathurashtaka.” Of the “Chatu-pushpanjali” and of the first “Govardhanashtaka,” whose verse Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati constantly repeated, we have spoken above.

“Vidagdha-madhava”

The “Vidagdha-madhava” is a play in seven acts on Krishna's vraja-lila. The marks of transcendental separation and meeting of hero and heroine that Rupa would later describe in the “Ujjvala-nilamani” he shows here through the pastimes of his chosen Deities, Radha and Govinda, and the “Ujjvala-nilamani” draws many examples from the play. The acts are titled: “The Play of the Flute's Sound,” “The Love Letter,” “Meeting with Radha,” “The Stealing of the Flute,” “Radha's Grace,” “Autumn Pastimes” and “Pastimes at Gauri's Shrine.”

Of the verses of benediction (nandi) that open the play, and of how Rupa read them in Puri, we have spoken above. The play itself, as the sutradhara says in the first act, was written at a command received in a dream from Bhagavan Shankaradeva, the bhakta-avatara; Vishvanatha Chakravarti explains in his commentary that this is Gopishvara, who dwells on the bank of Brahma-kunda. At Gopishvara's command the play was also presented to an assembly of scholars from many lands. These are his words: “The life of these devotees, in whom separation from Mukunda has awakened, is ready to leave the body. Save them by revealing the river of the nectar of His pastimes; my mercy will gather for you all that is needed.”

Some, not understanding these words, raise objections: what separation is meant, if the play was being written in the Lord's presence? But separation from Mukunda is the natural trait of the Gaura-bhaktas who follow Rupa: they are always steeped in the rasa of separation. Besides, the Gosvamis sometimes revised their books long years afterwards. Jiva writes in a letter quoted in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (14.19) that some corrections still remained in the “Rasamrita-sindhu,” the “Madhava-mahotsava,” the “Uttara-champu” and the “Harinamamrita”; he finished the “Uttara-champu” in 1592, while the “Madhava-mahotsava” is dated 1555 — so he was still revising his own book thirty-seven years later.

Rupa, too, could have inserted these words during a revision.

Another objection from those who trust empirical knowledge alone: by the date at its end the play was completed in the year of Mahaprabhu's departure, while Kaviraja writes that the Lord Himself heard its verses — how can his account be true? The answer is simple: often most of a book is written at once and the remainder, for particular reasons, long afterwards; so it was with many mahajanas. Most of the "Vidagdha-madhava" was written in Mahaprabhu's presence, and He Himself relished it with Ramananda Raya and others; this is also indicated by Svarupa Damodara's words to the Bengali poet about Rupa's two plays, which refer only to their opening:

"The two beautiful plays of Sri Rupa Gosvami are an example of this. Merely on hearing their opening alone, all the devotees feel the highest happiness." (CC, Antya 5.108)

In the year of Mahaprabhu's departure Rupa wrote the remainder, finished the revision and then put the date; to begin so large a play after the Lord's departure and finish it in the same year would have been impossible. The account that Kaviraja, Rupa's undivided servant, recorded from Raghunatha Dasa's words must not be declared a "poetic fiction" on the strength of the conjectures of modern scholars.

The characters of the play: Nanda, king of Vraja; Krishna, the hero; Balarama; the friends Shridama and Subala; Madhumangala, companion and jester (vidushaka); Abhimanyu, son of Jatila; the sutradhara — Rupa Gosvami himself — and his assistant (pariparshvika), a disciple of Rupa. The female roles: Yashoda, queen of Vraja; Radhika, the heroine; Her sakhis Lalita and Vishakha; the messenger Vrinda; Paurnamasi, mother of the muni Sandipani and disciple of Narada; Nandimukhi, Madhumangala's sister; Jatila; Mukhara, Radhika's maternal grandmother and Yashoda's nurse; Sarangi, a sakhi of Radhika; the old gopis Karala and Karalika; Chandravali, a group-leader (yutheshvari), and her sakhis Padma and Shaibya.

The "Vidagdha-madhava" reveals one of the secrets of Gaudiya Vaishnava siddhanta. Paurnamasi explains how the group-leaders Radhika and Chandravali, deceiving Abhimanyu, Jatila's son, Govardhana, the overseer of Kamsa's cows, and others, always delight Krishna: for the sake of this deception Yogamaya Herself made everyone believe in the appearance of their marriages, whereas they are Krishna's eternal beloveds ("Vidagdha-madhava," 1.24–25).

The play ends with three verses: Rupa calls on the learned to study the "Vidagdha-madhava," full of Sri Radha's pastimes and separation and adorned with the sixty-four arts; names the time and place of completion — Sri Gokula, at the close of 1589 Samvat (1532 CE);[65] and humbly says that as stars of feeble light adorn the night, so the peaceful, exalted bhagavatas turn even a heap of faults into virtues. The manuscript collection of the shripata of Gopivallabhapura holds a Bengali copy of the play on sixty-six leaves, made in 1657. Yadu-nandana Thakura, a disciple of Hemalata Thakurani, composed an elegant Bengali verse rendering of the play, the "Rasa-kadamba."

"Lalita-madhava"

The "Lalita-madhava" is a play in ten acts. The first four depict the sweet pastimes of Vrindavana, but from the fifth to the tenth the pastimes of Dvaraka are mingled with them, and so the play is considered devoted to dvaraka-lila. Rupa explains the title in the conclusion: here Hari, who captivates the mind of Kamadeva himself, by His own free will did not display the lofty (udatta) heroism befitting the heroes of plays, and by His pastimes took on the "lalita"-bhava — a playful, graceful mood.[66] The acts are titled: "The Evening Festival," "The Slaying of Shankhachuda," "Radhika Maddened," "Radha's Tryst," "Chandravali Found," "Lalita Found," "Meeting in the New Vrindavana," "Pastimes in the New Vrindavana," "Gazing at the Picture" and "Desires Fulfilled."

Like the “Vidagdha-madhava,” this play Rupa wrote at the command, given in a dream, of Gopishvara Shiva, who dwells on the bank of Brahma-kunda. At its beginning, in the role of the sutradhara, he relates that at the festival of Dipamalika, during the worship of Govardhana, he read the play to an assembly of Vaishnavas gathered to the east of the temple of Madhavi-Madhava on the bank of Radha-kunda, and pleased them; the command he had received in a dream from Gopishvara, crowned with the crescent moon, great lord of the land by Brahma-kunda adorned with lotuses, knower of the rasa of the vow to live by the bowers of Vrindavana (1.3). The opening of the play is a wish for the Vaishnavas' joy, an obeisance to Krishna, a mention of Gopishvara's command, a prayer for Gaura's mercy (“may the son of Shachi grant me good”), a confession of his own unworthiness, and praise of Sanatana Gosvami:

“He who once appeared in the world as the third of the perfected ones — Sanaka and the others — to instruct the paramahamsas, has now descended to place in the hearts of the bhaktas the whole secret of bhakti-rasa with all its parts. To him, the complete teacher of the world, obeisance.” (“Lalita-madhava,” 1.7)

So Rupa calls Sanatana an avatara of the four Kumaras and the teacher of the world (vishva-guru).

In the first act, in a conversation between Gargi and Paurnamasi, Rupa reveals a special secret: the semblance of Radha's marriage to Abhimanyu is only an appearance created by yogamaya;[67] otherwise how could a lowly man take the hand of Radha — a vaijayanti garland woven of the flowers of Mount Vindhya's austerities, enriched with the nectar of Brahma's blessing, a nectar of sweetness that softens Madhava's heart (1.25)? In the plot of the play, two daughters, famed in the three worlds, were born to Vindhya by Brahma's blessing. Among the eight great shaktis full of sweetness — Radha, Chandravali, Lalita, Vishakha, Padma, Shaibya, Shyamala and Bhadra — these two are especially renowned as the abode of all virtues and as group-leaders. At Brahma's request Yogamaya transferred the girls from the wombs of the wives of Vrishabhanu and Chandrabhanu into the wombs of Vindhya's wives; Putana, the stealer of children, brought Vrishabhanu's daughter to Gokula, while Vindhya's elder daughter fell into a river flowing into Vidarbha and was found by Bhishmaka, king of Vidarbha. And the marriages of Chandravali and the others to the cowherds headed by Govardhana are only an appearance: the cowherds who fancy themselves husbands are left with nothing but the feeling “mine,” for even to see these girls is almost impossible for them (1.44).

In the fifth act, through Narada, Rupa briefly reveals also the secret of how the queens of Dvaraka are related to the maidens of Vraja: in essence they are one but different in body, and only in the interval, by the power of the same yogamaya, did they become as if quite other. The beauties of Vraja are still in Vraja, overwhelmed by prema; but Yogamaya, to give them even in separation the joy of their Beloved's company, gave them the sense of being the queens of the city, and they experienced this as in a long dream; while the sixteen thousand one hundred and eight queens whose deeds will be described at the pilgrimage to Kurukshetra are others. “Enough of revealing this secret,” Narada concludes (5.5).

The penultimate verse of the play gives the time and place: 1459 Shaka (1537 CE), the month of Shukra (Jyeshtha), the fourth tithi, a Sunday; Rupa, bowing to Hari, completed it in Bhadravana. There are many more characters here: besides the dwellers of Vraja — Uddhava, Narada, Garuda, Sunanda, Bhishmaka, Shankhachuda, Vishvakarma, Suparna; among the female roles — Rohini, Kundalata, Madhavi, Nava-vrinda, Sukanthi, Tulasi, Malati, Pingala, Vindhyavasini (Ekanamsha), the doorkeeper Kanchuki, Bhargavi, Gargi, Bakula and others. There is a Bengali verse rendering of the play, the “Prema-kadamba,” made in imitation of the “Rasa-kadamba”; it is not known that Yadu-nandana himself translated the “Lalita-madhava.”

Both plays, the “Dana-keli-kaumudi” and Rupa's rasa-shastras are beyond the reach not only of the ordinary human mind but even of the empirical judgement of extraordinary people: one who is in the grip of lust, anger and the other enemies will not, by learning alone, touch even the shore of these transcendental oceans. Therefore many who fancied themselves panditas, not grasping the meaning of the plays, fell into confusion — especially over the Lord's words to Rupa: “Do not try to take Krishna out of Vrindavana, for He never wishes to go beyond it” (CC, Antya 1.66; see above). The true resolution was given by Bhaktivinoda Thakura in an article, “Remarks on the Plays ‘Vidagdha-madhava’ and ‘Lalita-madhava’”; he did not publish it in his lifetime, and it was printed later in the journal “Gaudiya” (year 20, no. 6).

“Dana-keli-kaumudi”

The “Dana-keli-kaumudi” is a one-act play of the bhanika type, one of the minor dramas (uparupaka). According to the “Sahitya-darpana” of Vishvanatha Kaviraja (6.308–313), a bhanika has elegant costumes, two junctures of action (sandhi) — opening and conclusion — the kaishiki and bharati styles, one act, an exalted heroine and an excellent hero, and seven parts; Rupa's book comes still closer to the marks of a bhanika in Sharadatanaya's “Bhava-prakashana”: its subject is the deeds of Hari, its chief rasa is shringara, dance and song are subsidiary, and it is full of witty jests.

In the introduction Rupa wishes the Vaishnavas good from Radha's glance and victory for Her love for Krishna; the sutradhara speaks of Vaishnavas overwhelmed by prema in the valley of Mount Nandishvara: the lovers' quarrel of Nanda's son draws even the atmaramas away from the bliss of brahman. The opening verse of the bhanika has a double meaning: it glorifies Krishna, whose name attracts the knowers of rasa, whose conduct increases the joy of Nanda and of the sadhus, whose beauty bestows festivity, whose body is eternal (“sanatana”) — and at the same time “my master,” whose tongue is drawn by the holy name (“rasajna” means both “knower of rasa” and “tongue”), whose nature gladdens the sadhus, who gives festivity to Rupa and bears a body named “Sanatana,” that is, Sri Sanatana (11).

The plot is this. Vasudeva, wishing good to Balarama and to his friend's son Krishna, son of the king of Vraja, began a sacrifice in the forest, appointing as his representative Bhaguri, Gargi's son-in-law. Radha and Her friends, with the elders' permission, carried fresh ghee (haiyangavina) to the sacrificial pavilion by Govinda-kunda. Paurnamasi had informed Krishna beforehand through Nandimukhi, and at Govardhana Krishna, posing as a toll collector (dana), demanded the toll from Radhika and Her friends; at the end Paurnamasi, acting as mediator, arranged a fitting payment. The characters are Krishna, Madhumangala, Arjuna, Subala, Ujjvala, the sutradhara and an actor, and among the female roles Radha, Lalita, Vishakha, Champakalata, Chitra, Nandimukhi, Vrinda and Paurnamasi. The dana-lila, the toll pastime, is described in this bhanika in detail.

Before the end Paurnamasi prays to Krishna in two verses. In the first she asks Madhava ever to play at the crossing with Radhika, best in virtues, surrounded by Her friends, and with His jesting companions; in the second she says:

“Madhava, who by Your merciful glance fulfil the desires of all the dwellers of Vrindavana! He who lives in a hut on the bank of Radha-kunda, having given up all other affairs, and longs for direct service to You Two — quickly make the tree of his longing bear fruit.” (“Dana-keli-kaumudi,” 114)

So Rupa points to Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami. The two concluding verses say that the bhanika, which gives joy to the sadhus, was woven at the command of “my dear friend” — may it adorn the bank of his kunda even for a moment — and written when Rupa lived at Nandishvara; the commentary that in the Baharampur edition is circulated as Jiva Gosvami's explains that the “dear friend” is Raghunatha Dasa, who lives by Radha-kunda.

The year in the last verse is given in number-words (“manu-shata,” “chandra,” “svara”); by the rule “figures are read from right to left” this is 1471 Shaka, that is, 1549 CE. Another reading would give years when Rupa was a child and Raghunatha Dasa had not yet appeared or was an infant; Raghunatha appeared in 1506, and by 1549 his request is quite possible.[68] That the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu,” completed in 1541, quotes verses of the bhanika does not stand in the way: Rupa could have been writing both books at once and quoted verses from the finished part of the bhanika (the printed edition has 414 sections, and the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” quotes sections up to the 117th), finishing it afterwards. Following Rupa's bhanika, Raghunatha Dasa wrote the “Dana-keli-chintamani” and says in it that “the blind one” gathered this gem only by the power of the dust of Rupa's feet. This also answers the question whether the bhanika was written before Raghunatha came to the Lord, since it has no obeisance to Sri Chaitanya. Aufrecht's catalogue mentions a commentary on the “Dana-keli-kaumudi” by a certain “Raghunathadasa” (whether this is the same Raghunatha is unknown); the “Padyavali” has three verses under Raghunatha Dasa's name. Of the tradition that Rupa wrote this merry bhanika to draw Raghunatha out of the ocean of separation we have spoken above.

“Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” and “Ujjvala-nilamani”

The “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” (“The Ocean of the Nectar of Bhakti-rasa”) is the finest ripe fruit of the wish-fulfilling tree of Gaudiya rasa literature, the scientific shastra on bhakti-rasa; of how the Lord in Prayaga told Rupa to write it, and of its opening verse, we have spoken above. A detailed review of the book was printed in the journal “Gaudiya” (year 12, nos. 47–49). Among its conclusions is that mental service (manasi-seva) is higher than service with physical articles: Rupa gives the example of a brahmana of Pratishthanapura who by mental service attained the company of Narayana in Vaikuntha (1.2.182). According to one biography, in the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” Rupa accepted the path of pushti (grace) of which the early Vallabhacharya, a follower of Gadadhara Pandita, had spoken; the later “pushti-marga” the Gaudiya Vaishnavas did not accept.

The “Ujjvala-nilamani” (“The Radiant Sapphire”) is the scientific shastra on the ujjvala, or madhura, rasa of Krishna, the embodiment of the nectar of all rasas; it unfolds what is said briefly about madhura-rasa in the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” (see above). A review of it was printed in the “Gaudiya” (year 12, nos. 40–41).

“Prayuktakhyata-chandrika”

This book has been sought, and is sought to this day, in Vrindavana and elsewhere, but there is no reliable information anywhere about a manuscript of it. The compilers of one of the biographies, with their guru and senior Vaishnavas, searched for it in the library of the temple at Jaipur (October 1927), in the book collection of the shripata of Gopivallabhapura together with Vishvambharananda Deva Gosvami (11 February 1925), in the library of the Ranganathaji temple in Vrindavana, in the Madras Government Oriental Manuscripts Library and in various shripatas of Bengal and Orissa — the search is not over. Judging by its title, it is, like Jiva's “Dhatu-sangraha,” a special treatise on Sanskrit grammar dealing with the akhyata — verbal forms and the use of roots. Colebrooke mentions a Vaishnava grammar, the “Sri Chaitanyamrita”; Baladeva Vidyabhushana's grammar “Vyakarana-kaumudi” is almost lost (its manuscript was with Radhacharana Vidyavagisha in Vrindavana); and the library of Dacca University holds a manuscript of sixteen leaves attributed to Rupa, the “Sri Harinamamrita-vyakarana-sankshepa.”

“Mathura-mahatmya”

Jiva calls this book “Mathura-mahima,” Kaviraja “Mathura-mahatmya,” Narahari Chakravarti again “Mathura-mahima”: it is a compilation by Rupa of testimonies to the glory of Mathura. It begins with an obeisance to Sri Mathura and the verse: “Hari usually grants liberation, but not bhakti, even to those

who worship Him; to you, Mathura, who have vowed to give this highest gift — obeisance.” Then Rupa says that for the joy of fortunate hearts he gathers the glory of Mathura, crown of all tirthas, and cites testimonies to her purifying power — from the “Adi-varaha” (58.1: Mathura-mandala extends twenty yojanas, and one who bathes anywhere in it is freed from grave sins) and other shastras.

The compilation then proceeds thus: Mathura destroys sins, contains countless tirthas, gives shelter to the shelterless, is attainable only by Bhagavan's mercy, grants liberation, Vishnu-loka and everything desired and is beyond the world; the fruits of residence there at special times — chaturmasya, the Janmashtami of the month of Bhadra, Karttika, Prabodhini, dvadashi, the Bhishma-panchaka; Madhupuri in Madhuvana, Krishna's birthplace, Keshavadeva, Bhuteshvara, Vishranti-tirtha and the twenty-four chief tirthas of the Yamuna; the brahmanas and residents of Mathura; the twelve forests and Govinda in Vrindavana; Brahma-kunda, Keshi-tirtha, the pool of Kaliya; the order of circling the twelve forests, the parikrama of Govardhana and bathing in the Manasi-ganga; Govardhana with Brahma-kunda and the tirthas of Indra, Varuna, Kubera and Yama at the four quarters, Govinda-kunda; and finally the great tirthas and Deities of Mathura — Narayana, Keshava, Svayambhu, Padmanabha, Dirgha-Vishnu, Govinda, Hari and Varaha. Rupa cites the “Adi-purana” most often, but also the “Gopalottara-tapani,” the “Gautamiya-tantra,” the “Padma,” “Brahma-vaivarta,” “Brahmanda,” “Bhavishya,” “Vamana,” “Vayu,” “Varaha,” “Vishnu” and “Skanda” Puranas, the “Bhagavatam,” the “Vishnu-dharmottara,” the “Brihan-naradiya” and others.

The end of the compilation in the old Vrindavana manuscript runs thus: in the “Gopalottara-tapani” still more is glorified, and the Puranas name many tirthas of Mathura, but here only some, known today, are recorded; there follow the colophon, an obeisance to the Yamuna, a wish that by this compilation, the Yamuna's friend, the Enemy of Madhu may be pleased “with me,” and an obeisance to Vrindavana. In the manuscript described by Haraprasad Shastri the obeisances to the Yamuna and Vrindavana and the penultimate verse are absent, and the colophon calls the book compiled by “Shrimad Rupa Gosvami.” These words apparently belong to the copyist: Rupa, the embodiment of superhuman humility, calls himself in the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” and other books “wretched” and “little Rupa” and would never have called himself “Shrimad Rupa Gosvami”; the author's humility is a sign of authenticity, and grand titles in colophons come from copyists. Manuscripts of the compilation also exist at Dacca University (a copy of 1766, with the obeisance to the Yamuna, as in the Vrindavana one), in Jaipur, in the library of the Govindaji temple, and in Gopivallabhapura with Vishvambharananda Deva Gosvami — there they are kept separately from the “Mathura-mahatmya” of the “Varaha-purana.”

Farquhar and some others asserted that Rupa's compilation was later inserted into the “Varaha-purana” as its chapters 152–180; some build conjectures on seeing in the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” (11.260) a reference to a “Mathura-mahatmya” in the “Varaha,” and perhaps misunderstand the CC as well:

“He collected books on the greatness of Mathura and uncovered hidden places of the divine pastimes, wandering through the forests of Vraja.” (CC, Madhya 25.208)

The compilation itself easily refutes this guess. Were it part of the “Varaha-purana,” Jiva and Kaviraja would not have named it as a separate book of Rupa, nor would separate manuscripts of it be found in the libraries of the old Gosvamis of Vraja; moreover, in the “Varaha-purana” the glory of Mathura-mandala fills whole chapters, 152–180, whereas Rupa takes from it only individual verses and cites verses from many other shastras. The wish to make an ancient testimony received through succession “modern” is the work of maya, which, knowingly or unknowingly to them, beguiles those who have turned away from the Lord.

“Padyavali”

The “Padyavali” (“A String of Verses”) is an anthology of verses on Hari and His pastimes: here are mahajanas, contemporaries of Rupa, and ancient “ordinary” poets — Amaru, Umapatidhara, Kshemendra, Bana, Bhavabhuti, Mayura and others. It shows that the worship of Radha-Govinda, the son of Nanda, in various rasas has from time without beginning adorned the lips of the Vaishnava mahajanas and been a subject of verse even for ordinary poets. The first verse explains the design: this “Padyavali,” composed by rasikas, beautiful with words about Mukunda, an ocean of waves of joy dispelling all darkness, is gathered for the pleasure of an assembly of the discerning. After an obeisance to the flute-playing Vanamali, Radha's beloved, and a blessing on the bhaktas come a hundred and twenty-four sections: Krishna's greatness, the glory of bhajana, prema, the glory of the holy name, krishna-katha, meditation, the devotees — their humility, entreaties, longing and disregard of liberation — the glory of Mathura and Vrindavana, Nanda and Yashoda, Krishna's childhood and boyhood, Radha's purva-raga, trysts and the kinds of heroine, the stealing of the flute, the lifting of Govardhana, the boat pastime, the rasa, Krishna's disappearance, the water pastimes, the eternal lila, the departure to Mathura, Radha's lament, messages through Uddhava, Krishna's separation in Dvaraka, Sudama, Kurukshetra.

In the conclusion Rupa says that besides verses of Jayadeva, Vishvamangala and others, other verses too are gathered here. Vishvamangala's “Krishna-karnamrita” Gaurasundara brought from the south, and Jayadeva's “Gita-govinda” circulated as a book anyway; but the verses of poets and mahajanas not collected in books were scattered or passed from mouth to mouth among devotee-rasikas with good memories, and Rupa set them in order. In some manuscripts and editions one more verse is added at the end — an entreaty to a wish-fulfilling tree like a young tamala, in blossoms of radiant ujjvala-rasa, surrounded by the protectresses of Gokula.

Some suppose that the “Padyavali” was compiled before Rupa met the Lord, since it has no obeisance to Gaura. But it includes the “Shikshashtaka” (under the name “Sri Bhagavatah”), a verse of Sanatana (under the name “Shrimat-prabhunam”), verses of Raghunatha Dasa and Gopala Bhatta — among them a verse on chanting the holy name — verses of Raghupati Upadhyaya that Rupa heard at Adaila (his complete verse on the highest rasa is no. 82), verses of Ramananda Raya and Karnapura, and two verses of a certain Manohara (274–275); so it was compiled after the meeting with Mahaprabhu. The CC proves this especially clearly (Madhya 1; Antya 1): the verse “priyah so ’yam,” which entered the “Padyavali,” was composed already by Gaura's mercy (on the numbering of the verse see above).

“Nataka-chandrika”

The “Nataka-chandrika” (“Moonlight of Drama”) is a treatise on dramaturgy: Rupa wrote it to bring together the definitions, examples and subjects of both his plays. Almost all the marks of drama are present in the “Lalita-madhava,” so the examples for them are almost always taken from it (some hundred and seventy-five times; from the “Vidagdha-madhava,” only a few). At the beginning Rupa says that he has studied the shastra of Bharata Muni and the fine “Rasa-sudhakara” of Shingabhupala and sets out the definition of drama very briefly, while for the most part not accepting the method of the “Sahitya-darpana,” as little suited to practice and contrary to Bharata.

The book examines the marks of drama; the three kinds of hero (divine, mixed and earthly); the three kinds of plot (known, invented and mixed); the three kinds of nandi (benediction, obeisance, indication of the subject); the prologue, the five elements of the plot, the five stages of action, the five junctures (sandhi) with their subdivisions, the thirty-six ornaments, the kinds of stage speech (aloud, aside, in confidence), the act and the interpolated act (garbhanka), the rules for Sanskrit and the Prakrits and the four styles (vritti) — with definitions and examples of which style suits which rasa. There is no concluding verse; the colophon calls the author “Srila Rupa Gosvamipada, the best of the teachers of the Gaudiya Vaishnava sampradaya, whose poetry is fragrant in the forest of the hearts of sadhus, first

among the dear associates of Bhagavan Chaitanyadeva.” The compilers of one of the biographies saw an old manuscript of the book copied in Bhaktivinoda Thakura's own hand.

Besides his own plays and the “Padyavali,” Rupa quotes in the book verses from the “Dasha-rupaka,” the “Rasa-sudharnava,” the “Kamsa-vadha,” the “Keshava-charita,” the “Vira-charita” and the “Hari-vilasa,” and opinions of “others,” “some” and “the teachers”; the “Dasha-rupaka” and the “Rasa-sudhakara” he names also in the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” and the “Ujjvala-nilamani.” Verses of both plays and of the “Padyavali” are in the “Nataka-chandrika,” but not one from the “Dana-keli-kaumudi”; so it was written after the two plays and the “Padyavali” but before the bhanika, the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” and the “Ujjvala-nilamani.” In the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” (4.9.22) Rupa says that the styles, “the mothers of drama,” are described in “the marks of drama” — and Jiva in the “Durgama-sangamani” explains: “in his own work, the ‘Nataka-chandrika.’” The definition of pravartaka that Kaviraja gives is also from the “Nataka-chandrika”:

“When the characters appear in the play separately and at the proper time, this is called pravartaka.” (CC, Antya 1.135)

Many definitions from the “Nataka-chandrika” are also cited by the commentary on the “Lalita-madhava” that some attribute to Jiva Gosvami.

“Laghu-bhagavatamrita”

The conclusions that Sanatana set out at length in narrative form in the “Brihad-bhagavatamrita,” Rupa set out briefly in the “Sankshepa-bhagavatamrita” and, out of humility and in respect for his elder brother's book, called it “the lesser” — the “Laghu-bhagavatamrita” (so Kaviraja too calls it). It is a special handbook of the concepts of the whole “Bhagavatam” and the Puranas, in which every conclusion is established by the testimony of shabda. In the introduction Rupa says that he sets out briefly what “the lotus feet of Shrimat Prabhu,” that is, Sanatana, unfolded in the “Bhagavatamrita”; that this amrita is twofold — by relation to Krishna and by relation to His bhaktas — and the “Krishnamrita” is served to the friends first; and that, giving up attachment to lengthy reasoning, he accepts of all the pramanas the chief one, shabda, for Vyasa in the “Vedanta-sutra” by the sutra “shastra-yonitvat” (1.1.3) recognized the sole authority of revelation and by the sutra “tarkapratishthanat” (2.1.11) rejected reasoning as having no foundation.

Four verses of benediction glorify Sri Krishna Chaitanya — the avatara who purifies the Kali-yuga, who bestows love for Krishna's name and is worshipped in nama-sankirtana together with His associates (“krishna-varnam tvishakrishnam,” “Bhagavatam” 11.5.32) — the sound of Krishna's flute and Krishna's name: may the maha-mantra of thirty-two syllables that came from Sri Chaitanya's lips plunge the world into prema. The book is divided into the “Krishnamrita,” an examination of Krishna's forms and avataras, and the “Bhaktamrita,” on the supreme value of worshipping His intimates and on the grades of bhaktas. A description of it was printed in the “Gaudiya” (year 18, no. 46). Rupa relies above all on the “Bhagavatam,” and also on the “Padma,” “Vishnu,” “Brahmanda” and “Skanda” Puranas, the “Vishnu-dharmottara,” the “Brahma-samhita,” the “Hari-vamsha,” the “Mahabharata,” the “Brahma-sutras,” the “Gita,” the “Gopala-tapani,” the tantras and pancharatras, the “Brahma-tarka” and the words of Shridhara Svami.

Eleven Verses on the Eightfold Lila

According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (1.818–819), Rupa, at the wish of a certain Vaishnava, composed eleven verses on the eightfold (ashta-kaliya) lila — a treasure for the fortunate — and gave them to Krishnadasa Kaviraja to expand. In some manuscripts these verses are called “Ashta-kalika-shlokavali” or “Smarana-mangala-ekadasham.” In the Baharampur edition of the “Govinda-lilamrita” three of them

are verses 3, 4 and 10 of the first sarga, and the rest open sargas 2, 5, 8, 19, 20 and 21; individual words of the last two verses coincide with part of the first verse of the 22nd sarga. Haraprasad Shastri describes a manuscript of the “Smarana-mangala” of thirty-five verses with the colophon “thus ends the ‘Smarana-mangala,’ the ‘Ashta-kalika-shlokavali’ on Radha-Krishna, composed by Shrimad Rupa Gosvami”; the Bangiya Sahitya Parishad holds a manuscript of eleven verses. The report of the “Bhakti-ratnakara” is confirmed by Kaviraja himself at the end of the “Govinda-lilamrita”: he wrote this sequence of the eightfold pastimes of Radha and Her Lord following the path shown by Sri Rupa (23.54).

“Samanya-virudavali-lakshana”

Listing Rupa's books, Kaviraja names the “Govinda-virudavali,” and Narahari Chakravarti adds that Rupa also briefly composed its “marks” (lakshana) but did not include them in the count of books: the example for them is the “Govinda-virudavali” itself, and the two form one whole. Baladeva Vidyabhushana in the introduction to his commentary on the “Govinda-virudavali” likewise says that the author himself composed the “marks of a virudavali” and that, having studied them, the reader will understand the “Govinda-virudavali” fully; there he also sets out how a general virudavali differs from the “Govinda-virudavali,” and quotes many verses of the “Lakshana.”

Rupa begins the book with an obeisance to Krishna — the highest bliss, lord of the forest of Vrindavana — and promises to set out briefly the marks of a virudavali: it contains kalikas, verses and virudas of various kinds, shines with the glorification of the hero's fame, might, valour and beauty, has verses at the beginning and end of the kalikas, is free of faults and is composed in a sonorous, rich style; its composer must be learned, steady of mind and free of envy, and both composer and reader must be devotees of Krishna. The main content of the book is the marks, kinds and examples of the kalika, the shloka and the viruda. Rhythmically ordered words are called “kala,” a group of kalas a “kalika” (no more than sixty-four kalas and no fewer than twelve); syllables are combined by five rules, each with short and long syllables, ten kinds in all; at the beginning and end of a kalika stand verses on the hero's virtues, and the description of these virtues poets call a “viruda.” Of earlier authors are named “some,” Bhujageshvara Pingala and Shanmukha; almost all the examples Rupa took from his own “Govinda-virudavali.” The conclusion of the book: Vasudeva, praised with a fine virudavali bearing all the marks, rejoices and bestows mercy, but one who glorifies Him with a virudavali lacking the proper marks Hari does not accept, however well he may recite. Following this book and the “Govinda-virudavali,” Jiva Gosvami wrote the “Gopala-virudavali,” and Vishvanatha Chakravarti the “Nikunja-keli-virudavali.”

“Upadeshamrita”

The “Upadeshamrita” (“The Nectar of Instruction”) is a little book of eleven verses in which instructions on bhajana, from the stage of the sadhaka to perfection, are set out in good order. Its first verse:

“That steady person who can restrain the urge of speech, the urge of the mind, the urge of anger, the urge of the tongue, the urge of the belly and the urge of the genitals can instruct the whole world.” (“Upadeshamrita,” 1)

A similar verse is found in the “Mahabharata,” in the instruction of Brahma, who had taken the form of a golden swan: one who withstands the urges of speech, mind, anger, the desire to retaliate, the belly and the genitals I consider a true brahmana and muni (Shanti-parva 305.14).

Then, in order: six tendencies hostile to bhakti — overeating or hoarding, excessive endeavour, idle talk, wrong adherence to rules, association with those averse to God, and fickleness and greed; six

favourable ones — enthusiasm, confidence, patience, performing the limbs of bhakti (hearing, chanting and the rest), giving up bad company and following the conduct of the sadhus; six kinds of association with sadhus that nourish bhakti; the proper treatment of Vaishnavas of the beginning, middle and highest stages; the prohibition of looking at a Vaishnava with a worldly eye; the way of remembering Krishna's name and the rest; the way of bhajana, the place of residence and the conduct of the practitioner; a comparison of places of bhajana and the pre-eminence of Sri Radha-kunda; in the tenth verse, that among practitioners the highest is one who has taken shelter of Radha-kunda, and in the eleventh, its glory. To restrain the six urges is the essence of a true tridandi-gosvami.

Rupa's poetics, plays and teaching on the ornaments of speech are prized and discussed by the prakrita-sahajiyas and ordinary men of letters for the sake of enjoyment, but the “Upadeshamrita” enjoys no such esteem; some even doubt that Rupa wrote it. The reason is that it teaches the actual practice of pure bhakti — the sacrifice of the six urges and of all other desires. Yet it is an indispensable beacon on the path of pure bhakti: where it is unknown, ignorance and weakness obscure the understanding of the essence and practice of bhakti.

Bhaktivinoda Thakura brought the “Upadeshamrita” from Vrindavana and published it in the ninth year of the “Sajjana-toshani” (1898) with the Sanskrit commentary “Upadeshamrita-prakashika” by Radharamana Dasa Gosvami of the Radha-ramana temple and his own Bengali commentary, the “Piyusha-varshini-vritti.” At its end he writes that he composed it for the joy of Shrimad Gosvami Banamali, the happiness of the devotee Prabhunatha and the prosperity of his own abode of bhajana, as a resident of Sri Godruma, on the bright ashtami in the year 412 of the Gaura era, and dedicates it to “the moon of Godruma.” The manuscript was given to him by Pandita Banamali Lala Gosvami, who had it copied for the purpose from the old book collection of his family. The compilers of one of the biographies met him in that collection in Vrindavana on 28 October 1940; he told them that Bhaktivinoda, on reading the verses of the “Upadeshamrita,” was so amazed and delighted that he placed the manuscript on his head and, trembling with prema, in a faltering voice, said again and again that it would bring the world immeasurable good. Bhaktivinoda, who considered the book a priceless treasure for the true servants of Hari, also made a verse rendering of it (“Sri Upadeshamrita-bhasha”), set it to songs in the “Bhajana-lalasa” section of the “Sharanagati,” in the graceful tripadi metre, and in the 10th–11th years of the “Sajjana-toshani” (1898–1899) wrote, on the basis of the second and third verses, twelve articles on the six things favourable and the six unfavourable to bhakti.

One edition with a translation into Brajabhasha (Vrindavana, 1924) attributes the “Upadeshamrita” to Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami, but Banamali Lala Gosvami firmly confirmed that it is Rupa's work. It is called Rupa's work also by a manuscript in the collection of Vishvambharananda Deva Gosvami at Gopivallabhapura and by Rajendralal Mitra. Mitra, it is true, describes under this title an instruction of Rupa to Jiva Gosvami in forty-three verses, with the colophon “thus ends the ‘Upadeshamrita’ composed by Shriman Rupa Gosvami”; the first and last verses there are the same as in the Vrindavana manuscript, and nothing is known of the “extra” verses. Neither the Vrindavana manuscript nor the edition of the Radha-ramana temple has them: everywhere the “Upadeshamrita” is eleven verses.

Obeisances to Gaura and Sanatana

An obeisance to Sri Gaurasundara is found in Rupa's books at the beginning of the greater “Ganoddesha-dipika,” in the three “Chaitanyashtakas,” in the second nandi verse of the “Vidagdha-madhava,” in the opening of the “Lalita-madhava,” in the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” (1.1.2), in the “Padyavali” (the verses of the “Shikshashtaka” and, in some manuscripts, other verses signed “Sri Bhagavatah”) and in the opening of the “Laghu-bhagavatamrita.” Sanatana Rupa remembers in the “Hamsa-duta” (“Sakara”), in the “Krishna-janma-tithi-vidhi” (“at the command of prabhu”), in the “Gitavali” (his name at the end of the songs), in the “Lalita-madhava” (1.7), in the

“Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” (1.1.3, 5), in the “Padyavali” (“Shrimat-prabhu”) and in the opening of the “Laghu-bhagavatamrita.” For Rupa, Sanatana is an avatara of the Kumaras and the teacher of the world; and in the opening verses of his books Rupa remembers Gaura, Sanatana and Raghunatha Dasa.

Works Attributed to Rupa

Besides the books described, attested by Jiva, Kaviraja, Narahari Chakravarti and Krishnadasa Adhikari, many other works are attributed to Rupa; in Aufrecht's “Catalogus Catalogorum” and some other books certain hymns of Jiva and Raghunatha Dasa are also wrongly ascribed to him. The catalogue of the Madras Government Oriental Manuscripts Library (1927) lists under Rupa's name the “Ekanta-nikunja-vilasa” (a hymn on Radha and Krishnachandra in a secluded bower: one who reads it every night with concentrated mind will gain friendship among Radha's friends), the “Panchashloki” (its first verse is the fifth verse of the “Upadeshamrita,” its last an entreaty to Krishna that by the mercy of Lalita and others the author may be allowed to fan Him), the “Premandha-stava” (“though I am a vessel of offences, I await Your mercy — be merciful to me, Madhava”), the “Ujjvala-chandrika” (a conversation of Radhika with Lalita on the nature of love for Krishna) and the “Vaishnava-puja-vidhana” — an order of worship from the remembrance of Radha-Krishna and meditation on the siddha-deha to arati according to the rule of the “Brahmanda-purana” (four times at the feet, twice at the navel, once at the face, seven times around the whole body) and sprinkling with water from the conch. The colophons of all these manuscripts name Rupa as the author.

Rajendralal Mitra describes a “Gangashtaka” and a “Sadhana-paddhati” attributed to Rupa. The “Gangashtaka,” written in the same metre as the “Yamunashtaka” of the “Stavamala,” is a hymn to Sri Ganga-devi, the daughter of Nityananda Prabhu; the “Sadhana-paddhati” is a hundred verses with prose on the method of sadhana to Radha-Krishna: to meditate on the guru, a follower of Shachinandana, His beloved servant, serving him, with his permission to meditate on the earlier teachers, and by Sri Chaitanya's mercy, the guru's word and the holy name to go to Vraja; its last verse is about Vilasa-manjari. Manuscripts of a “Sadhanamrita” (in Kathavate's report, 1904) and a “Shiksha-dashaka” (in Roth's Tübingen catalogue) are also mentioned. The Bengali journal “Sri Nityananda-dayini” (1870s) printed a “Sahasranama-stotra” of Sri Krishna Chaitanya Mahaprabhu “spoken by Shrimad Rupa Gosvami” — Raghunatha Dasa asks Rupa about the Lord's names, and Rupa tells of the reason for Gaurasundara's appearance and of His thousand names — as well as a “Navadvipashtaka” (its fruit is rare prema for Shachinandana's feet) and a “Vrindavanashtaka” (one who lives in Vrindavana free of attachments will attain rati and play with Him who is clad in yellow). The “Gadadhara-pandita-gosvami-dashaka,” supposedly composed by Rupa, was taken from a manuscript of the Madras library and printed in the “Gaudiya”; Gopivallabhapura holds copies of an “Upasana-vidhi” (1853) and a “Prema-samputa” “that came from the lips of Sri Rupa” (1684). Also attributed to Rupa are a “Hare-Krishna-maha-mantrartha-nirupana,” “Tulasyashtaka,” “Vrinda-devyashtaka,” “Nanda-nandanashtaka,” “Vrindavana-dhyana,” a “Sri Sanatanashtaka” (where Sanatana is praised as the ornament of the line of the royal brahmanas of the south, grandson of Mukunda-deva, son of Kumara-deva, elder brother of Rupa and of Vallabha, Jiva's father) and others; in some catalogues Rupa's well-known books appear under other titles.

The prakrita-sahajiyas, for their part, in order to connect their invented teachings, contrary to the Rupanugas, with Rupa's name, vainly ascribe to him several Bengali books of recent date; such books are ascribed also to Jiva and to Krishnadasa Kaviraja, but to the seeker of truth it is clear that the acharyas of the rasa of pure bhakti could not have written them. The “Pancha-rasikas” and other sahajiyas also tell various legends about Rupa, the founder of the siddhanta of pure bhakti; the servants of the true Rupanugas accept them with special caution.

Songs in Praise of Rupa

Songs too were composed about Rupa. In one of them, signed by Radhavallabha, it is sung: no one proclaimed Gaura's moods as Rupa did; through him the world learned that Vrindavana is the eternal supreme abode, the son of Nanda the source of all avataras, Radhika the first and most revered of His beloveds, and the sakhis Her retinue; whoever has realized this on the path of raga has realized it by his mercy. Having received Sri Chaitanya's command and studied the “Bhagavatam,” Rupa drew from it the treasures of the siddhanta of bhakti, made them into his books and gave living beings the chintamani of prema; in plays, songs and verses on the rasa of Radha-Krishna he established the pure view of parakiya, established on earth Sri Chaitanya's innermost desire and tasted its sweetness; and at the end the song speaks of the cruellest anguish in separation from Sri Chaitanya — of raving and lament.[69]

Two other songs are signed “Madho.” If Rupa had not taken a body in the Kali-yuga, the first sings, who would have opened the storehouse of the treasure of vraja-prema, who, like a swan, would have separated milk from water, who, giving up everything, would have worshipped Vrindavana, who would have known Mathura and Vrindavana, the customs of Vraja, the deeds of Radha-Madhava and that love? By the mercy of his feet all sing and make others sing. The second glorifies Rupa, the ocean of the great rasa: his darshana, touch and words are nectar; he is deep, steadfast and merciful, a treasury of prema-bhakti, who revealed the great gem of ujjvala-prema; he renounced Gauda, is adorned with virtues, gladdens the learned, lives in Vrindavana, and his fame is pure.

Departure and Memorial Places

Rupa left this world in Vraja, on the twelfth day of the bright fortnight of the month of Shravana; by our calendar this is the Gaura-dvadashi of the month of Shridhara, the morning after the Gaura-ekadashi that begins the Jhulana-yatra (on the years and the disagreement of sources see above, in the section “Years of His Life”).

Raghunatha Dasa poured out his separation from him in the “Prarthanashraya-chaturdashaka”:

“Sri Rupa, my life, ever sprinkled me with the fragrant foam of an unprecedented ocean of prema; and now, by ill fate, at every step I burn in the fire of calamities and am without support — with whom but him shall I seek shelter?”

“Without him the great pasture is empty, the king of hills is like a python, and the kunda like the jaws of a tiger.” (“Prarthanashraya-chaturdashaka”)

Rupa's samadhi temple stands in the courtyard of the Radha-Damodara temple in Vrindavana; there too he performed bhajana in the last years of his life. When Ramachandra Kaviraja came with Jiva to the Radha-Damodara temple and saw Rupa's samadhi, he was plunged into such ecstasy that he amazed everyone (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 9th taranga). Another memorial place of Rupa in Vraja is the place of his bhajana, Teri-kadamba (Ter-kadamba), near Nandagrama.

Rupa-manjari

In Krishna's eternal pastimes Rupa is Rupa-manjari. The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” says: “Sri Rupa-manjari, who was once famous in Vrindavana, has now appeared, having become Rupa Gosvami” (180). Lalita is first among the sakhis of Radharani's retinue, and Rupa-manjari is first among those who follow Lalita; therefore in Gaura-lila too Rupa is the head of the six Gosvamis.[70] Her closest friend is Rati-manjari, whom the wise also call Lavanga-manjari; according to the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (181–182), she is now Sanatana.

Rupa and Sanatana are eternal associates of Krishna in Vrindavana: they came to enrich Gauranga's pastimes and only played the role of sadhakas striving for perfection. Therefore the words in which the

brothers called themselves men of “low birth,” “consorting with the low” —

“We have disgraced our birth by low deeds and association with base people. We are unworthy even to stand before You.” (CC, Madhya 1.189)

— are the humility (dainya) of a Vaishnava, and to take them literally is an offence: Rupa and Sanatana are eternal associates of the Lord, above varnashrama, gurus even for paramahamsas. “Our Teachers” says still more: all the great souls who contributed to the succession of Mahaprabhu are not merely teachers and sages but eternal associates of Srimati Radharani, endowed with power, and all of them serve Her under the guidance of Sri Rupa-manjari, who appeared in this world as Sri Rupa Gosvami. So Narottama in his songs prays for service under Rupa-manjari, and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati considered the dust of Rupa's feet the one desire of his life (see above). Information about Rupa is also found in the articles on Madhavendra Puri, Nityananda, Gadadhara Pandita, Svarupa Damodara, Ramananda Raya, Bhugarbha, Gopala Guru, Sundarananda and Vishnupriya.

1. The verse follows our translation of the drama, as does the number; one biography gives the verse as 9.39 (incorrectly). Another biography renders the verse thus: “In Rupa — dear, beloved, whose very nature is prema, naturally beautiful, like Him, one with Him and the image of His vilasa — the Lord unfolded bhakti-rasa.” The first biography also takes the words “priya-svarupe” as “dear friend of Svarupa”: the Lord expounded the science of rasa to Rupa as to no one else, because Rupa was the dear friend of Svarupa Damodara, in essence the Lord's beloved, by nature prema itself, naturally beautiful; Mahaprabhu knew him to be like Himself, and he was His vilasa (manifestation).

2. Other testimonies differ. A manuscript from the library of Pandita Banamali Lala Gosvami at the Radha-ramana temple in Vrindavana (the Radha-ramana-ghera) puts both dates four years later: appearance in 1415 Shaka (1550 Samvat, 1493 CE), departure in 1490 Shaka (1625 Samvat, 1568 CE), on the same day, the dvadashi of the bright fortnight of Shravana; it does not otherwise distinguish the periods of his life at home, in Vraja and on earth as a whole. The year of appearance 1493 is also given by one biography (according to which Sanatana was born in 1488). According to Ashutosh Deb's Bengali dictionary, Rupa's years are 1489–1558 (1410–1479 Shaka).

3. According to one biography — “the month of Bhadra, the twelfth day of the bright fortnight, the day after Jhulana-ekadashi.” Jhulana-ekadashi falls in the lunar month of Shravana; the month there is evidently named by the Bengali solar calendar.

4. The years of rule (Sarvajna became king in 1381, Aniruddha in 1416) are given by only one biography; the “Anubhashya” places the family in the twelfth century of the Shaka era. The same biography calls Harihara skilled not in arms but in statecraft, and says that Rupeshvara went with his wife to Paurastya and befriended King Shekhareshvara. According to the “Anubhashya,” neither brother inherited his father's lands, and the elder, Rupeshvara, went to live in the hills.

5. According to another account, eight.

6. According to another account, also citing the “Laghu-vaishnava-toshani,” it was Mukunda himself who moved to Fatehabad near Jessore, in the pargana of Bakla-Chandradvipa. According to the “Anubhashya,” Kumara-deva's house stood in the village of Bakla in Chandradvipa, and “his home” was in Fatehabad in the district of Jessore.

7. One of the biographies states plainly that the name of Rupa's mother is unknown; the other biographies do not mention a daughter of Kumara-deva.

8. According to another biography, Vidyavachaspati was Sanatana's teacher.

9. In “Our Teachers” the earlier names are listed in a different order: “Santosh, Amar and Vallabha … became known as Sri Sanatana Gosvami, Sri Rupa Gosvami and Sri Anupama”; by this order Sanatana was called Santosh and Rupa Amar.

10. According to one biography, the Shah, hearing of the brothers from pious people, himself wished to give them posts, and they were obliged to accept out of fear of the yavana king.

11. Accounts of the posts differ. Rupa is also called a prominent minister — “perhaps the minister of finance,” as the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana” puts it — or a revenue officer and treasurer; Sanatana is called the chief, first minister or the Sultan's personal secretary.

12. Different distances are given: about four kroshas south of Malda; about eight miles south of English Bazar and five or six miles from Malda station; about five miles from the station, near the border.

13. According to one biography — affirmatively, without “according to tradition” and without “at midnight”: Mahaprabhu first met Rupa and Sanatana in Ramakeli under kadamba and tamala trees; the same account mentions the shrine and footprints. According to that description, the temple of Madana-mohana, whom Sanatana personally served, also houses Nitai-Gauranga and Advaita, and the ponds are named thus: Radha-kunda, Shyama-kunda, Surabhi-kunda, Lalita-kunda,

Vishakha-kunda and Sanatana-sagara.

14. According to another account (retelling CC, Madhya 1), after spending five years in Puri the Lord went to Bengal to see the Ganga and His mother, stayed several days with Advaita in Shantipura and from there went to Ramakeli. The same account does not describe separately Rupa's leaving royal service, Prayaga or Puri, and mentions the Lord's meeting with Rupa and Sanatana also in its retelling of Lochana Dasa's "Chaitanya-mangala" (Shesha-khanda, ch. 2) — right after the Lord's visit to Mathura.

15. He is also called Keshava Khatri and Keshava Kshatriya. According to one biography, he assured the king that the Lord had only three or four companions.

16. According to one biography, the brothers came in the evening to a tree on the bank of the Ganga where the Lord was resting with only His close associates.

17. According to one biography the advice was given by Sanatana, according to another by both brothers together; in the CC both speak (Madhya 1.221–224), and the Lord then ponders "Sanatana's words" (Madhya 1.228). The pictures at Kanai-natashala are mentioned by only one biography; one of them also refers here to the "Bhakti-ratnakara" (1.635).

18. According to the "Chaitanya-charitamrita," the Lord gave the brothers their names in Ramakeli (Madhya 1.208); Vrindavana Dasa tells the story in his own way, and it is his account that is given here. One biography attributes the words about the "third samskara" to Vrindavana Dasa himself; in the CB they stand not in the verse but in an explanatory subheading to it (in Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's edition).

19. Purashcharana, according to the "Hari-bhakti-vilasa" (17.11), is a rite of Deity worship, repetition of the mantra, libations, fire sacrifice and feeding of brahmanas in the morning, at midday and in the evening for a prescribed period. For the maha-mantra it is unnecessary: even a single utterance of the holy name brings all the fruits of purashcharana.

20. According to one biography, the wealth was taken on two boats to Bakla-Chandradvipa, half was given to Vaishnavas (or to Vaishnavas and brahmanas), and the ten thousand (gold) coins for Sanatana were deposited with a grocer in the capital, Gauda.

21. According to one biography, the letter reached Sanatana in Ramakeli; according to another, Rupa, on receiving the news, at once left Bakla.

22. According to one biography, the seven thousand rupees were brought to Sanatana by the grocer from the money Rupa had left (ten thousand had been left in all); according to another, following the CC, Sanatana bought his release with money "sent by Rupa." Compare the tradition of the Havaskhana ghat.

23. According to the chapter on Balabhadra Bhattacharya in one biography, in Prayaga, at Triveni (during the ten days of bathing in the month of Makara), Balabhadra invited Rupa and Vallabha (Anupama) and fed them the remnants of Mahaprabhu's meal. This agrees with the CC: in the house of the South Indian brahmana "the Bhattacharya" (evidently Balabhadra, the Lord's companion) invited the two brothers as well, and they received the remnants from Mahaprabhu's plate (Madhya 19.58–59); later Vallabha Bhatta gave them the remnants of the Lord's meal (Madhya 19.88–89).

24. In the CC: "This conversation about Krishna aroused in Mahaprabhu the bliss of maha-prema, but in the presence of the Bhattacharya He restrained His feelings" (Madhya 19.63); according to one biography, Vallabha marvelled at the Lord's ecstatic symptoms.

25. So also in the CC (Madhya 19.89); according to another biography — to Rupa and Anupama.

26. The division of Tirhut today comprises four districts — Saran, Champaran, Muzaffarpur and Darbhanga.

27. One biography gives these verses with a wrong number (Madhya 19.105–107). The same biography's references to CC Antya 1.73–86 (given as Madhya 13.66–72) and Antya 1.100 (given as 1.101) are inaccurate; its other references to the CC and CB in the story of Rupa are correct.

28. The verse numbers follow our translation of the drama. One biography gives this verse as 9.104, and the verse about Rupa free of attachment to home as 9.70 (by another numbering). The original has "in that same place" (tatraiva), that is, where, as the drama relates, the Lord instructed Rupa and Sanatana; another biography takes it as "in Vrindavana."

29. According to one biography — differently: of millions devoted to karma only one is a jnani, of millions of jnanis only one is liberated, and among millions of the liberated a devotee of Krishna is hard to find; many people follow the Vedas only in name, and of those who follow dharma many seek its fruits; the soul is there called an atomic spark of consciousness, and mobile beings are divided into those of land, air and water.

30. One biography introduces this verse with the words "Sri Krishna said to Uddhava," but in the "Bhagavatam" (3.29) it is Kapila's instruction to Devahuti.

31. One biography speaks here of "twelve rasas," that is, the five principal and seven secondary together.

32. According to one biography, Anupama passed away on the road, while the brothers were going along the Ganga to Bengal. According to one account, Mahaprabhu Himself told Sanatana in Puri of Rupa's coming, of Anupama's devotion to Rama and of his passing; according to another, Sanatana heard of his brother's passing from Haridasa Thakura.

33. According to one biography, all three were born into a high, respected brahmana caste; according to another, they were gurus even for the best of transcendental brahmanas.

34. One biography gives the verse as “Bhakti-ratnakara” 1.631, another as 1.630–631.

35. The Lord's verse “yah kaumara-harah” is included in the “Padyavali” (386 in the Russian translation of the CC used here, 382 in another numbering), and also in the “Sahitya-darpana” (1.2) and the “Kavya-prakasha” (1.4). Rupa's verse “priyah so ’yam” is “Padyavali” 387 in the same translation, 383 in the other numbering.

36. According to another account, Rupa did not go to bathe but came when the Lord was already in ecstasy and fell before Him like a rod; and the Lord, embracing him, gave him His blessing.

37. In another numbering — “Vidagdha-madhava” 1.33.

38. According to one biography, the Lord's displeasure was aroused by the verse of the “Vidagdha-madhava” (1.2): the Lord said that its praise was excessive, while the other devotees were overwhelmed with prema. In the CC, after this verse is read, the Lord only “did not praise it” and considered it too embellished (Antya 1.131), and He reproaches Rupa after the verse of the “Lalita-madhava.”

39. According to one biography, Kalidasa was once considered the greatest Sanskrit poet — until Rupa began to write his transcendental poetry, imbued with divine feelings.

40. The “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Antya 1) names among those who heard Rupa's dramas Sarvabhauma Bhattacharya, Ramananda Raya, Svarupa Damodara and Haridasa Thakura; according to the CC (Antya 1.207), Advaita Acharya and Nityananda also embraced Rupa. Bhagavan Acharya and Shikhi Mahiti are named only in “Our Teachers.” Mahaprabhu's request that all should bless Rupa is in the CC as well (Antya 1.199); the Vaishnavas' reply “Your mercy will be enough” and the words “You are My friends” are given only in “Our Teachers.” Only there, too, are the “test” of Rupa, Ramananda as “judge,” and the words “we acknowledge him as Your successor”: according to the CC, the Lord Himself brought Sarvabhauma, Ramananda and Svarupa to Rupa and praised Rupa in order to test Sarvabhauma and Ramananda themselves (Antya 1.103–106), and Ramananda questioned Rupa about the dramas (Antya 1.123 ff.); that they had never heard the glory of the name described like this is said in the CC by all the devotees (Antya 1.121–122).

41. According to one biography (citing the “Bhakti-ratnakara”), Rupa perfectly fulfilled everything except one thing: the service of the Deity had not yet been established, and Rupa was anxious about how to establish it. So too in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (2.404–406): having discovered the lost holy places, Rupa “pondered one thing” — that he could not find Sri Govinda (see below, “Sri Govinda-deva”).

42. Accounts differ as to where Sanatana was then. According to one biography, he was already in Vraja by that time; according to another, Sanatana came to Puri by the forest road through Jharikhanda, a year after Dola-yatra left by the same road for Vraja, and Rupa soon joined him, so that the brothers met again more than a year after parting; according to a third, having at last returned to Vrindavana, Sanatana met Rupa again, and both remained to carry out Mahaprabhu's commands.

43. The order in which they came to Vrindavana is told differently: according to one biography, Rupa and the others came there after Lokanatha; according to another, a few days after coming to Vrindavana Lokanatha met Rupa, Sanatana, Gopala Bhatta, Bhugarbha and others there.

44. One biography calls Gopinatha the Deity of Raghunatha Dasa; usually, however, the Gopinatha of Vrindavana is associated with Madhu Pandita. This is apparently a transfer to the Deity of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's scheme, in which Raghunatha Dasa is the acharya of prayojana (see below).

45. One biography gives the account as “Bhakti-ratnakara” 2.404–437. Both references are correct: Narahari's own account of Govinda is 2.404–421 and 433–437, the verses of the “Sadhana-dipika” are 2.422–432 (Govinda), 444–445 (Kashishvara) and 451–453 (Vrinda-devi). But that biography places the reference after the information about the hut and the temple built by a disciple of Raghunatha Bhatta, which is not in “Bhakti-ratnakara” 2.404–437 (it is CC, Antya 13.131; see below).

46. According to one biography, this Vrajavasi — a divine person in the form of a handsome resident of Vraja — did not lead Rupa to the hill but consoled him: “Do not worry: Govinda is on the hill of Goma-tila, the Yoga-pitha of Vrindavana; every morning a cow comes there and gladly gives Him milk,” and vanished.

47. According to another opinion, Rupa revealed Govinda-deva not from the Yoga-pitha near Goma-tila but from Sri Govinda-kunda.

48. One biography calls Vajranabha Krishna's grandson; in fact he is Krishna's great-grandson.

49. According to one biography, when Madana-mohana appeared to Sanatana and Sanatana began to serve Him with an abhisheka, Rupa, seeing the wonderful Deity, was filled with prema and informed Mahaprabhu in Puri of it through a messenger.

50. The Deity's route is told differently: according to one biography, Govinda went straight to Jaipur; according to another, first to Bharatpur, then to Jaipur; according to a third, a prince of Amber took Him to Galta near Amber, the chief seat of the Ramanandis, and Raja Jai Singh built a large temple there and installed in it “the Govinda-deva of Rupa, the guru of

Man Singh"; later a dispute arose between the Ramanandis and the Gaudiya priests, in which Baladeva Vidyabhushana took part. That it was Aurangzeb who destroyed the temple one biography puts in question; according to another, the upper storey of the seven-storeyed temple was destroyed.

51. One biography gives Purva 2.111.

52. One biography also refers here to the "Bhakti-ratnakara," 5.1333; but that verse concerns the meeting of Uddhava Dasa, Madhava and others with Srinivasa at Nandishvara, not Gopala in Mathura (Uddhava Dasa is named among Rupa's companions in CC, Madhya 18.51).

53. The biography supports this with couplets of the "Bhakti-ratnakara," but there (5.798–806) it is Raghava Pandita's account to Srinivasa while going round Gathuli; Rupa is not mentioned in them.

54. Where this took place is told differently: according to one account, at Rupa's place of bhajana, Teri-kadamba near Nandagrama; according to another, Sanatana was then living in a hut by Pavana-sarovara near Nandagrama. Ghee is mentioned in only one account.

55. Sanatana's answer is reported differently: according to one account, he forbade Rupa ever to cook sweet rice again, so that Radharani would not trouble Herself for his sake; according to another, he strictly forbade him to accept such gifts in future, since the relationship of service had been reversed; according to a third, with tears of prema he reproached himself for having accepted service from Her whom he longed to serve.

56. The number follows our translation of the drama; one biography gives 9.45.

57. According to one biography, the Lord replied by letter and sent Gopala Bhatta a dor, a kaupina and a bahirvasa; according to another, He sent with a messenger to Rupa a kaupina and the upper garments of a babaji, and Rupa accepted them with great joy.

58. So according to one biography. Another dates the appearance to "1599 of the Christian era," on a full-moon day; there too 1599 Samvat (1542 CE) is apparently meant, for in 1599 CE Rupa was no longer on earth. According to some accounts, Sri Radha-Govinda revealed Gopala Bhatta's cherished desire to Rupa in a dream, and it was Rupa who revealed the Deity of Radha-ramana; usually the appearance of Radha-ramana is associated with Gopala Bhatta himself.

59. So the "Bhakti-ratnakara" (5th taranga) tells of "Rupa's mercy to Jiva": on a hot summer day, when Rupa was writing the "Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu" and Jiva was fanning him, Vallabha Bhatta came. Having read the opening verses, he suggested correcting something. Jiva followed him to the Yamuna to fetch water, asked what error he had found and refuted each of his objections. Vallabha, returning to Rupa's hut, told how amazed he was at the young man's learning; Rupa gently reproached Jiva and told him to return to Bengal and come back to Vrindavana only when he had calmed down. But Jiva went not home but to the neighbouring village of Nanda-ghata, and there by severe austerities and fasting sought his guru's forgiveness, until his body grew quite weak. Sanatana, happening to come there, found him, took him to Rupa and begged his brother to forgive him; Rupa and Jiva were reconciled, and Jiva again received Rupa's affectionate blessing. Following the "Bhakti-ratnakara," one biography retells this incident precisely as "Rupa's mercy to Jiva."

60. The same biography says elsewhere that in Vraja Narottama met Rupa, Sanatana and Lokanatha — it contradicts itself: Rupa departed before Narottama came. And the chapter on Lokanatha in one biography says that even before His own coming to Vrindavana the Lord sent Rupa and Sanatana there; this contradicts the CC, where Rupa is sent to Vrindavana in Prayaga, after the Lord's visit to Vrindavana — evidently a careless retelling.

61. One biography says that Srinivasa, Narottama and Duhkhi Krishnadasa (Shyamananda), studying the Gosvamis' scriptures at Jiva's feet, "thus lived with Rupa Gosvami, who taught these dear disciples everything"; probably Rupa's teaching transmitted through Jiva is meant, or it is a slip.

62. In the Bengali paraphrase of this verse in one of the biographies the "Stavamala" stands in place of the "Utkalika-vallari"; Jiva's verse itself reads "stavasyotkalikavalli."

63. In one of the biographies this verse is called now "the verse before the penultimate," now verse 130; in a poem of 131 verses that is indeed the penultimate verse, which contains the words "rupashraya-pada."

64. Baladeva speaks of forty-one songs (gathas), while both printed editions of the "Stavamala" have forty-two.

65. The Lord's withdrawal is usually dated 1533 (1455 Shaka); 1589 Samvat falls in 1532–1533 CE, so the words "in the year of Mahaprabhu's departure" in the reasoning above should be taken as approximate.

66. The Bengali paraphrase of this verse in one of the biographies says "having displayed lofty heroism… took on the lalita-bhava"; the verse itself has "aprakatayan," "not displaying," so the paraphrase apparently contains a misprint.

67. The original has "a transformation (vivarta) of maya." What is meant is yogamaya, the Lord's internal potency that arranges His pastimes: neither Radha nor Krishna nor Their associates are subject to the external maya, and the gopis' "marriages" are only an appearance for those who have no part in the confidential pastime.

68. Without the rule of reading from right to left one would get 1417 Shaka (1495 CE), and Rupa, who appeared in 1489 or 1493, would then have been six or two years old. For a superhuman mahajana even this is not impossible — Kavi Karnapura composed a verse in the arya metre at the age of seven (CC, Antya 16) — but a request from Raghunatha Dasa,

who had not yet appeared, would be outwardly impossible. The word “svara” can also mean “three” (the three tones of Vedic recitation), but that would give 1431 Shaka (1509), when Raghunatha was three years old.

69. In the original: “chaitanya-birahe shesh, pai atishay klesh”: the verb “pai” (“I suffer”) is grammatically more likely first person, so these words may belong to the singer himself; the anguish, raving and lament can be ascribed to Rupa only from the course of the song.

70. One of the biographies, in its chapter on Ramananda Raya, calls Rupa-manjari a follower of Lalita and Vishakha, with whom Ramananda is non-different.